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RACQUETS IN
OVERDRIVEHickling.
P.17

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Edit A mismatch of words & actions **P.6**

Cinema Celeb voices for students **P.15**



HEALING TOUCH | PM calls paper leaks a 'ghor paap', urges MPs to reassure students

'GUIDE STUDENTS, DON'T INCITE THEM'

Gaurav Vivek Bhatnagar
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday urged NDA MPs to engage constructively with students and avoid provoking them over examination-related issues, while asserting that those responsible for examination paper leaks would face the strictest punishment.

Addressing the NDA Parliamentary Party meeting, titled Mangal Milan, at the Parliament House complex, Modi described paper leaks as a "ghor paap" (grave sin) and said the government was committed to ensuring accountability and preventing such incidents in future. Briefing reporters after the meeting, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju said the Prime Minister highlighted the Centre's swift response to the NEET-UG paper leak case, noting that 13 accused had been arrested and sent to jail.

"The Prime Minister said strong action has been taken to ensure that no one plays with the future of the youth," Rijiju said, adding that the government had prioritised conducting the NEET re-examination and declared the results without delay to safeguard students' academic future.

Rijiju said Modi stressed that those guilty of paper leaks should receive the strictest possible punishment and that the government would



use every legal avenue, with the support of the country's top lawyers, to ensure exemplary action against those involved. He also underlined the need to establish a foolproof system to prevent such incidents from recurring.

The Prime Minister urged all state governments and the Centre to work together, irrespective of political affiliation, to tackle the menace of paper leaks.

► **Continued on** | P8

OWE STUDENTS MORE THAN OUTRAGE: PRADHAN

Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan accused Rahul of using students as "political tools". He said on X, "This is not about students. This is about manufacturing confrontation after avenue for discussion has been opened." He said the Centre was ready for a discussion in Parliament and remained committed to reforms, accountability and addressing students' concerns.

Union ministers JP Nadda and Jitendra Singh on Tuesday met activist Sonam Wangchuk at Medanta Hospital in Gurugram, sources said.

Rahul, Priyanka detained amid protest near PM's residence

Agencies/ NEW DELHI Rahul Gandhi and Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra were detained by the Delhi Police on Tuesday while leading a protest near Prime Minister Narendra Modi's official residence at Lok Kalyan Marg, where Congress leaders were demanding accountability over the NEET-UG 2026 paper leak and seeking the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan. While being detained by the Delhi Police, Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra said "They are cowards. They are scared. We are not scared of them. They are scared of us." Meanwhile, Sonia Gandhi arrived at Police Station, where Priyanka Gandhi & leaders were held after being detained.



'RaGa went back on his word'

Giving details of the conversation between him and Rahul Gandhi at Congress' protest outside Prime Minister's house, Union Minister Jitendra Singh alleged the LoP went back on his word and added another demand when the Centre agreed to the first one.

SONAM SHIFTED TO MEDANTA HOSPITAL, HUNGER STRIKE TO CONTINUE

Educator, innovator and climate activist Sonam Wangchuk, who is on an hunger strike for the last 24 days, was on Tuesday evening shifted to Medanta from Safdarjung Hospital, in compliance with an order by the Delhi High Court. Meanwhile, Wangchuk has decided to continue his agitation till the Parliament takes cognisance of the Delhi Police's "brutal action" on protestors during their 'Sansad Chalo' march, wife Gitanjali J. Angmo said on Tuesday.

SC suggests Sonam Raghuvanshi surrender

HONEYMOON MURDER

IANS
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Tuesday suggested that Sonam Raghuvanshi, the prime accused in the Raja Raghuvanshi honeymoon murder case, consider surrendering and face trial pending the examination of key prosecution witnesses, while indicating that the apex court could otherwise proceed



► **Continued on** | P8

Corporator booked, but not a penny paid by govt for victims' treatment

Our Staff Reporter
INDORE

The Indore Bench of the Madhya Pradesh High Court on Tuesday reviewed the investigation into the gas pipeline blast caused by illegal boring activity and directed the State to ensure uninterrupted, free treatment for all victims, including critically injured social media influencer Jini Jhala, who is undergoing treatment at Zydus Hospital in Ahmedabad.

Hearing a public interest petition filed by Ritesh Inani, a division bench comprising Justice Subodh Abhyankar

INDORE GAS PIPELINE BLAST

and Justice Alok Awasthi was informed by ACP Parag Saini that the police have named five accused, including local corporator Balmukund Soni. The officer said Jhala's statement is yet to be recorded and that her discharge summary will be required before the chargesheet is filed.

The investigating agency also informed the court that it is awaiting the Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) from the Indore Municipal Corporation.

► **Continued on** | P8

627% DA: LOKAYUKTA RAIDS WEST DISCOM SUPDT ENGINEER

Rs 14.54-crore assets unearthed

Our Staff Reporter
INDORE/ MORENA

The Lokayukta, Special Police Establishment (SPE), Indore unit, on Tuesday conducted simultaneous raids at nine locations linked to Shivram Semel, Superintending Engineer (Transmission and Finance) at West Discom's Pologround office in Indore.

50% tariffs



SS Electricals transformer unit in Ujjaini, Dhar

Following a detailed valuation of seized assets and financial records, the Lokayukta said Semel possessed disproportionate assets worth Rs 14.54,15,754, allegedly 627% higher than



Superintending Engineer Shivram Semel

his known legitimate income. The raids came just eight days after he was promoted to the post of Superintending Engineer.

► **Continued on** | P8

Assembly passes UCC BILL amid Opposition ruckus

Jo Hindu hit (interest) ki baat karega, wahi desh par raj karega, declares CM

Our Staff Reporter
BHOPAL

The Madhya Pradesh Assembly on Tuesday passed the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) Bill, 2026 amid repeated disruptions and protests by Congress MLAs, who demanded that the Bill be referred to a select committee and argued that implementing 27% reservation for Other Backward Classes (OBCs) was a greater priority. Speaker Narendra Singh Tomar adjourned the House twice as members from the Treasury and Opposition benches exchanged slogans.

Participating in the debate, Chief Minister Mohan Yadav raised slogans of "Jo Hindu hit ki baat karega, wahi desh par raj karega" and "Jai Shri Ram". Defending the Bill, he said it would ensure equal rights for women and bring uniformity in civil laws without interfering with religious practices.

Yadav said the law would prohibit polygamy and that anyone entering into more than one marriage would face imprisonment. "Only those who marry once will live on the soil of Madhya Pradesh," he said. He added that a per-



Chief Minister Mohan Yadav visits Vidhan Sabha

son deceiving a wife through a live-in relationship could face up to five years' imprisonment. Divorce outside the court would not be recognised, while live-in relationships would be regulated. The Bill also provides equal property rights for men and women, while allowing marriages to be performed according to individual customs, he said.

The Chief Minister accused the Congress of practising vote-bank and appeasement politics by opposing the Bill. He claimed the legislation was aimed at empowering women and said even Muslim men and women had supported it. "This sin will sink the Congress," he said.

► **Continued on** | P8

After 12-day lull, monsoon returns to drench Bhopal, other districts

Met forecasts widespread rain across the state till July 25

Our Staff Reporter
BHOPAL

After a 12-day dry spell, monsoon rains returned to Bhopal and several parts of Madhya Pradesh on Tuesday, bringing widespread showers across the state. The last significant rainfall in Bhopal was recorded on July 9.

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) has forecast widespread rainfall across Madhya Pradesh over the next five days, till July 25. According to



the IMD, the revival of the monsoon is due to the southward shift of the monsoon trough from the Himalayan foothills and the formation of low-pressure systems over central India. These weather systems are drawing moisture-laden winds from the Arabian Sea and the Bay of Bengal into the state.

During the past 24 hours, rainfall was recorded at most places in Gwalior, Chambal,

Rewa, Jabalpur, Shahdol and Sagar divisions, at many places in Bhopal and Narmadapuram divisions, and at a few places in Indore and Ujjain divisions. Majholi recorded the highest rainfall at 124.4 mm, followed by Sihawal (118.6 mm), Gairatganj (118 mm), Mauganj (109 mm), Udaipura (109 mm), Birsinghpur (105 mm) and Rajgarh (103 mm).

The IMD has issued a heavy rain alert for Rajgarh, Betul, Shivpuri, Bhind, Morena, Katni, Mandla, Damoh and Chhatarpur districts over the next 24 hours. Thunderstorms accompanied by lightning and gusty winds of 30-40 kmph are also likely in Bhopal and several other districts across the state.

20 DEAD in Sikkim tunnel collapse



Rescue operations underway after multiple people were trapped inside an under-construction tunnel in Namchi district, Sikkim

PTI
GANGTOK

At least 20 workers were killed and five others remained trapped for over 24 hours after a tunnel under construction collapsed in Sikkim's Namchi district following an explosion of suspected methane gas, a police officer said on Tuesday.

Chief Minister Prem Singh Tamang announced Rs 4 lakh as ex-gratia for the next of kin of each of those

workers who died in the collapse of the NHPC tunnel and Rs 50,000 for every injured person.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi spoke to the chief minister and took stock of the situation, besides assuring him of all help from the central government.

The PM also announced an ex-gratia of Rs 2 lakh to the next of kin of the deceased and Rs 50,000 each to the injured persons.

► **Continued on** | P8

QUIZ-08
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A. Paris, France B. New Delhi, India
C. Vienna, Austria D. Zurich, Switzerland
- The Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) was established on:
A. 17 March 1986 B. 14 Nov 1975
C. 12 Dec 1981 D. 4 May 1988
- Which Government of India initiative brings together renowned spiritual and social organizations to create widespread awareness against drug abuse?
A. SPANDAN B. NIDAN
C. MANAS D. NCORD
- The total number of Central Forensic Science Laboratories (CFSLS) in India is:
A. 7 B. 4 C. 5 D. 2
- Which of the following issues licences to farmers for the cultivation of opium poppy?
A. NCB (Narcotics Control Bureau)
B. CBN (Central Bureau of Narcotics)
C. Ministry of Agriculture
D. State Police

Scan the QR code to participate in the quiz.

Quiz-07: Winners
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WASHINGTON

US President Donald Trump on Monday imposed 50% tariffs on most Canadian goods, declaring that Canada had unfairly discriminated against American automobiles, alcohol and dairy products. Trump is poised to impose fresh tariffs on

dozens of countries, including India, as soon as this week, the Financial Times reported on Tuesday, with his temporary 10% global tariff scheduled to expire on Friday.

The Financial Times said the most immediate new duties are expected to be on a par with the 10% tariffs currently in place. However, the administration is also working

on other investigations that could provide the legal authority to impose higher duties.

US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer, in an interview with The New York Times, said the US tariff policy had been "wildly successful" and that the Trump administration was planning new measures to replace those struck down by the Su-

preme Court.

Greer said the administration had changed 70 years of US trade policy within the past year and that the new measures had reduced the trade deficit while encouraging businesses to reshore manufacturing. "They are. Yeah. I think we've been wildly successful," Greer said when asked whether the tariff

regime was delivering results.

According to The New York Times, the Trump administration is working to recreate the tariffs struck down by the Supreme Court through levies targeting countries that rely on forced labour in manufacturing and those with surplus production.

► **Continued on** | P8

City Digest

Khandelwal Youth Club celebrates family bonding



Khandelwal Youth Club organised a family get-together featuring a parents' felicitation ceremony, musical tambola and cultural performances. Club secretary CA Praveen Gupta said the event was organised to strengthen family values and promote bonding among members. Pushpendra Ameria, Shailen Vaidya, Ashish Gupta, Dinesh Odh, Ajay Patodiya, Atul and Deepak Bhukhmara, and Manoj, Nitin and Rakesh Badgoti were among those present. The event was coordinated by Vishal and Vineeta, Kamlesh and Savita, Dinesh and Nidhi, and Anand and Adwita.

MLB Girls' College holds anti-drug essay competition



Government Maharani Laxmibai Postgraduate Girls' College organised an essay competition under the Nashe Se Doori Hai Zaroori 2.0 campaign. DSP Asha Seikar, Inspector Shehnaz Bano and Sub-Inspector Ashish Sharma addressed students on the harmful effects of drug abuse and the importance of staying away from narcotics. Shikha Lodhi, Durga Sharma and Ananya Bhaduria secured the first three positions and were awarded medals and certificates.

Poetry meet celebrates rain, nature



Manpasand Kala Sahitya Manch organised its monthly poetry session on the theme "Shower, O Clouds" amid the delayed monsoon. Poets recited verses celebrating rain and highlighting the need for environmental conservation. The programme also featured devotional songs, while saplings were distributed to promote tree plantation and ecological awareness.

Naresh Saxena's poetry celebrated at Kavita Kona



A poster featuring poems by senior poet Naresh Saxena was unveiled at Sutradhar's Kavita Kona at the Indore Press Club by noted litterateur Jyoti Jain. Literature enthusiasts, including Hareram Bajpai and Anand Pachauri, recited poems by Saxena as well as their own compositions.

IMC issues notices to 5 consultants, seeks reports from 12 others

Our Staff Reporter

INDORE

Indore Municipal Corporation (IMC) has intensified its fire safety enforcement drive, issuing notices to five fire consultants and vendors over

IMC had directed fire consultants and vendors to submit geo-tagged photographs and details of installed fire protection systems, completed works and pending installations

deficiencies in fire audit reports, while seeking compliance reports from 12 other consultants within three days.

The IMC said inspections are being conducted in commercial, industrial, educational and residential buildings, malls, hotels and other public-use premises to verify fire safety arrangements. The objective, officials said, is not merely to enforce

FIRE SAFETY ISSUE

regulations but to ensure effective fire prevention systems are in place to minimise the risk of fire incidents and enable prompt control during emergencies.

According to the civic body, several buildings that had earlier been sealed for violating fire safety norms were allowed to reopen conditionally based on fire audit reports submitted by consultants, proposed safety upgrades and undertakings furnished by building owners.

To review the progress of the promised fire safety works, the IMC had directed fire consultants and vendors to submit geo-tagged photographs and details of installed fire protection systems, completed works and pending installations.

During the review, officials

RAID AT WEST DISCOM SE's PROPERTIES | Lokayukta DSP Sunil Talan said the agency was probing the allotment process

Rs 2.5 crore plot deal inked hours before raid

Our Staff Reporter

INDORE

Among the most significant recoveries, Lokayukta sleuths seized property agreement papers dated July 20, showing that Semel had finalised an agreement to purchase a plot worth Rs 2.5 crore in the name of his son, Shubham, a day before the raid. An advance payment of Rs 1 lakh had also been made.

Lokayukta officials highlighted a potential conflict of interest, noting that Semel's family members repeatedly secured lucrative contracts for transformer manufacturing and repairs from the state power distribution company.

Lokayukta DSP Sunil Talan said the agency was probing the allotment process to establish whether norms were flouted or if internal collusion took place.

Detailed inventory and seizure breakdown

The official inventory valuation report compiled during the operation outlines an extensive footprint of residential properties, transformer manufacturing plants, high-value vehicles and bank deposits.

Industrial units and transformer factories

■ **Shubham Electricals (Pithampur, Dhar):** Factory shed, plant machinery, plot valuation and bank deposits totalling Rs 4,17,43,276 at Plot 479, Sector 03, Bagdoon.

■ **SS Electricals (Ujjaini, Dhar):** Transformer unit at Industrial Growth Centre (Plots 184-185), featuring shed construction, inventory and 106



transformers valued at Rs 2,06,07,972.

■ **Transformer Repairing Unit (Gram Ujjaini, Dhar):** Facility at Plot 169 equipped with coil stocks, oil and transformer repair machinery used for repairing faulty MPEB transformers, valued at Rs 1,48,95,240.

■ **Karnish Power Zone (Pithampur, Dhar):** Plot 749-A (Sector 03) with factory construction and inventory worth Rs 1,06,72,595, along with Plot 732 (Sector 03) containing inventory and an Eicher commercial vehicle (MP 09 GS 2567) valued at Rs 71,03,002.

■ **Krishna Power Firm (Ujjaini, Dhar):** Under-construction factory site valued at Rs 10 lakh.



ornaments and cash seized from the premises. Older furniture and appliances at Saptashrungi Colony were valued at Rs 1,69,000.

■ **Vehicles:** A Mahindra electric vehicle and a Kia Seltos purchased for Rs 31,50,000.

■ **Bank deposits and lockers:** Bank accounts in the name of the officer's wife holding Rs 41 lakh at SBI Silicon City, along with an SBI locker in the names of Sunita Semel and Saurabh Semel containing gold jewellery valued at Rs 22,36,669. **Lokayukta's second raid this year**

This marks the second major operation by the Lokayukta this year.

■ **JUNE 9:** Lokayukta raided premises linked to Laxmi Narayan Kandwal, joint director of the Women and Child Development Department, and unearthed assets worth more than Rs 10 crore.

■ **Earlier** on Saturday, the Lokayukta caught a junior engineer of West Discom allegedly accepting a bribe of Rs 40,000 after allegedly demanding Rs 80,000 to clear and forward a file related to the installation of a solar panel system at a commercial property.

■ **Moveables, gold, cash and bank deposits**

■ **Household items and electronics:** Household belongings at C-44 Silicon City valued at Rs 69,50,000, along with Rs 57,88,000 in gold, silver

STARING ROW: Five held for stabbing youth

Our Staff Reporter

INDORE

Police arrested five men for allegedly stabbing a 25-year-old man multiple times outside a wine shop near Arbitto Mall under the Vijay Nagar police station limits late on Sunday night.

The victim, Prakash Khichi, a resident of Bhagirathpura, was allegedly attacked after he accidentally brushed past a group of men, leading to an argument.

According to the police, the argument soon escalated, with the accused—identified as Kunal, Himesh, Deepak and two others—allegedly abusing and assaulting Khichi. During the scuffle, Kunal allegedly pulled out a knife and stabbed him three to four times in the abdomen.

Police have registered a case of attempt to murder against the accused and arrested all five.

DAVV files cyber complaint over fake social media accounts

Registrar says some mischievous persons using the university's name and logo on social media

Our Staff Reporter

INDORE

Devi Ahilya Vishwavidyalaya (DAVV) has lodged a complaint with the cyber cell after discovering multiple fake social media accounts using the university's name and official logo to circulate misleading information, particularly regarding admissions and examinations.

University officials said three to four unauthorised accounts have been identified on platforms such as Instagram, Facebook and X. Some of the accounts, including davvinore64, davv, davv indore and davv64, are allegedly using the university's name and logo without authorisation.

According to the complaint, these accounts have been posting misleading and inaccurate information, creating confusion among students, par-

ents and the general public. Many users are reportedly mistaking these profiles for DAVV's official social media handles and treating the information shared on them as authentic.

The university has urged the cyber cell to take action against those operating the fake accounts, stating that the unauthorised use of its name, identity and logo is damaging the institution's reputation and credibility.

Registrar Dr Prajwal Khare said DAVV has only one official Instagram account and that all other accounts using the university's name and logo without permission are unauthorised. He said the cyber cell has been requested to investigate the fake accounts and initiate appropriate action against those responsible.

The university authorities have also appealed to students and the public to rely only on DAVV's verified official social media platforms and website for information related to admissions, examinations and other academic matters.

MUNDLANAYATA VILLAGE ENCROACHMENTS CLEARED

Our Staff Reporter

INDORE

Acting on the directions of Collector Shivam Verma, the district administration on Tuesday removed encroachments from government land and a drain in Mundlanayata village under Juni tehsil.

A joint team of the Revenue Department, Indore Municipal Corporation and police

demolished tin sheds, boundary walls and other illegal structures built on 0.560 hectares of government land (Survey No. 28), clearing both the land and the drain of encroachments.

Officials said the drive against illegal encroachments on government land and public property will continue, with strict action to be taken against violators as per the rules.

90-year-old dilapidated house of doctor demolished



Our Staff Reporter

INDORE

Indore Municipal Corporation (IMC) on Tuesday demolished an around 90-year-old dilapidated house belonging to a doctor in Juni Kasera Bakhla as part of its ongoing drive against

Our Staff Reporter

INDORE

Students of the School of Education at Devi Ahilya Vishwavidyalaya (DAVV) approached the district collector Shivam Verma during the Jansunwai on Tuesday, alleging that an assistant professor had not conducted classes for the Educational Administration paper for nearly a year, affecting two consecutive semesters.

According to the students, the subject was divided among three faculty members, with each assigned specific units. However, they alleged that one of the teachers did not teach her allotted portion despite repeated requests, leaving the syllabus incomplete and causing academic stress and uncertainty.

The students further alleged that the second-semester results were declared without awarding marks for

the paper, with asterisks appearing in place of scores. They said the issue remains unresolved even as the third semester has begun, and classes for the same subject have yet to start.

After failing to get a resolution from the university administration, the students submitted a written complaint to the district collector, seeking immediate intervention.

The students alleged that the prolonged delay has affected their academic progress. Seven students have received ATKT due to the pending paper, while some NET-qualified students fear the issue could adversely affect their future opportunities.

Meanwhile, School of Education head Laxman Shinde said that a show-cause notice has been issued to the concerned teacher. As it could not be served in person, the notice is now being sent to her through the prescribed official process.

1,500 from Indore to appear in CBSE supplementary exam

Our Staff Reporter

INDORE

Around 16,500 Class 12 students from Madhya Pradesh, including nearly 1,500 from Indore, are expected to appear in the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) Supplementary Examination 2026 after the board released admit cards for the examination on Tuesday, July 21, 2026.

The supplementary examination, scheduled for July 28, 2026, will provide eligible students another opportunity to clear subjects and continue their higher education

plans without losing an academic year.

The release of admit cards has brought the examination process into its final phase, with students now able to check important details such as roll number, subjects, examination centre and instructions for the examination day. The examination is significant for the CBSE Bhopal Region, which covers Madhya Pradesh and has a large network of affiliated schools. In the 2026 Class 12 board examination, 80,454 students appeared from the Bhopal Region, which recorded a 79.43% pass percentage.

Our Staff Reporter

INDORE

unsafe structures. A pccain machine was used to raze the building, sending clouds of dust into the air as the demolition began.

According to civic officials, the house had become severely dilapidated and posed a serious risk of collapse during the monsoon.

Lady SI accused of seeking bribe; family alleges false dowry case drove man to suicide

Family seeks probe, SI denies allegations

Our Staff Reporter

INDORE

A major controversy has surfaced after the family of a deceased man accused a woman sub-inspector of demanding a bribe and filing a false dowry harassment case. The family has submitted a written complaint to commissioner of police Santosh Kumar Singh, seeking an impartial investigation into the matter.

Complainant Kamlesh Rathore alleged that his younger brother, Rajeev Rathore, married Shivani Rathore on Dec 1. According to the complaint, disputes began soon after the marriage. The family has accused Shivani Rathore, her

father Uttam Rathore, mother Rita Rathore and brother Gautam Rathore of demanding Rs 50 lakh and the transfer of family property in their favour. They alleged that when these demands were not met, they threatened to implicate the family in a false dowry harassment case and defame them publicly.

The complaint further alleges that, during the counselling process, investigating officer Sub-Inspector Khushboo Parmar demanded Rs 20,000 in exchange for giving them time and helping in the case. The family claims that after refusing to pay the alleged bribe, a false dowry harassment FIR was registered against them.

Kamlesh Rathore stated that Rajeev Rathore suffered

severe mental trauma because of the criminal case, repeated threats and social stigma. According to the complaint, Rajeev allegedly consumed poison on July 6, 2026, and died while being taken to hospital. The family has urged the commissioner of police to order a fair inquiry into the role of Sub-Inspector Khushboo Parmar and to initiate departmental as well as legal action if any wrongdoing is found.

Sub-Inspector Khushboo Parmar denied the allegations. She said the police acted strictly in accordance with legal procedures and that the case was registered based on the complainant's statements and available facts. She described the allegations against her as false and baseless.

FP popcorn

Raktanchal 3 cast interacts with students in city

Our Staff Reporter

INDORE

The cast and director of the upcoming web series Raktanchal 3 interacted with students during a promotional event in the city on Tuesday.

Lead actors Kranti Prakash Jha and Nikitin Dheer, along with director Ritam Srivastava, shared their experiences in the entertain-



ment industry and spoke about acting, filmmaking and the challenges of working on web series.

During the interactive session, students asked questions about the actors' careers, preparation for roles and behind-the-scenes experiences from the series. The guests encouraged aspiring artistes to stay dedicated and continuously hone their skills. They also

urged audiences aged 18 years and above to watch Raktanchal 3.

The event concluded with an interactive session and a photo opportunity, allowing students to meet the cast. Faculty members, staff and a large number of students attended the programme, which aimed to give young audiences an insight into the world of acting and digital entertainment.

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Police warn NEET protesters, alert coaching institutes

Security personnel and traffic police have been deployed at the intersection to maintain law and order. Officials said adequate arrangements are in place to deal with any situation.

HC HEARS PLEA OVER 241-MARK NEET DISCREPANCY

A petition alleging a 241-mark discrepancy in the NEET-UG 2026 result has reached the Indore Bench of the Madhya Pradesh High Court, with the petitioner also challenging the legal status and constitutional

NEET-UG

Jhabua student alleges his score was reduced from 305 to 64 despite matching OMR sheet and answer key; also challenges the National Testing Agency's legal authority to conduct entrance examinations

Lokendra Singh Khadiya, a student from Jhabua district, has filed a writ petition through advocate Abhinav P. Dhanodkar, alleging serious inconsistencies between his official OMR sheet, the official answer key and the final result declared by the NTA. According to the petition, the OMR sheet and answer key show that he secured 305 marks, but the final result awarded him only 64 marks a discrepancy of 241 marks that has allegedly jeopardised his chances of securing admission to medical courses.

The petition states that after passing Class XII in 2024, Khadiya spent nearly two years preparing

Based on the second OMR sheet and the official answer key, the petitioner claims he scored 104 marks in Physics, 125 in Chemistry and 76 in Biology, taking his total to 305 marks. Despite emailing the NTA immediately after the results were declared on July 16, he alleges that no corrective action was taken, affecting his participation in counselling for MBBS, BDS, BAMS, BHMS, BUMS, BVSc and BSc Nursing courses.

The petition seeks verification of the OMR sheet, evaluation process and mark calculation, clarifying that it seeks correction of an apparent discrepancy rather than re-evaluation. It further contends that the NTA, being a society registered under the Societies Registration Act, 1860 and not a statutory body, lacks the legal authority to conduct national entrance examinations.

Hearing the matter, a Division Bench comprising Justice Subodh Abhyankar and Justice Alok Awasthi directed the respondents to obtain instructions regarding the petitioner's OMR sheet and listed the matter for hearing next week.

DAVV to hold special MBA third semester examinations from Aug 6

Devi Ahilya Vishwavidyalaya (DAVV) has decided to conduct special examinations for MBA third semester students who were unable to appear in their regular examinations due to participation in sports competitions or campus placement activities. The special examinations will be held from Aug 6 to Sept 9, and admit cards will be issued from next week.

The decision was taken after affected students approached vice-chancellor Dr Rakesh Singhai, stating that although they had successfully cleared the first, second and fourth semester examinations, they could

Special examinations for students who missed papers due to sports or placements

As a result of their absence, the students were marked with ATKT (Allowed to Keep Terms) in the third semester, affecting their academic progress.

University officials said that while third semester examinations are normally conducted in December-January, the examination rules provide for special examinations under exceptional circumstances. Considering the students' academic interests, the university has decided to invoke this provision.

The special examination will cover MBA Marketing Management, Financial Administration, Human Resource (HR), and full-time MBA programmes. Around 1,500 to 2,000 students are expected to appear for the examination.

Examination controller Prof Ashesh Tiwari said several students had missed the regular examinations because of their participation in sports activities. Keeping the students' interests in mind, the university decided to organise a special examination to ensure that their academic careers are not adversely affected.

नागरिक सुरक्षा की दिशा में एक बड़ा कदम

मध्यप्रदेश अग्निशमन एवं आपातकालीन सेवाएं विधेयक, 2026

सुदृढ़ एवं जवाबदेह अग्निशमन व्यवस्था

अग्निशमन एवं आपात सेवाओं के नियंत्रण हेतु जवाबदेह प्रशासनिक तंत्र

अग्नि सुरक्षा प्रमाणन अनिवार्य

निर्धारित भवनों परिसरों के लिए फायर सेफ्टी सर्टिफिकेट अनिवार्य

एकीकृत कमांड एवं नियंत्रण केंद्र

अग्नि दुर्घटना पर त्वरित प्रतिक्रिया के लिए ICCC केंद्र की स्थापना

कड़े दंडात्मक प्रावधान

कानून का उल्लंघन, झूठी सूचना, सुरक्षा उपकरणों से छेड़छाड़, कार्य में बाधा दंडनीय अपराध

क्षमता निर्माण एवं जन-जागरूकता

अग्निशमन सेवा आवश्यक सेवा घोषित प्रशिक्षण, जनभागीदारी से आपदा प्रबंधन

निरीक्षण एवं ऑडिट

अधिकृत एजेंसियों द्वारा प्रमाणन निर्धारित भवनों में प्रशिक्षित सुपरवाइजर की नियुक्ति अनिवार्य

एकीकृत डिजिटल फायर पोर्टल

फायर प्लान, प्रमाण-पत्र एवं ऑडिट सहित सभी प्रमुख सेवाएं ऑनलाइन उपलब्ध

फायर अकादमी

भोपाल जिले में होगी फायर अकादमी की स्थापना

त्वरित संसाधन उपलब्धता

आपात स्थिति में निःशुल्क जल स्रोतों, उपकरणों की तत्काल उपलब्धता की स्थानीय निकाय और जिला प्रशासन की जिम्मेदारी होगी

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36 नये फायर स्टेशन

इंदौर, उज्जैन, गुरेना, सागर, रतलाम, रीवा, छिंदवाड़ा, खंडवा, शिवपुरी, छतरपुर, मंदसौर, नीमच, दमोह, सीहोर, बैतुल, सिवनी, दतिया, धार, टीकमगढ़, हरदा, मैहर, नरसिंहपुर, सीधी, पन्ना, पांडुरंगा, रायसेन, आगर, झाबुआ, आलीराजपुर, अनूपपुर, मऊगंज, निवाड़ी, बुरहानपुर, बानमौर, मंडीदीप एवं मेधनगर

“हर नागरिक का जीवन अमूल्य है। यह विधेयक आधुनिक अग्नि सुरक्षा, त्वरित आपातकालीन सहायता और प्रभावी बचाव व्यवस्था के माध्यम से प्रदेश में सुरक्षा का नया मानक स्थापित करेगा।”

— डॉ. मोहन यादव, मुख्यमंत्री

म.प्र. माध्यम / 127083/2026

SIMHASTHA INFRA PROJECTS

FP News Service

UJJAIN

The Simhastha Fair Authority has appointed Certification Engineers International Ltd (CEIL) as the third-party quality audit (TPQA) agency for infrastructure projects being undertaken for Simhastha-2028. CEIL is a Government

of India enterprise and a wholly owned subsidiary of Engineers India Limited (EIL). The TPQA mechanism will independently assess the quality of permanent and temporary infrastructure works being executed by various departments and agencies for the mega religious event. The audit will

cover construction quality, materials, workmanship, adherence to approved specifications, periodic inspections, monitoring of corrective measures and submission of audit reports to facilitate timely decision-making. The audit will cover infrastructure projects valued at more than Rs 18,400 crore,

including roads, bridges, ghats, public amenities, water supply, sewerage, power infrastructure, accommodation facilities and temporary infrastructure required for Simhastha-2028. The quality audit will follow a risk-based methodology involving periodic inspections, quality verification and compliance

monitoring to ensure all projects meet prescribed standards and are completed on schedule. Divisional commissioner and Simhastha Fair officer Asheesh Singh said Simhastha is among the world's largest religious gatherings and requires large-scale infrastructure to be completed within strict

timelines. He said engaging an independent central public sector undertaking for third-party quality audits would strengthen quality assurance, enhance transparency and accountability, and help executing agencies identify and rectify deficiencies at an early stage. Singh said CEIL has ex-

tensive experience in quality audits and technical inspections of major infrastructure projects across the country and had previously carried out the third-party audit of the Shri Mahakal Lok Project in Ujjain. He said the agency was selected because of its proven expertise and technical capabilities.

He reiterated the State government's commitment to providing safe, durable and high-quality infrastructure for the millions of devotees expected during Simhastha-2028. He also directed heads of all executing departments to maintain updated project-wise progress records to facilitate the audit process.

HOUSE CLEARS | Compensation, sanitation, loan and swimming facility proposals after debate

UMC COUNCIL CLEARS KEY SIMHASTHA PROPOSALS

FP News Service

UJJAIN

A special meeting of the Ujjain Municipal Corporation (UMC) Council was held on Tuesday under the chairmanship of Corporation Speaker Kalavati Yadav in the presence of Mayor Mukesh Tatwal and Municipal Commissioner Abhilash Mishra.

During the meeting, the Council deliberated on the agenda and unanimously approved proposals to demolish dilapidated public toilets across the city and construct new facilities under SBM 2.0. Approval was also granted for the reconstruction of the Sulabh toilet at Khadthiya in Ward 24, the urinal near Lal Masjid, and the removal of the urinal outside Gandhi Bal Udyan at Ksheersagar.

Keeping Simhastha-2028 in view, the Council unanimously approved a series of compensation proposals for property owners voluntarily surrendering buildings and commercial establishments affected by ongoing road-widening projects. These include widening works from Gadapulia to Lal Pul via Jaysinghpura (Bhagat Singh



Marg); VD Market to Chhoti Puliya via Teliwada and Dhaba Road; Gaadi Adda Chauraha to Bada Pul covering Lala Lajpat Rai Marg, Vallabhbbhai Patel Marg and Veer Durgadas Marg; Harifatak Road to Mahakal Parking via Maharajwada School No. 2; GAIL India Chauraha to Neelganga and Shanti Nagar to Manchhama Chauraha; Sanwer Road from Muni Nagar to Sarthak Nagar on Indore Road; Hamukheddi Bijasan Mata Temple to Dewas Road; and compensation for residents of the 12 Quarters affected by the four-lane expansion of the Harifatak Railway Overbridge under the Madhya Pradesh Road Development Corporation's Simhastha-2028 project.

The Council also approved the proposal to name the Municipal Corporation's under-construction shopping complex at Alakhddham

and directed that the supplementary proposal be placed before the House through the Mayor-in-Council.

While considering the proposal to transfer the Ujjain Swimming Complex to the Department of Sports and Youth Welfare for establishing a swimming academy, the Council approved it on the recommendation of the Mayor-in-Council, subject to obtaining State government approval, if required. The House also unanimously approved the proposal for the regular operation of the swimming pool at Dewas Road in Ward 52.

In another significant decision, the Council cancelled the previously approved project with GAIL India Limited for setting up a CBG plant under the PPP model and approved inviting fresh tenders.

Opposition storms proceedings

The UMC Council meeting witnessed heated exchanges on civic issues and the functioning of the BJP board, with Opposition Congress members strongly opposing several proposals. Following intense debate, the Council approved compensation for leaseholders affected by ongoing road-widening projects. During the discussion, the Opposition objected to the ruling side's initial resistance to compensating leaseholders. Leader of Opposition Ravi Rai argued that the government itself had granted the land leases and that those losing their houses for public infrastructure projects should receive compensation on priority. The proposal was eventually approved after sustained pressure from Opposition members.

Congress workers lay siege to UMC headquarters

Angered by the city's crumbling roads, poor civic amenities, contaminated water supply and what it termed discriminatory action by the UMC, the City Congress Committee staged a protest outside the civic headquarters despite heavy rain. Led by president Mukesh Bhati, party leaders and workers marched on foot from Koyla Phatak Chauraha to the UMC headquarters, raising slogans throughout the procession. The demonstration concluded with the reading out and submission of a memorandum to the additional municipal commissioner. Addressing the gathering, Bhati alleged that the UMC was adopting a biased approach in its anti-encroachment and road-widening drives. He claimed that while ordinary residents were voluntarily demolishing portions of their homes, encroachments belonging to BJP leaders were being spared. According to him, the encroachment of BJP leader Roop Pammani on the Sati Gate-Kanthal to Chhatri Chowk road is the biggest obstacle to the widening project, yet the Corporation has failed to act.



Daily run of Indore-Ganganagar train approved

UJJAIN: Shri Kshetra Valmiki Dham Peethadheeshwar Bal-yogi Umeshnath and a Rajya Sabha member paid a courtesy visit to Union Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw and requested that the Indore (Laxmibai Nagar)-Shri Ganganagar Gogamedi train be operated daily.

During the meeting, Vaishnav directed officials to operate the train daily. The decision is expected to benefit lakhs of devotees from Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Rajasthan and Gujarat travelling to various religious destinations, including Bhadwa Mata in Neemuch, Shri Khatu Shyam, the Gogadev Gogamedi Fair and other places of pilgrimage.

Citizens urged to seek prompt treatment for snakebite

UJJAIN : With snake movement increasing during the monsoon season in agricultural fields, bushes, water-logged areas and residential localities, the Health Department has urged citizens not to panic in the event of a snakebite and to seek immediate treatment at the nearest government hospital. CMHO Dr Ashok Kumar Patel said all government health institutions in Ujjain district have adequate stocks of anti-snake venom (ASV) and other essential medicines for the treatment of snakebite cases. He said timely medical intervention

enables successful treatment in most cases.

The department has advised people to keep the victim calm and minimise movement after a snakebite. The bite area should be washed with clean water, covered with a clean cloth and the affected limb should be kept as still as possible. Rings, bangles, watches, belts and other tight accessories should be removed to accommodate swelling. If the victim becomes unconscious or is likely to vomit, they should be placed in the recovery position and taken to a hospital immediately.

Mixed milk samples collected from vendors, dairies

FP News Service

UJJAIN

Food safety officials on Tuesday collected a mixed milk sample from vendor Sagar Singh Thakur, who was transporting milk in cans in a vehicle. Another mixed milk sample was collected from vendor Vikram Rajput, who was also carrying milk cans in a vehicle, for laboratory examination.

In addition, a milk sample was collected from Jai Sanjay Milk Dairy at Temple Square in Unhel, Nagda tehsil. A mixed milk sample was also collected from Maa Ka Ashirwad Milk Product, located near Unhel Railway Station in Unhel.

Cong workers protest Rahul's detention



UJJAIN: Congress workers staged a protest on Tuesday evening after reports emerged that Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, MP Priyanka Gandhi and senior leaders of the All India Congress Committee (AICC) had been detained while protesting outside the Prime Minister's residence in New Delhi.

Led by City Congress Committee president Mukesh Bhati, party workers gathered near the statue of BR Ambedkar at Tower

Chowk, where they held a demonstration and raised slogans against the Union government. They also burnt an effigy of Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Reports that Rahul Gandhi had sustained injuries during police action in Delhi and had been taken into custody further intensified the anger among local Congress workers. In protest, a large number of party members remained on the road at Tower Chowk for more than two hours.

Police get leads in honey-trap case involving Rs 10L extortion

FP News Service

UJJAIN

Nanakhedha police have obtained crucial leads in connection with a gang suspected of honey-trapping a young construction worker and extorting Rs 10 lakh from him. Special police teams have been deployed to apprehend the suspects, who allegedly posed as members of a Hindu organisation before abducting the victim.

The victim, Haider, son of

Kalam Patel, a resident of Narwar who works in the construction sector, had befriended a young woman from Sehore through social media.

The woman reportedly asked him to arrange construction work for her. In this connection, she travelled to Ujjain on July 18, where Haider picked her up from the railway station in his car. The two first visited Haider's construction site to discuss work and later went to a hotel on Indore Road.

Confidence more important than perfection: Scientist Shubha Iyengar

FP News Service

UJJAIN

Confidence is more important than perfection. The true key to success lies in facing failures and challenges fearlessly while continuing to work with dedication and perseverance, said renowned Indian aerospace scientist and Padma Shri awardee Shubha Iyengar while inaugurating the third International Conference and Faculty Development Programme (NGMFT-2026) at Samrat Vikramaditya Vishwavidyalaya, Ujjain (SVVU), as the chief guest on Tuesday.

Addressing the inaugural session, Dr Iyengar shared insights from her research

journey and spoke about the development of India's first indigenous Runway Visibility Measuring System, 'Drishti', inspiring students and young researchers with her experiences.

Presiding over the programme, vice-chancellor Dr Arpan Bhardwaj emphasised the importance of innovation, practical learning and a scientific outlook in higher education. He said universities should not merely serve as centres of rote learning but must evolve into institutions capable of providing solutions to both local and global challenges.



Miyawaki forest inaugurated on Mall Road



FP News Service

MHOW

Under the joint aegis of the Cantonment Board and Station Headquarters, Mhow, a Miyawaki forest was inaugurated behind the fort on Mall Road. The forest was inaugurated by Station Commander Brigadier Atul Bhatia, SM, and Cantonment Board chief executive officer Jyoti Kapoor.

During the drive, military officers, Cantonment Board officials and staff, along with school students, social workers and eminent citizens, planted around 1,500 saplings. The species included amla, guava, Oltam, Kunj, Arjun, mango, pee-

pal, gulmohar, sheesham, kachnar, Ashoka and jamun. Students took a pledge for environmental conservation during the plantation drive. Cantonment Board officials said saplings planted in the same area about 1.5 years ago have now grown well and are yielding positive results. Owing to regular watering and care, the area is now covered with greenery. Officials present included Satish Agrawal, Manish Agrawal, Amit Vyas and Anil Bhati. Through the Miyawaki technique, a dense and fast-growing forest will be developed in a smaller area. This will promote biodiversity, strengthen ecological balance and expand green cover.

Bai Gram fair price shop suspended over violations

FP News Service

MHOW

The Food, Civil Supplies and Consumer Protection Department, Mhow, had been receiving complaints against the government fair price shop at Bai Gram, operated by Seva Sahakari Sanstha Chaural.

On Tuesday, assistant supply officer Mahadev Muvel conducted a surprise inspection of the shop. Several serious irregularities were found during the inspection.

At the time of inspection, the shop was found closed. During physical verification, a shortage of 442 kg of wheat and 101 kg of rice was detected. Consumers were being charged Rs 5 to Rs 10 extra for salt. Other violations included the absence of a stock board inside the shop, the shop opening only three days a week, and the electronic weighing scale not being verified by the Legal Metrology Department.

Two Addl Collectors hear public grievances



Dewas: Two Additional Collectors addressed public grievances during a weekly hearing held at the Collector's office in Dewas and directed departmental officials to resolve them promptly. Additional Collector Shobharam Solanki and Additional Collector Sanjeev Jain heard applications submitted by residents across various sectors. Joint Collector Vishakha Deshmukh and officials from multiple

government departments attended the session.

Applicants submitted grievances concerning the transfer of agricultural land, bank account deposits, water tax concessions, the Prime Minister Housing Scheme, land demarcation, electricity bill reductions, inclusion in the Below Poverty Line (BPL) list, land nomination, partition, removal of road encroachments and drain cleaning.

NEWLY ELECTED ALDERMEN WELCOMED TO CITY COUNCIL

FP News Service

SANWER

After a long wait, the Madhya Pradesh government released the list of alderman appointments on Monday. Vivek Ma-

haskar, Pankaj Jain, Kiran Johri and Omprakash Yadav were appointed aldermen in Sanwer Nagar Parishad, the only Nagar Parishad in the Sanwer Assembly constituency, on the recommendation of Nagar Parishad

Janpad CEO reviews mid-day meal quality

FP News Service

MHOW

As per the instructions of the district panchayat chief executive officer (CEO), deputy commissioner (development) and Janpad Panchayat chief executive officer Giriraj Dubey conducted a surprise inspection of the mid-day meal scheme on Tuesday.

During the inspection, Dubey visited Dongargaon Secondary and Primary School, Gawali Palasia Girls School and an anganwadi centre in Mhow block. He interacted with students and teachers regarding the quality of the mid-day meal.

National Children's Science Exhibition held at PM SHRI School



FP News Service

MHOW

The National Children's Science Exhibition (RBVP)-26 was organised at PM SHRI School, Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalaya, Manpur.

Principal Sunil Kumar Sharma of Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalaya, Indore, inaugurated the exhibition by cutting the ribbon. He later visited the exhibition along with teachers Ragini Bhatt, CS Sharma,

Shamsher Singh, PD Pandey, Rita Khapekar and Renu Adhyay. Sharma observed various scientific models and projects presented by students, asked them questions and appreciated their scientific approach, innovation and creativity. Balram Sule and Bhavna Yadav of Government Higher Secondary School served as judges. They examined all the models and conducted a fair assessment as per the guidelines.

Sharma, Jaideep Kanungo, Indresh Chavda, Manoj Sharma, Rajendra Verma, chief municipal officer Amit Lobania and BJP leaders welcomed and congratulated the newly appointed aldermen.

IN THE HOUSE | Assembly passes Fire Safety and Emergency Services Bill with stricter penalties

Rs 5L fine, mandatory fire NOC under new law

Integrated state fire safety and emergency service to be established

Our Staff Reporter
BHOPAL

The Madhya Pradesh Assembly passed the Fire Safety and Emergency Services Bill on Tuesday, providing for a maximum penalty of up to Rs 5 lakh for violations of fire safety norms. It introduces stricter fire safety provisions for multi-

storey buildings, commercial complexes, industrial units, educational institutions, hospitals, coaching centres and public pandals.

As per the Bill, an integrated Madhya Pradesh Fire Safety and Emergency Service will be constituted for the state. A separate directorate will be established for effective implementation of the services. The state government will be able to establish modern fire stations and field units either suo motu or on the recommendation of local bodies.

The Bill makes it mandatory to obtain fire plan approval and a Fire No Objection Cer-

Key penalties under the Bill

VIOLATION	PENALTY
Spreading rumours about a fire incident	Rs 20,000
Neglecting fire safety measures	Up to Rs 50,000
Continuing violations	Rs 5,000 per day
Operating a building without Fire NOC and sanctioned fire plan	Up to Rs 5 lakh
Breaking the seal of a building sealed by authorities	Rs 5 lakh
Negligence or cowardice by fire safety squad personnel	Up to three months' imprisonment or deduction of three months' salary

tificate (NOC) before construction of any building. In its absence, the concerned local body will not issue an Occu-

pancy Certificate. Private qualified agencies with expertise in fire safety, civil, electrical, mechanical and management

sectors will be empowered to issue licences. They will prepare fire plans, carry out third-party certification and conduct safety audits. To reduce the construction cost of commercial buildings, the Bill introduces a provision for shared fire safety infrastructure for a group of buildings or within the same area.

Spreading rumours about a fire incident will attract a penalty of Rs 20,000. A penalty of up to Rs 50,000 has been proposed for neglecting safety measures. A fine of Rs 5,000 per day will be imposed for continuing violations. A fine of up to Rs 5 lakh will be imposed

for operating a building without a Fire NOC and sanctioned plan. If a building is found to be dangerous to life and property, the competent officer may seal it. Breaking the seal will attract a fine of Rs 5 lakh.

The Bill also provides that if members of the fire safety squad are negligent in performing their duties or display cowardice during duty, they may face imprisonment of up to three months or deduction of three months' salary. In emergencies, the fire safety squad will have the authority to draw water free of cost from any government or private source.

MP CODE ON EMPOWERING WORK SPACES BILL GETS ASSEMBLY NOD

Employers barred from holding workers' original documents

Bill introduces right to disconnect, safeguards for women working on night shifts

Our Staff Reporter
BHOPAL

The Madhya Pradesh Assembly on Tuesday passed the Madhya Pradesh Code on Empowering Work Spaces (Labour Power Code) Bill, 2026, aimed at strengthening workers' rights and workplace welfare. It prohibits forced la-

bour and exploitative practices. Employers will no longer be allowed to retain employees' original educational certificates, identity cards or passports. They will also not be permitted to transfer employees without their consent.

The Bill introduces a "right to disconnect" to promote mental health and work-life balance. Under this provision, workers cannot be compelled to work during non-working hours. On-call duty will be treated as overtime. The maxi-

mum working hours have been fixed at 12 hours a day. Employees working night shifts or in hazardous conditions will be entitled to additional benefits through weighted hours.

Women will be permitted to work night shifts only after giving written consent and if employers provide free, secure transportation and ensure their safety. For the first time, gig and platform workers, including delivery personnel and cab drivers, have been brought under the ambit of the law.

Ease of doing business secretariat to come up, dept officers to be delegated

Our Staff Reporter
BHOPAL

The state government plans to set up an ease of doing business secretariat to quickly solve the problems of industries.

The House passed the Ease of Doing Business Bill on Tuesday. As part of the bill, the government will form a State Investment Promotion Committee and a District Investment Promotion Committee.

Plans are also afoot to notify the MP Industrial Development Corporation (MPIDC) as state nodal agency.

White and Green-category industries will be set up on the basis of self-declaration

The departments will provide necessary delegation of powers regarding the notified approvals under Schedule-4.

In cases, where the delegation of powers is not possible, the government will ensure posting or nomination of competent officers. The Bill consists of a provision for

implementing a self-declaration-based system for White and Green category industries. According to the provision, the eligible industries will get certificate of establishment.

An industry will get permission for starting activities on the basis of the certificate and a self-declaration.

According to the Bill, the industries should obtain approvals within the stipulated time frame. The inspection of public health, public safety, environmental protection, and national security will continue as before. There will be no exemptions to this provision.

Boston experts introduce Vidyasagar students to physiotherapy careers



Our Staff Reporter
INDORE

Vidyasagar School organised a career guidance session on physiotherapy and emerging opportunities in health sciences, where experts from the MGH Institute of Health Professions, Boston, interacted with students. The session focused on career prospects, the growing demand for physiotherapists and the importance of adopting a healthy lifestyle.

Associate professors Dr Devashish Tiwari and Dr Shweta Gore Tiwari addressed the students, explaining the role of physiotherapy in post-surgery rehabilitation, accident recovery, sports injury management and improving athletic performance.

They also highlighted research opportunities in health sciences and discussed high-

paying career options available in countries such as the US and Europe.

School principal Bhavana Pujari welcomed the guests and said students should explore emerging career options beyond conventional professions, adding that such interactions help them make informed career choices.

The interactive question-and-answer session saw students seek advice on health issues linked to excessive mobile phone use, including neck and spinal problems.

The experts demonstrated simple stretching exercises and emphasised maintaining proper posture and regular physical activity. Advising students to balance academics with fitness, Dr Devashish Tiwari and Dr Shweta Gore Tiwari stressed that a healthy body supports a healthy mind.

17 buildings fined Rs 6.75 lakh for failing to install rainwater harvesting systems

Our Staff Reporter
INDORE

Indore Municipal Corporation (IMC) has imposed fines totalling Rs 6.75 lakh on 17 commercial establishments and buildings for failing to install or maintain mandatory rainwater harvesting (RWH) systems, as part of its ongoing drive to promote water conservation.

The action was taken on Monday under the directions of municipal commissioner

Kshitij Singhal to enforce the state government's rainwater harvesting regulations and building permission conditions. During the special inspection campaign, civic officials inspected commercial establishments, institutions and other buildings to verify the installation and functioning of rainwater harvesting systems. Buildings where the system was either absent or found to be non-functional were penalised under the prescribed rules.

Students use art, literature to spread anti-drug message

Our Staff Reporter
INDORE

As part of the Police Commissionerate's 'Nashe Se Doori, Hai Zaroori 2.0' (Say No to Drugs) campaign, a series of creative competitions were organised at Abhay Prashal to spread awareness about the harmful effects of drug abuse among children and youth. Painting, rangoli, slogan writing, poetry, essay writing and open mic competitions were held on the theme, "Say No to Drugs, Build a Drug-Free Society." A large number of students and young participants used their creativity to promote the message of staying away from drugs. Commissioner of police Santosh Kumar Singh inaugurated the programme in the presence of senior police officers, students and citizens. Addressing the gathering, he said drug addiction destroys not only an individual but also families and society. He urged young people to stay away from drugs and encourage others to

MP Police school holds anti-drug awareness prog
MP Police Public Higher Secondary School, in collaboration with the 15th Battalion, Special Armed Force (SAF), Madhya Pradesh Police, organised an awareness programme under the 'Nashe Se Doori, Hai Zaroori 2.0' campaign to educate students about the dangers of substance abuse and encourage them to adopt a healthy and responsible lifestyle.

do the same. Participants also took a pledge to support a drug-free society. The event became memorable when a three-year-old girl appealed to everyone to stay away from drugs. Special children also impressed the audience with paintings and slogans carrying strong social messages, inspiring everyone with their creativity and determination.

Gambhir revival shows early signs of success despite scanty rainfall

Our Staff Reporter
INDORE

The Gambhir River revival project in the district has begun showing encouraging results, with water starting to accumulate in the river and nearby wells despite scanty rainfall. The early signs of improvement have brought cheer to farmers, who see the project as a step towards securing the region's water future.

On Tuesday, during the Jan-sunvai, a large number of farmers from Kailod village, linked to the Gambhir River, gathered at the Collector's office to thank the government and administration for the initiative. They honoured collector Shivam Verma with a traditional turban and floral garland for the implementation of the river revival project. Village sarpanch Kamal Chaudhary, Janpad member (Mhow) Vilin Patidar and other farmers were present.

The Gambhir River is considered the lifeline of the Malwa region. Its conservation and rejuvenation are being carried out with the participation of the administration, public representatives, gram panchayats, voluntary organisations and



Water starts accumulating in river, nearby wells as farmers welcome conservation efforts

local farmers. Officials said that, following the directives of Chief Minister Mohan Yadav, efforts are under way to restore the river's continuous flow and improve its ecological health through a mass water conservation campaign.

The administration has identified activities including plantation along riverbanks, catchment area development, contour trenches, boulder check dams, loose boulder structures, recharge shafts and farm ponds to strengthen groundwater recharge.

State gets four weeks to reply in PIL over disability pension for PwDs

Our Staff Reporter
INDORE

The Indore Bench of the Madhya Pradesh High Court on Tuesday granted the State government four weeks to file its reply in a public interest litigation (PIL) alleging that persons with disabilities (PwDs) are not receiving disability pension in accordance with the Social Security Pension Scheme. The matter has been listed for hearing after four weeks.

The PIL has been filed by the Parivaar National Confederation of Parents Organisa-

tion through its president, Pankaj Maru. During the hearing before a Division Bench comprising Justice Subodh Abhyankar and Justice Alok Awasthi, the State sought time to respond to the allegations, which the court allowed.

The petition contends that disability pensions are not being disbursed to eligible beneficiaries in accordance with the provisions of the Social Security Pension Scheme, depriving persons with disabilities of benefits meant for their social security and welfare.

37 food samples collected during dairy shop inspection

INDORE: The Food Safety Administration conducted a drive against adulteration of milk and dairy products on Monday and Tuesday. During the two-day campaign, officials inspected nine dairy and food establishments and collected 37 food samples for laboratory testing. On the instructions of district collector Shivam Verma, food officials inspected dairies, sweet shops and milk product sellers, checking hygiene, storage conditions and food safety standards. Mobile Food Testing Laboratory units were also used to carry out on-the-spot preliminary testing at three establishments. Samples of milk, curd, paneer, ghee, khoya, sweets, cream barfi, milk cake and namkeen were collected from various shops across the city. At one dairy establishment, officials found that the refrigerator used to store paneer and curd was not properly cleaned. The owner was instructed to maintain hygiene, clean the refrigerator regularly and store food at the required temperature. Officials also inspected dairy products brought from outside Indore to ensure their quality before being sold in the city.

29 police personnel honoured for outstanding work

Our Staff Reporter
INDORE

Police Commissioner Santosh Kumar Singh honoured 29 police officers and staff members for their outstanding contribution in different areas of policing during a weekly reward programme held at the CP's office in Palasia on Tuesday. The personnel received appreciation certificates and cash rewards for their excellent work.

The Indore Police Commissionerate's weekly programme encourages officers and em-

ployees who perform exceptionally in their duties and improve policing for the public. The awarded personnel were recognised for solving important criminal cases, arresting suspects, exposing a blind murder case, recovering illegal drugs, including 110 g of brown sugar and 10 g of cocaine, preparing accident cases on the E-DAR system, linking FIRs in the SID system, arresting a consultancy operator in a fraud case, and maintaining better traffic management at major city intersections.

AFRC decides fees of 355 pvt institutions: Minister

Our Staff Reporter
BHOPAL

Technical education minister Inder Singh Parmar stated in its written reply to the Assembly on Tuesday that the Admission and Fee Regulatory Committee (AFRC) determined the fees for 5,062 private educational institutions for the period up to 2025-26 academic year.

The minister stated this in response to a question posed by MLA Pankaj Upadhyay wherein he demanded to know how the AFRC could thoroughly scrutinise applications and decide fees for 355 private educational institutions in one day's meeting.

He said that the process

required examining the income-expenditure details provided in the applications against reports from inspection teams and the department's own chartered accountant.

The MLA claimed that no answer was provided regarding the timeframe and the number of applications scrutinised by the institutions' authorised chartered accountants.

MLA said that of 1,824 applications scrutinised for 2025-26 year, he questioned how it was possible to examine 7 to 8 applications in a single working day.

He demanded a CBI or high-level committee inquiry into the fee fixation process for private educational institutions.

D.P. Abhushan Q1 profit jumps 77%, revenue rises 58%

Our Staff Reporter
INDORE

D.P. Abhushan Limited (NSE: DPABHUSHAN), a leading retail gold and diamond jewellery company, reported strong unaudited financial results for the quarter ended June 30, 2026, driven by robust consumer demand and retail expansion.

The company posted a net profit after tax (PAT) of Rs 64.45 crore in the first quarter (Q1) of FY2026-27, up 77% from Rs 36.42 crore in the corresponding quarter last year. Revenue increased 58% to Rs 852.40 crore from Rs 540.37 crore during the same period.

The company also announced plans to open new showrooms in Jabalpur, Madhya Pradesh, and Dahod, Gujarat. The Dahod outlet will be the company's first showroom in Gujarat and will operate under the company-owned, company-operated (COCO) model, while the Jabalpur outlet will be its first franchise-owned, company-operated (FOCO) showroom. Following the expansion, D.P. Abhushan will have 13 show-

rooms across Central India and one in Western India.

Managing Director Santosh Kataria said the company has begun FY27 on a strong note despite the Adhik Maas period and remains focused on expanding its footprint while continuing to deliver quality products and customer experience.

PANCHANG 22.7.2026 (DAKSHINAYAN)

Saka 1948 Samvat 2083

Month : Ashad Shukla 1-9 Wednesday
Nakshatra : Svati 11.04 PM, then Vishakha
Yoga : Sadhya 6.42 PM, then Shubh
Karan : Balav 6.07 PM, then Taila
Moon : Tula

VEN, KETU 5, 4 JUP, SUN 6, 2 MARS, MER 3, 12 SAT, NEP 10, 11 RAHU 9

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GRIHUM HOUSING FINANCE LIMITED
Registered Office: 6th Floor, B Building, Ganga Trueno, Lohegaon, Pune, Maharashtra - 411014

Whereas, the undersigned being the Authorised Officer of GrihUm Housing Finance Limited (hereinafter referred to as the "Secured Creditor") of the above Corporate/ Register office under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (hereinafter referred to as the "Act") and in exercise of the powers conferred under Section 13 (12) of the said Act read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued a demand notice below dated calling upon the below Borrowers to repay the amount mentioned in the notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The borrowers having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the borrowers and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/ her under Section 13 (4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002 on this 16th Day of the July Month of the Year 2026.

The borrowers in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of secured Creditor the amount and interest thereon.

The borrower's attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets. Details of Property taken in possession are herein below.

Name of Borrowers	Description of Property	Possession taken Date	Date of statutory Demand Notice	Amount in Demand Notice (Rs.)
YUJAY CHOUHAN, AJAY CHOUHAN, VARSHA CHOUHAN	All that piece and parcel of property being: Plot/House No.4B Situated At Gram Panwase, (verma Nagar) Main Road, Ujjain M.p. Total Area 69.64 Sq.mtr. Together With All Movables & Receivables, All Existing Buildings And Structures Thereon And Buildings And Structures As May Be Erected/ constructed there upon any time from/after The Date Of Respective Mortgages And all addition thereto and all fixtures and furniture's attached to the earth or Permanently Fastened To Anything Attached to The Earth, Both Present And Future and Bounded As Under: Boundaries Of The Plot:- East - Road Of Colony 20 Feet Wide West- Plot No.4B North- plot No.09 South - Road Of Colony 20 Feet Wide Total Area - 69.64 Sq.mtr.	16/07/2026	11/12/2025	Loan No. HL0018010000005056329 Rs. 6,54,489/- (Rupees Eight Lakh Fifty Four Thousand Four Hundred Ninety Five Only) payable as on 11/12/2025 along with interest @ 13.00 p.a. till the realization.

In any case if there is any difference between the contents of local language publication and English newspaper publication, the content of the English newspaper language published in Free Press shall be prevail.

Place : Madhya Pradesh
Date : 22.07.2026

Sd/- Authorised Officer
GrihUm Housing Finance Limited

WESTERN RAILWAY TO EXTEND TRIPS OF WEEKLY SPECIAL TRAINS

TRAIN NO.	FROM	TO	DAY OF RUN	EXTENDED UPTO
04728	VALSAD	HISAR	Thursday	13.08.2026
04727	HISAR	VALSAD	Wednesday	12.08.2026
04736	LAXMI BAI NAGAR	SRI GANGANAGAR	Friday	14.08.2026
04735	SRI GANGANAGAR	LAXMI BAI NAGAR	Thursday	13.08.2026

For detailed information regarding stoppages, timings of halts and composition, passengers may please visit www.enquiry.indianrail.gov.in.

The booking for extended trips of Train No. 04728 & 04736 opens on 22.07.2026 at all PRS Counters and on IRCTC website. The above trains will run as Special Train on Special Fare.

WESTERN RAILWAY
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SYMBOLIC POSSESSION NOTICE

ICICI Bank Branch Office: ICICI Bank Ltd. Office Number 201-B, 2nd Floor, Road No. 1 Plot No-B3, WIPIT Park, Wagle Industrial Estate, Thane (West) - 400604

The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice.

Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken symbolic possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules of the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number	Description of Property/ Date of Symbolic Possession	Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand Notice (Rs)	Name of Branch
1.	Sanjeev Karansingh Gambhir (Deceased) Through Its Legal Heirs & Taran Singh Gambhir & Mrs. Sumit Gambhir & Harcharan Gambhir- LBJA000005405169	House No. 30, Shashtri Colony, Jaora District, Madhya Pradesh- 457226/ July 18, 2026	March 16, 2026 Rs. 1,06,70,064.36/-	Jaora

The above-mentioned borrower(s)/guarantors(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.

Date: July 22, 2026
Place: Jaora

Sincerely Authorised Officer
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

Briefs

MEERUT
Governor Questions Scooty Scheme
UP Governor Anandiben Patel expressed displeasure over the delayed implementation and arbitrary rules of the Rani Laxmibai Scooty Scheme during the con-vocation ceremony at Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel University of Agriculture and Technology. She questioned officials over the delay in framing guidelines and urged that welfare schemes should prioritise deserving rural and needy girl students instead of relying solely on high academic scores.

SHAMLI
Notices Issued to Meat, Liquor Shops

Authorities in Uttar Pradesh's Shamli district have issued notices to meat and liquor shop owners located along the Kanwar Yatra route, directing them to comply with restrictions during the annual pilgrimage. Officials said the move is aimed at maintaining religious sentiments and ensuring smooth conduct of the yatra. Shopkeepers have been asked to follow the pre-scribed guidelines, while authorities warned that violations could invite legal action during the pilgrimage period.

LUCKNOW
Metro Launches Common Mobility Card

The Lucknow Metro has launched the National Common Mobility Card (NCMC), allowing passengers to make seamless digital payments for metro travel. The card is designed to offer a cashless, convenient and integrated travel experience and can also be used for other transport and retail payments where NCMC is accepted. Metro officials said the initiative is part of the government's vision to promote smart mobility and a unified digital payment ecosystem across India.

VARANASI
Hanuman Idol Vandalised

Tension gripped a village in Varanasi after unidentified miscreants allegedly vandalised a Hanuman idol at a local temple, triggering outrage among residents. Villagers gathered at the site and demanded strict action against those responsible. Police reached the spot, brought the situation under control and launched an investigation. Officials said efforts are underway to identify the accused, while security has been stepped up to prevent any law-and-order issues.

AGRA
Two Killed in Road Crash

Two people were killed after a car became trapped beneath a canter truck following a collision in Agra. Rescue teams used cutting equipment to extricate the bodies from the mangled vehicle after a lengthy operation. Police reached the spot, cleared the wreckage and sent the bodies for post-mortem examination.

LUCKNOW
E-Tricycles for Disabled Students

The Uttar Pradesh government will provide e-tricycles worth ₹65,000 to eligible girl students with disabilities to improve their mobility and access to education. The initiative aims to promote inclusive education and empower differently abled students by easing their daily commute. Officials said the scheme will benefit eligible students studying in educational institutions across the state.

DELUGE | **Monsoon Returns with Fury Across Uttar Pradesh**
Heavy Rain Alert in 70 Districts as IMD Warns of Thunderstorms

UP State Bureau
LUCKNOW/VARANASI

The southwest monsoon has regained momentum across Uttar Pradesh, bringing widespread rainfall, a sharp drop in temperatures and fresh warnings of heavy to very heavy showers over large parts of the state. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) has issued rain alerts for most districts, with orange alerts in several regions, warning of thunderstorms, lightning and intense down-pours over the next few days.

According to weather officials, eastern and western Uttar Pradesh are likely to witness widespread rainfall, with isolated spells of very heavy rain expected in several districts. Authorities have cautioned residents against unnecessary travel during thunderstorms and advised people to remain alert in low-lying and flood-prone areas.

The renewed monsoon activity has already brought



Heavy Rains Wash Away 25-Metre Road in UP, 50 Temples Flooded in Varanasi

relief from the recent spell of humid weather, with temperatures dropping noticeably across many cities, including Lucknow, Prayagraj

and Varanasi. However, the rain is also expected to cause waterlogging, traffic congestion and disruptions to normal life, particularly in urban centres where drainage systems remain under pressure.

The IMD has warned that lightning and strong winds may accompany heavy showers in several districts. Farmers have welcomed the rainfall as it is expected to

improve soil moisture and benefit paddy transplantation and other kharif crops, though excessive rainfall could affect low-lying agricultural fields.

Disaster management authorities have advised district administrations to remain on high alert and ensure preparedness for any emergency. Residents have been urged to avoid taking shelter under trees during lightning, stay away from waterlogged areas and follow official advisories until weather conditions improve.

Weather experts expect the active monsoon phase to continue for the next several days, with intermittent heavy rainfall likely across much of Uttar Pradesh. The spell is expected to provide a boost to agriculture and replenish reservoirs, but officials caution that persistent rain could also increase the risk of localised flooding and disruption to transport and daily life.

UP Centralises Doctor Recruitment



UP State Bureau
LUCKNOW

In a major administrative reform, the UP government has withdrawn the powers of Chief Medical Officers (CMOs) to recruit doctors across the state. The authority to appoint medical professionals will now rest with the state-level health department in an effort to streamline the recruitment process and improve transparency. The move comes amid repeated concerns over irregularities and inconsistencies in district-level appointments. Officials said the new system is expected to ensure uniform recruitment procedures, faster filling of vacancies and better deployment of doctors in government hospitals. District CMOs will continue to identify manpower requirements and oversee healthcare services, but the final recruitment process will be handled centrally.

Property Row Delays Father's Final Journey



UP State Bureau
AMROHA/MORADABAD

A family dispute over ancestral property delayed the last rites of an elderly man in Uttar Pradesh's Amroha district after his four sons reportedly quarrelled in front of their father's funeral bier. Instead of preparing for the cremation, the brothers became embroiled in a heated argument over ownership of the family home, forcing funeral arrangements to be halted. The body remained at the house overnight as relatives left and police failed to resolve the dispute.

The following morning, local residents and village elders intervened and con-

Four sons clash over ancestral home before funeral

vened a panchayat. The community decided that the family should first perform the father's final rites with dignity and settle the property dispute later through mutual agreement or legal channels. All four brothers accepted the decision, and the cremation was finally carried out at the Tigri Ganga cremation ground. The incident has sparked widespread discussion over the growing impact of property disputes on family relationships and traditional values.

Opposition Erupts After Rahul, Akhilesh Detained

UP State Bureau
LUCKNOW

Political temperatures soared on Tuesday after Congress leader Rahul Gandhi and Samajwadi Party (SP) chief Akhilesh Yadav were detained by Delhi Police during protests near the PM's residence, triggering demonstrations across UP, particularly in Lucknow. The leaders were protesting over alleged police action against students and demanding the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the examination paper leak controversy.

In Lucknow, workers of the Congress and the Samajwadi Party staged separate protests, raising slogans against the Centre and accusing the government of suppressing demo-



Congress, SP Hit Streets After Rahul, Akhilesh Detained

cratic dissent. Police detained several protesters as demonstrations intensified, while security was strengthened at key locations in the city.

SP leaders condemned Akhilesh Yadav's detention, alleging that peaceful protests were being curtailed. Congress leaders also criti-

cised the police action against Rahul Gandhi, claiming that opposition voices were being silenced instead of addressing students' concerns over alleged examination irregularities. Reports said Rahul Gandhi, Priyanka Gandhi Vadra and several opposition MPs were removed from the protest site by Delhi Police. The protests were linked to the continuing controversy over alleged paper leaks and police action against student demonstrators in the national capital.

BKU Protests at Commissioner's Office

UP State Bureau
MEERUT

Activists of the Bharatiya Kisan Union (BKU) Tikait faction staged a massive protest in Meerut on Monday, laying siege to the Divisional Commissioner's office and briefly blocking major roads to press their demands. The protesters raised slogans against the government, alleging that farmers' issues, including crop prices, electricity dues and compensation, remain unresolved. Heavy police deployment was made to prevent any untoward incident, while traffic was diverted due to the blockade. BKU leaders warned of intensifying the agitation if their demands were ignored and urged the government to hold talks with farmers at the earliest.

UP Cabinet Clears Free Scooters, E-Buses in Major Push

UP State Bureau
LUCKNOW

The UP Cabinet, chaired by Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, approved 18 major proposals on Tuesday, unveiling a package of measures aimed at strengthening women's empowerment, higher education, public transport and infrastructure across the state.

Among the biggest decisions was the approval of the Rani Laxmibai Scooty Yojana, under which around 50,000 meritorious undergraduate girl students will receive free petrol-powered scooters to improve access to higher education and promote safe, independent mobility.

Beneficiaries will also receive helmets, essential



18 key decisions focus on women's education, public transport and infrastructure

accessories, registration, insurance and an initial supply of fuel. The scheme has been allocated Rs.400 crore in the state budget. The Cabinet also approved the procurement of 220 new electric buses, reinforcing the

government's efforts to modernise public transport while promoting cleaner and more sustainable urban mobility.

Alongside this, several infrastructure projects, including new expressway links and other development initiatives, received the green signal.

Other key approvals include the construction of a large hostel facility for working women and measures to strengthen public services and urban infrastructure.

Swami Calls for Mathura Kar Seva

UP State Bureau
MATHURA

Swami Sachchidanand has reiterated his call for a Kar Seva in Mathura on August 9, urging saints and devotees from across the country to participate in what he described as a peaceful movement linked to the Shri Krishna Janmabhoomi issue. He said the programme would be conducted in a disciplined and non-violent manner despite administrative restrictions. The announcement comes amid heightened security and ongoing legal proceedings related to the Krishna Janmabhoomi-Shahi Eidgah dispute. Authorities have appealed for peace and warned that law and order will be strictly maintained, while the matter continues to remain under judicial consideration.

VHP Leader Set to Take Key Ram Temple Trust Role

UP State Bureau
AYODHYA

The Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust is expected to appoint its next General Secretary from the ranks of the Vishva Hindu Parishad (VHP), marking another significant administrative change in the management of the Ram Temple. The move follows the recent resignation of former General Secretary Champat Rai, which was accepted by the Trust during its organisational restructuring.

According to reports, the Trust is looking to ensure continuity in its functioning by selecting a senior VHP functionary with extensive organisational experience. The appointment comes as the Trust undertakes governance reforms, including the creation of a Chief Executive



New General Secretary likely to be chosen from Vishva Hindu Parishad ranks

Officer (CEO) post, to strengthen transparency and professional management.

The leadership changes come amid heightened public scrutiny following the ongoing investigation into alleged irregularities involving temple donations. Trust officials have maintained that the restructuring aims to reinforce accountability.

UP Monsoon Session from August 3

UP State Bureau
LUCKNOW

The Uttar Pradesh Cabinet has approved the convening of the third session of the state legislature from August 3 to August 6. The four-day Monsoon Session will primarily focus on the Supplementary Budget for 2026-27, replacement bills for ordinances issued after the previous session, and other key legislative business. The government is also expected to table several official reports and address important administrative matters during the session. The decision was taken at a Cabinet meeting chaired by Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath. The session is expected to witness discussions on financial allocations and major public issues raised by both the government and the Opposition.

Muharram Gathering Inspires Devotees

UP State Bureau
LUCKNOW/BASTI

A Muharram congregation held at Azakhana Syed Zafar in Gandhi Nagar witnessed devotees gathering in large numbers for the sixth session of the ten-day Safar-ul-Muzaffar Ashra-e-Majlis. Addressing the gathering, Maulana Dr Mohammad Askari Mashhadi highlighted the teachings of Prophet Muhammad and the Ahl al-Bayt, stressing the values of justice, compassion, morality and communal harmony.

Quoting Imam Ja'far al-Sadiq, he said that weeping in remembrance of Imam Hussain is an act of glorifying God, participating in mourning assemblies is a form of worship, and holding love for the Ahl al-Bayt is a path of devotion. He said that organis-



Scholar urges devotion through Imam Hussain's remembrance

ing mourning gatherings, performing matam and remembering the sacrifice of Karbala carry immense spiritual reward. The session concluded with an emotional narration of the sufferings of Hazrat Sakina, leaving many mourners in tears and reinforcing the message of sacrifice, faith and humanity.

UP Recruitment Aspirants Protest

UP State Bureau
LUCKNOW

Aspirants for the Uttar Pradesh Gram Panchayat Adhikari recruitment staged a protest outside the residence of Deputy Chief Minister Brajesh Pathak, demanding the early declaration of results for the 2023 recruitment process. Protesters formed a human chain and raised slogans, urging the state government to expedite the selection process.

They alleged that prolonged delays have left thousands of candidates uncertain about their future and affected their career plans. Police personnel were deployed at the site to maintain law and order as demonstrators continued their peaceful agitation.

polygamy

Panchayat Divides Husband's Week Between Two Wives

UP State Bureau
RAMPUR

A village panchayat in Uttar Pradesh's Rampur district has drawn widespread attention after resolving a domestic dispute by dividing a husband's week between his two wives. The unusual settlement was reached after the first wife complained that her husband had stopped supporting her financially and was living mostly with his second wife. The matter was initially reported to the local police before being referred to a village mediation meeting.



According to the settlement, the husband will spend three days each week with his first wife and three days with his second wife, while the seventh day will be left to his

own choice. The panchayat also directed him to provide monthly household rations to his first wife and pay her 500 per week for personal expenses. Both parties

Village settlement gives each wife three days, leaves seventh day to husband's choice

reportedly accepted the agreement, after which the complaint was not pursued further.

Reports said the man married his first wife about 14 years ago, and the couple has two daughters. Several years later, allegedly hoping for a son, he entered into a second marriage without the consent of his first wife. The second

marriage also resulted in two daughters, leading to growing tensions within the family.

The panchayat's decision has sparked debate on social media and beyond, with many questioning the role of informal village bodies in resolving complex family disputes.

While supporters viewed the agreement as a practical compromise accepted by all parties, others argued that such sensitive matrimonial matters should be addressed through the legal system rather than community settlements.

Youth Remain India's Biggest Hope

Rakhi Sharma
LUCKNOW

Amid growing concerns over India's social, political and economic landscape, analysts and public intellectuals say the country's greatest strength in overcoming current challenges is its youth. They argue that debates driven by identity politics and emotional issues often overshadow pressing concerns such as employment, education, healthcare and inflation. Experts caution that when propaganda replaces facts and dialogue gives way to

Experts urge focus on jobs, education and constitutional values

polarisation, democratic institutions and constitutional values face increasing pressure.

They also stress that India must make decisions based on national interest and long-term strategic priorities while remaining alert to changing global dynamics. Despite rising public frustration, observers believe the situation is far from hopeless.

Briefs

Aditya Birla Sun Life AMC Q1 profit rises 12% to ₹309 cr

Aditya Birla Sun Life AMC on Tuesday reported a 12% year-on-year surge in consolidated net profit to ₹309.5 crore for the June quarter, driven by an increase in other income. The asset management firm had earned a net profit of ₹277 crore in the same quarter last year. Revenue from operations rose 3% to ₹463 crore in the quarter under review from ₹447.4 crore in the April-June quarter of the preceding fiscal year.

Air India chooses JFK airport's Terminal 6 for ops from 2028

Air India on Tuesday said it has chosen the new terminal T6 at the John F Kennedy International Airport in New York for its operations, starting from 2028. Currently, Air India operates flights from Terminal 4 (T4) at the JFK airport. T6 will open in two phases, with the first set of gates opening in 2026 and the remaining gates and terminal completion expected by 2028, according to a release.

Rallis India Q1 profit rises 31% to ₹125 crore

Rallis India Ltd, which is in the farm inputs business, reported a 31% increase in April-June net profit at ₹125 crore on higher revenue. Its net profit stood at ₹95 crore in the year-ago period. Total income rose to ₹1,035 crore in the first quarter of this fiscal from ₹969 crore in the corresponding period of the preceding year, according to a regulatory filing on Monday.

Steel Exchange India Q1 PAT up 47% to ₹15 cr

Steel Exchange India Ltd (SEIL) on Tuesday reported a 46.89% year-on-year rise in its consolidated net profit to ₹15.03 crore for the quarter ended June 30, 2026, aided by improved margins and lower debt. The company's total income stood at ₹270.71 crore during the April-June quarter of FY27, down 11.23% from the year-ago period.

Advit Jewels FY26 PAT rises 36% to ₹34.39 cr

Advit Jewels Ltd on Tuesday reported a 35.56 per cent year-on-year increase in net profit to ₹34.39 crore for the financial year ended March 31, 2026. The company's total income rose 33.68 per cent to ₹167.03 crore in FY26 from ₹124.94 crore in the previous financial year. EBITDA increased 32.52 per cent year-on-year to ₹49.24 crore.

SC warns Parsvnath executives of jail, gives 1-week deadline to clear homebuyers refunds

PTI NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday granted Parsvnath Developers one week as the final opportunity to comply with orders passed in favour of homebuyers in Gurugram by depositing the entire amount along with 12 per cent interest with the registry within one week.

Observing that failure to do so would result in imprisonment, a bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana made very strong remarks against the real estate firm and its directors.

Bandhan Bank's Q1 PAT jumps 35% to ₹502 cr

Private sector lender Bandhan Bank Ltd on Tuesday reported a 35% year-on-year rise in its net profit to ₹502 crore for the first quarter of the 2026-27 financial year, compared to ₹372 crore in the corresponding period last fiscal.

Net interest income for the April-June period grew 5.9% to ₹2,921 crore compared to ₹2,757 crore a year ago, while net total income rose 1.2% to ₹3,524 crore from ₹3,483 crore in the corresponding period last year. Gross advances grew 16.4% year-on-year to ₹1,55,555 crore as of June 2026 from ₹1,33,625 crore a year earlier, the lender said. On a year-on-year basis, the retail book, excluding housing, grew 45%, wholesale banking rose 38%, and the housing loan book expanded 6%, a statement said.

Asset quality showed sequential improvement, with gross non-performing assets at 3.1% and net non-performing assets at 0.9% in the quarter, against 3.3% and 1%, respectively, in the preceding three-month period. -PTI

AESL profit jumps more than 2-fold to ₹1,237 cr in June qtr

Adani Energy Solutions posted a more than twofold rise in consolidated net profit to ₹1,236.56 crore in the April-June quarter compared to the year-ago period on higher revenues, the company said on Tuesday.

The consolidated net profit stood at ₹538.94 crore in the quarter ended on June 30, 2025, an exchange filing showed. Total income rose to ₹9,852.20 crore in the quarter from ₹7,025.49 crore in the same period a year ago.

Revenue from the trans-

Bajaj Auto Q1 profit rises 42% to ₹2,983 cr

PTI NEW DELHI



Bajaj Auto Ltd on Tuesday reported a 42% year-on-year jump in standalone net profit at ₹2,982.84 crore for the quarter ended June.

The Pune-based automobile maker had posted a net profit of ₹2,095.98 crore in the first quarter of FY26, according to a statement.

Total revenue from operations for the June quarter rose 37% to ₹17,243.72 crore from ₹12,584.45 crore in the corresponding quarter a year ago. On a consolidated basis, profit after tax surged 46% to ₹3,225.63 crore in Q1FY27 compared to ₹2,210.40 crore in the April-June period of FY26.

Consolidated revenue from total operations stood at ₹22,376.69 crore in the first quarter under review, up 64% from ₹13,642.33 crore in the first quarter of the previous year.

The company stated that it

saw a strong start to FY27 with record performance across volume, revenue, and profit, adding that its domestic business registered another solid quarter with double-digit growth across all segments, driving revenues up 26% year-on-year.

Total sales volume during the quarter grew 29% year-on-year at 1,438,251 units from 1,111,237 units, with domestic sales rising 11% and exports surging 54%.

Co expects double-digit growth in both two- and three-wheeler demand

Bajaj Auto on Tuesday said it expects double-digit growth in both two- and three-wheeler demand and aims for the top position in the electric

vehicle segment in the country.

Speaking in a post-earnings media interaction, Bajaj Auto Ltd Executive Director Rakesh Sharma stated that the company would have put up a better performance in the previous quarter but for factors like inflation, supply chain issues, and serious logistics problems, which impaired availability by 10% to 15%.

Sharma added that the company may consider roping in a strategic partner provided its vision strategies align with the brand.

"The demand hopefully will continue at this rate. Of course, not those rocking rates post-GST, but good solid double-digit or maybe let's say 8% to 10% growth rates in domestic. Both electric two- and three-wheelers are growing extremely fast because of the obvious reasons of operating economics of electric vehicles versus petrol," Sharma said.

Adani-Total Gas Q1 net profit falls 18% on higher gas price

PTI NEW DELHI



Adani Total Gas Ltd, the city gas joint venture of Adani Group and TotalEnergies of France, on Tuesday reported an 18% drop in June quarter profit as the price of gas soared in the aftermath of the West Asia crisis.

Net profit of ₹133 crore in April-June — the first quarter of the 2026-27 fiscal year — compared with ₹162 crore earned in the same period a year back, the company said in a statement. Revenue was up 27% at ₹1,910 crore on account of higher volumes of com-

pressed natural gas.

The cost of natural gas rose 39% to ₹1,454 crore. "Higher gas cost due to continued West Asia crisis, and increase in administrative price mechanism gas price ceiling, the cost of natural gas rose 39%," the statement said.

"During the quarter, administrative price mechanism allocation for compressed natural

Ather Energy raises ₹1,300 cr through QIP

Ather Energy on Tuesday said it has raised ₹1,300 crore through a QIP launched on July 15 as part of its ₹2,500-crore capital infusion plan. The issue received a healthy response from foreign and domestic institutional investors, with participation from leading FIs such as ADIA, White Oak and William Blair, alongside some DIs. -PTI

SC notice to Videocon Grp arms for inclusion of overseas assets in IBC

The Supreme Court on Tuesday issued notices to Videocon Oil Ventures Ltd and others on a petition by Videocon Group's former MD Venugopal Nandlal Dhoot seeking to include the foreign oil and gas assets of various arms of Videocon Industries Ltd in the latter's assets for its insolvency proceedings. Dhoot has sought that all foreign assets, properties, rights, and claims of Videocon Oil Ventures Ltd, Videocon Hydrocarbon Holdings Ltd, Videocon Energy Brasil Ltd, and Videocon Indonesia Nunkan Inc, be included as assets and properties of

In 2018, the Mumbai bench of the NCLT had admitted a petition by the State Bank of India seeking to initiate insolvency proceedings against Videocon Industries. In 2019, the tribunal allowed the consolidation of the corporate insolvency resolution processes of Videocon Group's related companies. Dhoot said that Videocon Industries' resolution profes-

SAIL approves ₹31,000 crore Bhilai Steel Plant expansion

PTI NEW DELHI

Steel Authority of India Ltd has given in-principle approval for the capacity expansion of its flagship unit, Bhilai Steel Plant, from 6.8 million tonnes per annum to 10.2 million tonnes per annum, at an estimated cost of ₹31,000 crore, Parliament was informed on Tuesday.

Bhupathi Raju Srinivasa, Minister of State for Steel, in a written reply to a question in the Lok Sabha, stated that the project has the potential to generate direct and indirect employment during the construction and operational

TVS Motor Co Q1 profit rises 65% to ₹1,057.61 cr



TVS Motor Company Ltd on Tuesday reported a 65% jump in consolidated net profit to ₹1,057.61 crore in the first quarter ended June 30, 2026, riding on record quarterly sales. The company had posted a consolidated net profit of ₹642.86 crore in the corresponding period of the preceding fiscal, TVS Motor Company said in a regulatory filing.

Consolidated revenue from operations in the first quarter stood at ₹16,295.52 crore, up from ₹12,210.05 crore in the year-ago period.

Total expenses in the quarter under review were higher at ₹14,894.22 crore,

compared to ₹11,261.6 crore in the same period a year ago.

During the first quarter, TVS Motor registered its highest-ever quarterly sales, with overall two- and three-wheeler sales growing by 28% to 16.3 lakh units, up from 12.8 lakh units in the year-ago period.

Motorcycle sales during the quarter under review grew by 19% to 7.4 lakh units, compared to 6.2 lakh units in the corresponding period last fiscal.

WCCI acquires Philippine firm S Brands

PTI NEW DELHI

Wipro Consumer Care International (WCCI) on Tuesday said it has acquired leading Philippine personal care company S Brands for an undisclosed amount.

It has signed a definitive agreement to acquire 100% shareholding of S Brands Consumer Care Inc, which will be "Wipro Consumer Care International's 16th strategic acquisition globally and its second in the Philippines", according to a joint statement.

business

Indore, Wednesday, July 22, 2026

IHCL's Q1 profit rises 19% at ₹391 crore

Tata Group-owned Indian Hotels Company Limited on Tuesday reported an 18.67% rise in consolidated net profit to ₹390.81 crore for the first quarter ended June 30, 2026.

The country's largest hospitality player had reported a net profit of ₹329.32 crore in the year-ago period. Revenue from operations in the June quarter of FY27 increased to ₹2,339.19 crore. Total expenses rose to ₹1,886.04 crore, as per a regulatory filing. "Q1 FY2027 marks the 17th consecutive best ever quarter with a consolidated revenue of ₹2,419 crore, a 15% growth over the previous year," Puneet Chhatwal, MD and CEO stated.

S Brands' portfolio includes

KERATINplus, described as the country's top hair treatment brand, along with hygiene brand AlcoPlus, powder deodorant brand DeoPlus, hair care brand Empress and teen fragrance brand Fiona Cologne.

Maruti Suzuki India to hike car prices by up to ₹30,000 from August

Car market leader Maruti Suzuki India on Tuesday said it will hike prices of its vehicles across models by up to ₹30,000 from August to partially offset the sustained increase in input costs.

The exact quantum of change will vary from model to model, the company said in a regulatory filing.

"In view of the continuous sustained increase in input costs, the company has decided to increase the prices of its models across its portfolio by up to ₹30,000," it stated.

The increase in prices will

come into effect from August 2026.

For the past few months, the company has been making continuous efforts to mitigate the cost impact to the extent possible through cost reduction measures.

However, with inflationary pressure at elevated levels and the adverse cost environment continuing, the company said it is constrained to pass on a portion of the increased costs to the market, while continuing to ensure that the impact on customers is kept to the minimum extent possible. -PTI

Paytm plans to infuse ₹100 cr in wealth tech arm Paytm Money

Fintech firm One97 Communications, which owns the Paytm brand, plans to infuse ₹100 crore in its wealth tech arm Paytm Money, the company said in a regulatory filing. Incorporated in 2017, Paytm Money is engaged in providing investment and wealth management services, including stock broking, mutual fund distribution, and

other financial services.

"Additional investment by the company, by way of subscription, to the equity shares of its wholly owned subsidiary, namely Paytm Money Limited (PML) by way of a rights issue for an amount up to ₹100 crore, subject to the necessary approvals, as applicable," Paytm stated in a filing.

The company expects to

close the transaction by September 30.

"PML is a wholly owned subsidiary of the company. Issuance of up to 10 crore additional equity shares of face value of ₹10 each by PML, pursuant to the Rights Issue, will not result in a change in shareholding of the company in PML, which remains at 100%," the filing added. -PTI

Aditya Birla Cap invests ₹1.24 bn in Aditya Birla Health Insurance

Aditya Birla Capital Ltd on Tuesday said it has invested ₹1.24 billion in Aditya Birla Health Insurance Company Limited through a rights issue.

The investment will help the health insurer meet its solvency margin.

Aditya Birla Health Insurance is an existing associate company of Aditya Birla Capital. Aditya Birla Capital's shareholding in Aditya Birla Sun Life will remain at 45.89% after the fund infusion, the company said.

IRCTC operates third Mukhyamantri Tirth Darshan special train



The Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation (IRCTC), in collaboration with the Maharashtra government, has flagged off a special Bharat Gaurav Tourist Train to Bodh Gaya under the Mukhyamantri Tirth Darshan Yojana from Dadar Railway Terminus on Monday. Maharashtra Minister for Social Justice

Sanjay Shirsat flagged off the train in the presence of MLA Kalidas Kolambkar, MLA Tukaram Kate, MLC Manisha Kayande, senior state government officials, railway officials and a large number of pilgrims. The special train is the third such service operated under the state government's pilgrimage scheme.

India accelerates seed sector reforms

FPJ News Service
MUMBAI

The Centre on Tuesday unveiled a comprehensive roadmap to modernise India's seed sector, with a strong focus on climate-resilient crop varieties, digital traceability, international collaboration and public-private partnerships to improve farm productivity, strengthen food security and expand the country's presence in global seed markets.

The government said sustained investment in agricultural research has resulted in a significant rise in the development of improved crop varieties.

Between 2014 and 2025, the National Agricultural Research and Education System released and notified 3,236 field crop varieties, of which 2,996 were climate-resilient. These include 587

New Delhi accelerates climate-smart seed reforms with digital traceability, advanced breeding, stronger exports and quality assurance to bolster food security nationwide

varieties specifically developed to withstand extreme weather conditions, comprising 341 drought-tolerant, 89 flood-tolerant, 80 salinity-tolerant, 59 heat stress-tolerant and 18 cold-tolerant varieties. Research is being led by a nationwide network comprising 56 ICAR institutes, 48 state agricultural universities, three central agricultural universities and 39 centres under the All India Coordinated Research Project on seeds. Cereals accounted for the lar-



gest share of improved varieties, with 1,574 releases, including 1,453 climate-resilient varieties. This was followed by 473 pulse varieties, 444 oilseed varieties, 408 fibre crop varieties, 207 forage var-

ieties and 96 sugarcane varieties, all of which were climate-resilient.

The government said the emphasis is on ensuring farmers have access to high-yielding seeds capable of with-

standing drought, floods, heat, salinity and waterlogging.

A total of 10,802 varieties across 219 crop species have been registered so far, with 5,689 registrations completed during 2023-26, enabling farmers, research institutions and private companies to protect newly developed varieties. India now has 229 seed hubs, 384 breeder seed production centres and 17 state seed corporations, supported by the National Seeds Corporation and several public sector enterprises alongside private seed companies.

Seed quality is monitored through 178 notified Seed Testing Laboratories, while financial assistance is being provided to upgrade laboratories and obtain international accreditation. The government has simplified seed import and export procedures by shifting approvals to the DGFT digital platform follow-

ing the abolition of the EXIM Committee in October 2024.

India's seed exports have continued to outpace imports. In 2025-26, the country exported 123.82 thousand metric tonnes of seeds worth ₹3,023.16 crore, while imports stood at 31.84 thousand metric tonnes valued at ₹1,755.96 crore.

International collaboration remains another key pillar of the strategy. India is a founding member of the International Treaty on Plant Genetic Resources for Food and Agriculture and works closely with global agricultural research organisations such as IRRI, ICRISAT, CIMMYT, ICARDA and the Alliance of Bioversity International and CIAT. These partnerships provide Indian researchers with access to global germplasm, advanced breeding technologies and climate-resilient farming practices.

(With inputs from PIB)

Redevelopment benefits largely remain tax-free



By Rajesh M Kayal

Redevelopment of ageing cooperative housing societies has become increasingly common, particularly in metropolitan cities such as Mumbai. Under a typical redevelopment agreement, a member temporarily hands over possession of an existing flat to the developer and, in return, receives benefits such as transit rent, hardship compensation and a larger redeveloped flat. The tax treatment of these benefits has long been debated. However, recent decisions of the Bombay High Court and the Mumbai Bench of the Income Tax Appellate Tribunal (ITAT) have provided significant clarity and largely favoured taxpayers.

Similarly, **Haresh Damji Shah v. ITO** (ITAT Mumbai, 2026) held that hardship compensation and additional facilities, including parking spaces provided under a redevelopment agreement, could not be taxed separately as income.

The landmark Bombay High Court ruling in **Sarfraz S. Furniturewalla** affirmed that hardship compensation received under redevelopment is a capital receipt intended to compensate members for inconvenience and temporary displacement. The decision has since been consistently followed by the Mumbai Tribunal.

CBDT Circular No. 9/2014 The Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT), through Circular No. 9/2014, clarified the tax consequences of redevelopment transactions and recognised that relief under the Income-tax Act may be available where the prescribed conditions are satisfied, helping reduce unnecessary litigation.

Practical guidance

Every redevelopment agreement should be examined on its own facts. The description of a payment alone is not decisive. Its true nature, the rights transferred and the obligations of the parties determine its tax treatment. Where payments are genuinely made towards transit accommodation, rehabilitation, hardship and temporary displacement—and not as consideration for transferring property rights—judicial precedents strongly support their treatment as non-taxable capital receipts.

Conclusion

Recent rulings of the Bombay High Court and the Mumbai ITAT have brought welcome certainty for members of cooperative housing societies. Transit rent, hardship compensation and similar redevelopment benefits are ordinarily treated as capital receipts and are therefore not taxable.

Likewise, receiving additional carpet area in exchange for an existing flat does not generally result in immediate taxation. Well-drafted redevelopment agreements and proper documentation remain essential to support the tax treatment recognised by the courts.

Looking ahead

Although the current judicial position is favourable, redevelopment transactions are becoming increasingly sophisticated as projects grow in scale and complexity. Issues involving additional monetary consideration, commercial premises, joint ownership, inherited properties and the subsequent sale of redeveloped flats may require separate tax analysis based on the facts of each case. Future amendments to tax laws or fresh judicial pronouncements could also influence the treatment of certain redevelopment benefits. Staying informed and seeking timely professional advice can help members navigate these evolving issues with greater confidence.

Gold futures climb as US-Iran talks progress amid optimism



Gold futures rose nearly 1% on Tuesday, tracking firm global markets as investors monitored diplomatic efforts to ease tensions between the US and Iran. PTI reported on Tuesday.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange, gold contracts for August delivery gained ₹988, or nearly 1%, to ₹1,42,376 per 10 grams, with a business turnover of 551 lots.

Analysts said bullion prices recovered after reports suggested Iran had received a proposal for a 10-day ceasefire from mediators. The development eased immediate geopolitical concerns, although investors remained cautious about the wider impact on global energy markets and inflation.

In the international market, Comex gold futures for August delivery climbed by \$66.30, or nearly 2%, to \$4,082.20 per ounce. Gold also rebounded from key support levels near \$3,960 per ounce after recent weakness. Market experts said expectations of further monetary tightening by the US Federal Reserve and a strong dollar

continued to limit the metals upside. However, relatively light investor positioning after months of exchange-traded fund outflows could restrict further declines.

Strong physical demand, particularly from China, along with continued central bank purchases, also provided support to gold prices.

Silver futures moved higher as well, following gains in overseas markets. On the MCX, silver contracts for September delivery rose by ₹2,600, or 1.19%, to ₹2,21,000 per kilogram, with a turnover of 1,017 lots.

In global trade, Comex silver futures advanced 2.8% to \$58 per ounce. Analysts attributed the rise to fresh positions built by market participants amid firm international cues.

Investors will now closely track developments in US-Iran negotiations, movements in the dollar and the European Central Bank's policy decision for further direction in bullion prices.

—Commodity Desk

Crude futures edge higher on geopolitical concerns



Crude oil futures climbed nearly 1% on the MCX on Tuesday as persistent geopolitical tensions in West Asia and concerns over potential supply disruptions kept market sentiment firm.

The August crude oil contract rose by ₹65, or nearly 1%, to settle at ₹8,014 per barrel, with a business turnover of 13,945 lots. The September contract also edged higher by ₹17, or 0.22%, to ₹7,856 per barrel, supported by cautious buying.

Analysts said oil prices remained volatile after Iran launched retaliatory attacks on US-linked military installations in Jordan and Bahrain following recent American airstrikes. The developments renewed fears of a wider regional conflict and possible disruptions to global energy supplies.

In the international market, Brent crude for September delivery traded slightly lower at \$88.82 per barrel, while West Texas Intermediate (WTI) crude was largely unchanged at \$82.43 per barrel.

According to Anindya Banerjee, Head of Commodity and Currency Research at Kotak Securities, Brent crude continues to hover near the \$90 mark as Iran has limited its military response and avoided direct attacks on Israel and Saudi Arabia.

Hopes of a proposed 10-day ceasefire have also prevented oil prices from rising further. However, Banerjee said downside risks remain limited because tanker movement through the Strait of Hormuz has slowed, inventories remain healthy and refining margins continue to support fuel markets.

—PTI

FCI rice stocks hit record high

Food Corporation of India (FCI) data released on Tuesday showed wheat stocks easing 2% month-on-month to 52.2 million tonnes as of 1 July, although they remained nearly 46% higher than a year earlier and well above the buffer requirement.

Rice stocks rose to a record 40.3 million tonnes, the highest level since 1998, surpassing both last year's level and the previous month's record.

Total foodgrain stocks stood at 92.6 million tonnes, compared with 73.7 million tonnes a year ago.

Higher wheat procurement during the 2026-27 rabi marketing season helped maintain comfortable inventories despite weather-related crop damage earlier this year.

Sugar prices steady, buyers cautious

Ex-mill sugar prices remained unchanged across key markets in Maharashtra and Uttar Pradesh on Tuesday as mills resisted cutting rates despite softer buying interest at elevated price levels.

Traders said buyers were negotiating for lower prices after the recent sharp rally, while mills continued to assess demand before making any pricing changes. Sugar prices have risen more than 15% in recent weeks, supported by panic buying, concerns over tighter supplies and deficient monsoon rainfall, which remains 23% below normal.

In Maharashtra, prices are expected to remain range-bound within a band of ₹20 per 100 kg. Global sugar prices edged up 0.1% to 14.83 cents per pound.

Market participants will closely monitor monsoon progress, government policy signals and buying interest, with sugar prices expected to remain stable unless fresh supply concerns emerge.

—Informist

Edible oils soften, groundnut gains on rains

Prices of most edible oilseeds eased across key markets on Tuesday, while groundnut prices climbed in Gujarat as heavy rainfall disrupted arrivals and tightened local supplies. Mustard and soybean prices remained under mild pressure due to comfortable availability and subdued buying.

In Kota, soybean prices were largely steady despite lower acreage, with traders expecting rainfall and arrivals to dictate price movements in the coming weeks.

Soybean prices could fluctuate depending on the progress of the monsoon. Groundnut prices in Gondal, Gujarat, rose sharply after heavy rains reduced arrivals by more than half compared with the previous session. Firm international edible oil prices and the approaching festive season are likely to lend support to domestic oilseed prices.

Weak monsoon lifts wheat prices, sparks fresh supply concerns

Wheat prices remained mixed across major spot markets on Tuesday, with Kota in Rajasthan recording gains as below-normal monsoon rainfall raised concerns over the upcoming rabi crop.

Traders said persistent rainfall deficits could affect reservoir levels, irrigation availability and wheat acreage, prompting some farmers to shift towards less water-intensive crops such as chana and mustard. In Kota, wheat prices rose by ₹50 to ₹2,525-₹2,550 per 100 kg, while arrivals remained steady at 8,000 bags.

Traders said Rajasthan has received around 30% below-normal rainfall between June 1 and July 20, increasing con-



cerns over crop production later this year. In contrast, wheat prices remained unchanged at ₹2,770 per 100 kg in Indore due to steady demand and limited arrivals. Traders are also awaiting the government's open market wheat sales for further direction. Prices in Vashi, Navi Mumbai, were steady at ₹2,900

per 100 kg, although wholesalers expect an upward trend if rainfall remains inadequate. Maize prices were largely stable across key markets. Indore prices held at ₹2,440 per 100 kg, while Davanagere in Karnataka quoted ₹1,800-₹2,050 per 100 kg amid balanced demand and steady arrivals. Rice prices also remained unchanged in Vashi. Basmati 1401 traded at ₹9,600-₹9,700 per 100 kg, 1509 at ₹8,200-₹8,300, and 1121 at ₹10,000-₹10,200.

Traders said rice prices may rise if kharif paddy sowing continues to lag due to insufficient rainfall across major producing regions, raising concerns over future supplies.

—Informist

COMMODITY FUTURES

Commodity markets witnessed mixed trading on Tuesday, with base metals extending gains while agricultural commodities remained mixed amid varying demand and supply conditions. On MCX, copper, aluminium and zinc advanced, supported by stronger spot demand and fresh buying by market participants. On NCDEX, cottonseed oil cake edged higher on improved cattle feed demand, while guar seed, guar gum and coriander declined due to ample supplies, subdued physical demand and profit-booking by traders across key producing regions.

Copper rose ₹7.10 to ₹1,321.25 per kg as higher spot demand and fresh buying supported prices. July contracts gained 0.54% with a turnover of 1,616 lots. Analysts said participants increased bullish bets, reflecting improving demand conditions in the domestic market.

Aluminium edged up 65 paise to ₹341.70 per kg as traders built fresh positions amid positive spot market trends. July contracts gained 0.19% with 102 lots traded. Analysts said demand from consuming industries and renewed buying interest supported aluminium prices.

Zinc gained 0.33% to ₹374.80 per kg as higher spot demand encouraged fresh buying by participants. July contracts rose ₹1.25 with a turnover of 164 lots. Traders attributed the increase to improved physical market demand, supporting zinc prices.

Cottonseed oil cake edged up ₹3 to ₹3,855 per quintal as traders created fresh positions amid rising cattle feed demand. August contracts gained 0.08% with open interest of 46,700 lots. Market participants said stronger demand supported prices despite limited overall movement.

Guar seed declined ₹129 to ₹6,039 per quintal as ample supplies from producing regions weighed on sentiment. August contracts fell 2.09% with open interest of 54,675 lots. Market participants attributed the decline to higher arrivals and comfortable availability in the physical market.

Guar gum dropped ₹284 to ₹11,683 per quintal as weak spot demand and ample supplies triggered selling. August contracts declined 2.37% with 65,485 lots traded. Market participants said sluggish buying and increased availability continued to pressure guar gum prices.

Most spice futures ended lower on the National Commodity and Derivatives Exchange as traders booked profits after recent gains. **Coriander** fell nearly 1% despite touching a fresh record high earlier in the session, supported by strong demand and tight market supplies.

Jeera edged lower on ample availability and subdued export sentiment, while turmeric remained largely steady after scaling record highs last week. Analysts said coriander and turmeric continue to enjoy firm underlying fundamentals, but intermittent profit booking may cap near-term gains. Weather conditions, crop quality, export demand and market arrivals are expected to remain the key drivers of spice prices. The most active August **turmeric** contract was largely unchanged at ₹21,500 per 100 kg. According to SMC Investments and Advisors, higher arrivals indicate increased farmer selling, but weather conditions will remain the key driver of prices.

MARKET PRICE PULSE				
(All rates in ₹/quintal unless otherwise specified)				
Rice (Fine): ₹5,800-₹5,500	Rice (Medium): ₹5,400-₹5,600	Jowar: ₹3,000-₹3,500	Jaggery (Cube): ₹5,500-₹6,000	Jaggery (Ball): ₹5,200-₹5,400
Coriander Seed: ₹16,000-₹22,000	Chilli (Fine): ₹35,000-₹60,000	Potato (Big/Medium): ₹1,800-₹2,400	Onion (Big): ₹2,400-₹2,800	Onion (Medium): ₹1,400-₹2,200
Onion (Small): ₹1,000-₹1,500	Turmeric: ₹7,000-₹13,000	Garlic: ₹9,000-₹25,000	Horsegram: ₹5,800-₹6,500	Wheat: ₹3,200-₹4,500
Turmeric: ₹18,000-₹22,000	Toor Dal: ₹8,000-₹12,500	Green Gram Dal: ₹8,800-₹10,800	Black Gram Dal: ₹9,000-₹15,000	Bengal Gram Dal: ₹7,000-₹8,500
Mustard: ₹9,800-₹11,500	Gingerly: ₹14,500-₹19,500	Sugar: ₹24,700-₹26,000	Groundnut Seed: ₹16,500-₹18,500	Groundnut Oil: ₹1,600-₹2,000
Coconut Oil (10 kg): ₹2,270-₹4,130	Gingerly Oil: ₹2,310-₹4,300	Ghee (5 kg): ₹2,260-₹3,300	Black Pepper (Ready): ₹725-₹850	Ginger (Branded/Unbranded): ₹370
Copra (Office, Allepore): ₹15,000	Copra (Office, Kuttanadu): ₹14,800	Copra (Rajapur, Mumbai): ₹19,500	Copra (Edible, Mumbai): ₹19,500	Coconut & Mumbai Coconut Oil: ₹40,000
Note: Prices may vary across Maharashtra and other states due to supply disruptions, transportation costs, climate changes, and other market factors.				

Tur corrects after rally; chana trades mixed amid demand

Tur prices corrected across major wholesale markets on Tuesday after Monday's sharp rally, while chana traded on a mixed note and urad remained steady amid tight supplies and profit-booking, traders said.

In Akola, Maharashtra, tur prices fell by ₹100 per 100 kg to ₹8,300-8,325 after touching a two-month high of ₹8,450 on Monday, matching the minimum support price (MSP) for the next marketing year. Prices in Katni, Madhya Pradesh, also eased by ₹50 to ₹8,400-8,500 per 100 kg. Traders said the correction was largely driven by profit-booking following recent gains. However, the near-term outlook for tur will continue to depend on monsoon progress



and kharif sowing. Government data showed tur acreage was down nearly 18% year-on-year at 2.48 million hectares as of last week due to deficient rainfall in key growing regions. Chana prices in Akola slipped ₹25 to ₹6,475-6,500 per 100 kg after Monday's sharp rise, while Delhi prices remained unchanged at ₹6,250.

—Informist

DII / FPI trading activity			
	BUY VALUE	SELL VALUE	NET VALUE
DII	14,638.54	15,295.42	-656.88
FII / FPI	16,327.88	14,677.72	1,650.16

All figures in ₹ crores

You pay a very high price in the stock market for a cheery consensus.

Warren Buffett



Nifty stuck in narrow trading range



Motilal Oswal Wealth Management

MUMBAI

Indian equity benchmarks ended on a subdued note on Tuesday, with the Nifty remaining confined to a narrow trading range as investors refrained from taking aggressive positions despite key support levels holding firm. Technical indicators suggested indecisiveness after the recent rally, while derivatives data pointed to a broader consolidation phase.

The Nifty opened on a flat note and slipped during the first half of the session before finding buying support near the crucial 24,150 level. The index formed a bearish candle along with an inside bar and an NR3 pattern on the daily chart, indicating reduced volatility and a lack of clear directional momentum. Technical analysts said the Nifty must decisively move above 24,250 to resume its upward trajectory towards 24,350 and subsequently 24,450. On the downside, immediate support is placed at 24,100, followed by the psychologically important 24,000 level.

Derivatives data reflected a cautious undertone. Maximum Call Open Interest (OI) was concentrated at the 24,200 strike, followed by 25,000, while Maximum Put OI was also highest at 24,200, followed by 23,000. Fresh Call writing emerged at 24,200 and 24,600, whereas Put writing was visible at 24,200 and 24,100 strikes. The options chain indicates a broader trading range of 23,800-24,600, with an immediate range between

24,000 and 24,400. The BSE Sensex also witnessed a lacklustre session after opening flat. Selling pressure persisted through most of the day, although the index managed to defend its previous session's low near 77,300. It formed a small-bodied bearish candle with shadows on both sides, signalling an ongoing tussle between buyers and sellers.

For the Sensex, analysts believe a sustained move above 77,500 is required to trigger a recovery towards 78,000 and 78,200. Immediate support is seen at 77,200, followed by 76,800. The Bank Nifty initially advanced from around 57,850 to 58,250 but failed to sustain higher levels, eventually slipping back towards 57,800 by the close. The index formed a small-bodied candle with a long upper shadow, suggesting selling pressure at higher levels even as lower supports remained intact. A move above 57,750 could pave the way for gains towards 58,250 and 58,500, while supports are placed at 57,500 and 57,250.

Meanwhile, the Nifty futures contract settled 0.31% lower at 24,185. Stocks showing technical strength included TVS Motor, Manappuram Finance, IndusInd Bank, Shriram Finance, Sonata Software, Laurus Labs, Godrej Properties, Bajaj Finserv, SRF and Aditya Birla Capital. Weakness was evident in Bank of Baroda, HDFC AMC, HDFC Bank, Tata Elxsi, Kaynes Technology, Force Motors, Infosys, Crompton Greaves Consumer Electricals, NBCC and Reliance Industries.

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Data source: Capitaline

Wall St. gains as chipmakers, earnings cheer investors

Wall Street's major indices traded higher on Tuesday as strong corporate earnings and a rally in semiconductor stocks outweighed concerns over the continuing conflict between the US and Iran. Investors shifted their focus towards quarterly results, with optimism over company performance lifting broader market sentiment.

The Dow Jones Industrial Average rose around 375 points, or 0.7%, while the S&P 500 gained 0.8%.

The technology-heavy Nasdaq Composite outperformed, advancing 1.3% as chipmakers led the market higher.

Industrial giant 3M surged more than 9% after reporting stronger-than-expected second-quarter earnings. General Motors also impressed investors with better-than-expected revenue and profit, sending its shares up 5%.

According to FactSet, nearly 88% of the 66 S&P 500 companies that have reported quarterly results so far have exceeded analysts' earnings estimates.

Market participants are now awaiting results from major technology companies, including Alphabet, IBM and Tesla, later this week, which are expected to



provide fresh direction for global equities. Semiconductor stocks were among the strongest performers. The VanEck Semiconductor ETF gained 4%, while Micron Technology jumped 10%.

Intel rose 7%, Marvell Technology added 7%, and Astera Labs advanced 6%, reflecting renewed investor confidence in the sector after last week's sharp correction.

Despite the positive momentum, geopolitical risks continued to influence market sentiment. Fighting between the US and Iran remained intense, although reports suggesting a proposed 10-day ceasefire offered some optimism and eased fears of an immediate escalation.

—Business Desk

52-week high

Company Name	21/7/2026	52-week High	52-week Low	Change Rs	Chg (%)
Solar Industries	19070.20	19137.45	11641.10	7496.35	64.40
Navin Fluor.Intl.	7856.50	7929.90	4500.10	3429.80	76.22
SPR Auto Technologies	4518.10	4525.00	2300.00	2225.00	96.74
Stylam Industrie	3542.30	3542.30	1575.15	1967.15	124.89
Sar Auto Prod.	3399.00	3399.15	1490.00	1909.15	128.13
Gujarat Fluoroch	4605.00	4629.90	2917.00	1712.90	58.72
Titan Company	4688.05	4692.20	3301.05	1391.15	42.14
RPG LifeScience.	3020.45	3080.90	1731.25	1349.65	77.96
Ajanta Pharma	3571.00	3594.05	2335.00	1259.05	53.92
Cemindia Project	1639.70	1650.00	481.40	1168.60	242.75
Inox India	2090.10	2105.95	1030.85	1075.10	104.29
Adani Energy Sol	1741.35	1789.00	745.45	1043.55	139.99
Rubicon Research	1520.00	1538.95	571.00	967.95	169.52
Lloyds Metals	1933.00	1948.00	1044.00	904.00	86.59
Tatva Chintan	1685.00	1786.70	977.85	808.85	82.72
Corona Remedies	2079.20	2129.55	1336.95	792.60	59.28
Tinna Rubber	1145.25	1320.05	529.00	791.05	149.54
Laurus Labs	1592.95	1599.90	810.75	789.15	97.34
Ador Welding	1507.20	1586.00	850.00	736.00	86.59
Gabriel India	1493.40	1518.95	795.80	723.15	90.87
Zelio E-Mobility	812.00	812.00	154.90	657.10	424.21
India Nipp.Elec.	1242.90	1278.65	653.25	625.40	95.74
CFF Fluid	966.15	1008.95	445.00	563.95	126.73
Sai Life	1294.90	1307.60	779.45	528.15	67.76
Inv. & Prec.Cast.	889.70	895.15	397.15	498.00	125.39
SMT Engineering	513.45	513.45	25.25	488.20	1933.47
T N Merc. Bank	818.00	848.00	418.65	429.35	102.56
Sky Gold & Diam.	656.10	673.85	245.95	427.90	173.98
Sun Pharma.Inds.	1962.15	1966.75	1547.25	419.50	27.11
Shreeji Ship. GI	608.05	626.20	221.55	404.65	182.65
Himadri Special	800.80	819.50	420.00	399.50	95.12
Cyient DLM	622.80	628.45	264.95	363.50	137.20
IndusInd Bank	1064.30	1068.40	710.85	357.55	50.30
Shyam Metals	1055.60	1089.60	745.65	343.95	46.13
Transchem	370.25	370.25	38.31	331.94	866.46
Sona BLW Precis.	733.20	734.35	402.55	331.80	82.42
Asian Hotels (W)	462.55	462.55	143.80	318.75	221.66
Amagi Media Labs	595.00	618.25	310.75	307.50	98.95
Waterways Leisure	907.05	925.05	623.30	301.75	48.41
M M Forgings	555.00	558.60	276.05	282.55	102.35
Balrampur Chini	616.90	642.00	393.40	248.60	63.19
Avadh Sugar	555.00	555.00	307.75	247.25	80.34
Rotographics (I)	306.65	306.65	66.47	240.18	361.34
Jana Small Finan	561.60	569.65	330.30	239.35	72.46

Top gainers (value)

Company Name	20/7/2026	21/7/2026	Chg in ₹	% Chg
MRF	132738.91	133780.00	1041.09	0.78
Abbott India	28275.25	28775.35	500.10	1.77
Shree Cement	26850.60	27267.00	416.40	1.55
Honeywell Auto	38210.35	38600.00	389.65	1.02
Gujarat Fluoroch	4313.90	4605.00	291.10	6.75
Data Pattern	3989.20	4241.25	252.05	6.32
TVS Holdings	14009.25	14241.00	231.75	1.65
TVS Motor Co.	3591.00	3791.60	200.60	5.59
J K Cements	5453.95	5643.50	189.55	3.48
UltraTech Cem.	11897.80	12067.05	169.25	1.42
Eicher Motors	7562.45	7688.25	125.80	1.66
Thermax	4709.75	4817.00	107.25	2.28
Bajaj Holdings	10316.25	10422.75	106.50	1.03
Ajanta Pharma	3469.20	3571.00	101.80	2.93
Gabriel India	1399.00	1493.40	94.40	6.75
Muthoot Finance	2984.80	3078.50	93.70	3.14
Atul	6089.75	6180.40	90.65	1.49
Bayer Crop Sci.	4259.70	4350.00	90.30	2.12
Hind.Aeronautics	4494.35	4581.25	86.90	1.93
Maruti Suzuki	13507.45	13593.30	85.85	0.64
Interglobe Aviat	5228.05	5310.15	82.10	1.57
Gillette India	7819.90	7900.00	80.10	1.02
Cummins India	5505.05	5583.00	77.95	1.42
Netweb Technol.	4182.75	4257.35	74.60	1.78
Emcure Pharma	1860.70	1935.00	74.30	3.99
CRISIL	4235.85	4309.00	73.15	1.73
SRF	2872.05	2941.40	69.35	2.41
Cera Sanitary.	6180.00	6249.20	69.20	1.12
Zen Technologies	1750.85	1819.70	68.85	3.93
ZF Commercial	2341.05	2402.10	61.05	2.61
P & G Hygiene	8728.85	8788.80	59.95	0.69
Garden Reach Sh.	2562.30	2618.80	56.50	2.21
United Breweries	1351.20	1405.00	53.80	3.98
Hero Motocorp	4977.40	5030.00	52.60	1.06
Phoenix Mills	2073.65	2125.00	51.35	2.48
Godrej Propert.	2114.95	2166.00	51.05	2.41
Action Const.Eq.	990.10	1039.80	49.70	5.02
eClerx Services	1878.25	1925.85	47.60	2.53
Grasim Inds	3143.70	3191.00	47.30	1.50
GE Vernova T&D	4443.90	4490.70	46.80	1.05
Titan Company	4642.80	4688.05	45.25	0.97
C P C L	1214.65	1259.70	45.05	3.71
KEI Industries	4930.80	4973.75	42.95	0.87
Solar Industries	19029.75	19070.20	40.45	0.21
Bajaj Finserv	1861.90	1900.40	38.50	2.07

Top losers (value)

Company Name	20/7/2026	21/7/2026	Chg in ₹	% Chg
Dixon Technolog.	14587.95	14121.10	-466.85	-3.20
Hitachi Energy	32498.90	32185.35	-313.55	-0.96
PTC Industries	18040.70	17785.00	-255.70	-1.42
Amber Enterp.	7850.55	7621.95	-228.60	-2.91
Page Industries	40299.05	40095.00	-204.05	-0.51
Force Motors	17911.30	17740.00	-171.30	-0.96
3M India	35245.60	35100.00	-145.60	-0.41
Bajaj Auto	10518.90	10408.10	-110.80	-1.05
Waaree Energies	2826.90	2731.25	-95.65	-3.38
Apar Inds.	13907.15	13811.65	-95.50	-0.69
Aditya AMC	1119.10	1042.80	-76.30	-6.82
JSW Holdings	11050.35	10975.50	-74.85	-0.68
Tata Elxsi	3535.95	3462.80	-73.15	-2.07
Aegis Logistics	1387.50	1314.80	-72.70	-5.24
HDFC AMC	2644.40	2581.15	-63.25	-2.39
Kaynes Tech	3328.95	3271.10	-57.85	-1.74
Neuland Labs.	18942.05	18890.00	-52.05	-0.27
Aditya Infotech	3560.35	3510.00	-50.35	-1.41
One 97	1348.00	1299.70	-48.30	-3.58
OneSource Spec.	1694.95	1648.40	-46.55	-2.75
Radico Khaitan	4131.40	4085.00	-46.40	-1.12
L&T Technology	3349.35	3304.00	-45.35	-1.35
Premier Energies	1085.50	1048.75	-36.75	-3.39
LTM	4081.15	4044.80	-36.35	-0.89
Ipca Labs.	1831.30	1796.70	-34.60	-1.89
Timken India	3128.80	3095.00	-33.80	-1.08
Trent	2926.45	2894.20	-32.25	-1.10
Caplin Point Lab	2647.75	2616.00	-31.75	-1.20
TCS	2250.10	2220.50	-29.60	-1.32
Supreme Inds.	3434.15	3405.00	-29.15	-0.85
Poly Medicure	1721.55	1692.80	-28.75	-1.67
Wockhardt	1922.60	1893.90	-28.70	-1.49
Jubilant Pharmo	1023.95	995.45	-28.50	-2.78
Narayana Hrudaya	2026.05	1998.00	-28.05	-1.38
Escorts Kubota	2979.80	2952.65	-27.15	-0.91
Colgate-Palmoliv	2113.35	2086.25	-27.10	-1.28
Mphasis	2414.60	2388.00	-26.60	-1.10
Gallantt Ispat L	619.25	593.90	-25.35	-4.09
Inventurus Knowl	1904.00	1879.30	-24.70	-1.30
C.E. Info System	1095.90	1071.85	-24.05	-2.19
Siemens Ener.Ind	3391.10	3367.05	-24.05	-0.71
Titagarh Rail	865.90	843.95	-21.95	-2.53
JSW Duxux	3004.40	2984.00	-20.40	-0.68
Cholaman.Inv.&Fn	1783.10	1763.10	-20.00	-1.12
Tata Technolog.	748.20	728.55	-19.65	-2.63

52-week low

Company Name	21/7/2026	52-week High	52-week Low	Change Rs	Chg (%)
JSW Holdings	10975.50	22839.20	10920.00	-11919.20	-52.19
Tata Elxsi	3462.80	6255.15	3453.25	-2801.90	-44.79
City Pulse Multi	608.00	3289.95	608.00	-2681.95	-81.52
National Standar	376.25	2600.00	376.25	-2223.75	-85.53
Indian Link Ch.	632.10	2640.75	620.00	-2020.75	-76.52
Pondy Oxides	563.00	1618.60	560.00	-1058.60	-65.40
Simplex Papers	1148.00	2094.00	1127.05	-966.95	-46.18
JSL Industries	848.00	1561.00	845.10	-715.90	-45.86
PNGS Gargi FJ	651.80	1197.00	626.00	-571.00	-47.70
Le Lavoir	62.35	340.60	62.35	-278.25	-81.69
Olatch Solution	64.15	290.90	63.50	-227.40	-78.17
Gujarat Energy	267.00	484.20	265.10	-219.10	-45.25
Mizzen Ventures	80.25	296.90	80.25	-216.65	-72.97
Adcounity Media.	85.70	282.00	85.50	-196.50	-69.68
Aqylon Nexus	29.80	226.00	29.80	-196.20	-86.81
TaylorMade Renew	74.89	266.40	73.77	-192.63	-72.31
DSM Fresh	68.00	208.00	65.50	-142.50	-68.51
Duroply Indust.	109.00	248.70	109.00	-139.70	-56.17
Sai Silks	89.90	222.90	89.55	-133.35	-59.83
Global Surfaces	24.69	139.90	24.69	-115.21	-82.35
Flair Writing	249.20	356.95	245.00	-111.95	-31.36
UHM Vacation	38.00	132.80	36.89	-95.91	-72.22
Nanavati Venture	78.70	163.30	78.70	-84.60	-51.81
Ansal Buildwell	77.75	157.70	74.13	-83.57	-56.89
RDB Infrastruc.	13.81	91.89	13.81	-78.08	-84.97
S V Global Mill	123.05	192.95	116.30	-76.65	-39.73
Ambo Agritech	10.15	86.69	10.10	-76.59	-88.35
Sri Chakra Cem.	31.96	99.29	31.96	-67.33	-67.81
Asstton Pharmaceu	63.15	125.50	60.00	-65.50	-52.19
A-1	5.25	70.41	5.25	-65.16	-92.54
Coromandel Engg.	52.25	114.93	52.00	-62.93	-54.76
Saumya Cons	118.90	169.50	108.60	-60.90	-35.83
Darjeeling Industries	16.73	75.47	16.73	-58.74	-77.83
Landmark Global	13.30	72.00	13.30	-58.70	-81.53

corporate gallery

Tira Brings Viral K-Beauty Brand Dr. Melaxin to India



Tira, the omnichannel beauty destination from Reliance Re-tail, continues to expand its portfolio of globally sought-after beauty brands with the exclusive launch of Dr. Melaxin, the fast-rising South Korean dermo-cosmetic brand renowned for its science-led approach to skin-care. The brand will be available exclusively on Tira online and at select offline stores. Dr. Melaxin is redefining K-beauty with targeted skincare inspired by the principles of vaccine science. Built around its philosophy of “slow aging,” the brand develops clinically evaluated formulations that address specific concerns including pigmentation, enlarged pores, under-eye aging and loss of firmness, helping strengthen the skin’s resilience over time. Following its international expansion across the United States, Japan and Southeast Asia, Dr. Melaxin has rapidly gained global recognition, becoming the #1 K-beauty brand on TikTok Shop in both the US and UK. The brand follows an 8-FREE clean formulation standard, with every product being cruelty-free, dermatologist-tested and suitable for sensitive skin. Independent clinical studies have demonstrated visible improvements in hydration, radiance and skin firmness within four weeks. Leading the India launch is the brand’s globally viral Peel Shot range—a gentle exfoliating ampoule powered by rice-based AHA and BHA, Pentavitin and rice water to exfoliate, refine pores and visibly improve skin texture and radiance. Launching exclusively on Tira across its online platform and select offline stores, the partnership underscores Tira’s commitment to curating globally acclaimed beauty innovations while offering customers access to authentic, high-performance brands backed by expertise and efficacy. Commenting on the launch, Yu Kyoung Hwa, Chief Executive Officer, Dr. Melaxin, said: “Indian consumers are curious, informed and genuinely interested in effective skincare solutions. Their key concerns—from pigmentation to texture and firmness—are exactly what we have set out to address. Through our launch with Tira, we are excited to bring our most innovative products, including the Peel Shot line, to the people it was created for.” With the launch of Dr. Melaxin, Tira continues to strengthen its growing portfolio of globally sought-after beauty brands, reinforcing its commitment to bringing cutting-edge, science-backed innovations and the latest international beauty trends to Indian consumers.

CII, Consulate General of Mexico Explore Opportunities to Strengthen Economic Ties



An Exclusive interaction with Adolfo Garcia Estrada, Consul General of Mexico in Mumbai, and Dr Alpa Antani, Regional Director, CII Western Region to discuss strengthening India–Mexico economic collaboration. The meeting focused on opportunities across trade, investment, manufacturing, and technology in Western India. Both sides explored leveraging CII’s platforms to enhance engagement between Mexican businesses and India’s industry ecosystem, reinforcing their shared commitment to deeper economic cooperation and future growth.

RPF of NFR Ensures Prompt Medical Care for Passengers Across Railway Network



The Railway Protection Force (RPF) of Northeast Frontier Railway (NFR) continues to uphold its commitment towards passenger safety and welfare by providing timely medical assistance to passengers who fall ill during their journey. Through coordinated efforts with railway authorities and local medical facilities, RPF personnel ensure that passengers receive immediate attention whenever medical emergencies arise. On 17th July 2026, RPF personnel at New Jalpaiguri Railway Station rendered immediate medical assistance to an ailing female passenger travelling by Train No. 15607 (Thiruvananthapuram Central – Silchar) Aronai Express. She was promptly shifted to the Railway Hospital at New Jalpaiguri by ambulance and was subsequently referred to a higher medical facility for specialized treatment. On the same day, RPF personnel at New Jalpaiguri Railway Station also extended medical assistance to another passenger travelling by Train No. 13174 (Sabroom – Sealdah) Kanchanjungha Express. The passenger was shifted to the Railway Hospital at New Jalpaiguri for further medical treatment after receiving immediate assistance at the station. As part of these efforts, 12 passengers were provided medical assistance across NFR during the month of June 2026. Continuing this humanitarian service, 7 more passengers have been provided timely medical assistance during July 2026 (till date), reflecting the prompt response and dedication of RPF personnel in safeguarding passengers’ well-being. Northeast Frontier Railway remains committed to ensuring a safe, secure and passenger-friendly travel experience. The RPF, in coordination with railway medical authorities and other departments, continues to respond swiftly to medical emergencies, reinforcing Indian Railways’ commitment to passenger care and humanitarian service

Anand Nilayam Senior Citizen Home Project Construction to Start This Year



The Annual General Body Meeting of all founder members of the Anand Nilayam project was held on Sunday, 19th July 2026, at F-TAM Center, Thane, under the chairmanship of Sri A. V. Gupta, with Secretary Dr. U. V. Girish Kumar in attendance. Chief Promoter Sri Jaganbabu Ganji informed members that 5 acres of land, all government approvals, and non-agricultural notification have been completed, with a separate 7/12 extract now registered in the name of Anand Nilayam. Over 75,000 sq ft of development, planned to accommodate 200 senior citizens for active living, is ready for construction. Around 25 members attended the proceedings, and the following resolutions were passed unanimously. Notable members who attended include Sri Anji Reddy, M. K. Subrahmanyam, Raghava Rao, Raj Kumar Khajanchi, Satish Nair, Bandi Gangadhar, Margam Mallesh, G. V. Subba Rao, Nangendhar Damji, Keerti Teja, Achintya Rakshit, Jalandhar Ande, Srinivasulu Chenagoni, and others.

Solapur Division of CR Achieves Another Milestone in Freight Business with First Automobile Loading from Bhigwan Goods Shed



The Solapur Division of Central Railway has successfully commenced automobile loading from Bhigwan Goods Shed in a significant boost to freight business and customer-oriented logistics services. This marked the addition of a new stream of freight traffic for the Division. The first New Modified Goods (NMG) rake carrying automobiles was loaded on 19th July 2026 from Bhigwan to B.R. Transcon Limited Goods Cargo Terminal, Rangiya Division of Northeast Frontier Railway (NFR) in Assam’s Kamrup district. The new automobile traffic is expected to contribute significantly to the Division’s freight earnings. As many as 26 indents for automobile loading through NMG rakes have already been registered from Bhigwan to multiple destinations. The commencement of automobile loading marks another milestone in the transformation of Bhigwan Goods Shed into a versatile freight handling terminal. The handling line at Bhigwan was earlier utilised exclusively for ballast handling.

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Dr Suresh Mehrotra

»» BJP looking to make Punjab a direct contest with AAP?

The BJP is intensifying its political efforts to position the Punjab Assembly election as a direct contest between itself and the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), while seeking to sideline the Congress. Political observers say the coming months will provide greater clarity on whether this strategy succeeds.



»» Youngest District Collector in Nagaland

IAS officer Ajit Kumar Verma, Deputy Commissioner of Mokokchung district, has become the youngest District Collector in Nagaland. Born in 1986, Verma is a 2016-batch IAS officer of the Nagaland cadre.



»» Odisha sends panel of IPS officers to UPSC for DGP post

The Odisha government has forwarded a panel of around 10 senior IPS officers to the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) for consideration for the post of Director General of Police (DGP). Among the frontrunners are Sudhanshu Sarangi (IPS 1990), Susanta Kumar Nath (IPS 1993) and R.P. Koche (IPS 1993). Incumbent DGP Y.B. Khurania is due to retire in August.

»» Did intelligence failure mislead Home Ministry on CJP protest?

Questions are being raised over whether inaccurate intelligence inputs left the Home Ministry unprepared for the massive turnout at the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) protest. According to sources, initial assessments significantly underestimated the scale of mobilisation, resulting in the government being caught off guard. The unexpectedly large gathering reportedly prompted emergency late-night meetings in the Home Ministry, where internal security and intelligence departments were said to have been held accountable for the alleged lapse in assessment.

»» Delhi Police reshuffle unlikely to affect field operations

The recent appointment of a new Delhi Police Commissioner has triggered speculation over possible administrative changes. However, authoritative sources maintain that the force’s field-level operations are expected to continue without disruption. Sources said routine administrative changes following a change in leadership are unlikely to affect district and constituency-level functioning. The new leadership is expected to focus on maintaining operational continuity and institutional stability rather than undertaking a major restructuring of the police force.

»» Did a Union Minister tell Amit Shah CJP protest was ‘bad optics’?

A Union Minister reportedly expressed concern over the ongoing Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) protests during a recent high-level meeting convened by Union Home Minister Amit Shah, according to sources familiar with the closed-door discussions. The minister is learnt to have remarked that the “CJP protest is not good for optics”, reflecting growing concern within the government over public perception and media coverage. The meeting, attended by several senior Union Ministers, was called to assess the prevailing political situation and the implications of recent public demonstrations. The reported observation highlights concerns that the prolonged agitation could be affecting the government’s public image. Sources said managing the political narrative surrounding the CJP protests has emerged as a key priority for the government.



»» No immediate threat to Vijay-led government in Tamil Nadu

Despite alleged attempts at sabotage, experts believe there is no immediate threat to the Vijay-led TVK government in Tamil Nadu. They said the government is expected to remain stable for at least the next 2 years.



»» Akash Patil joins KRCL as Deputy Chief Mechanical Engineer

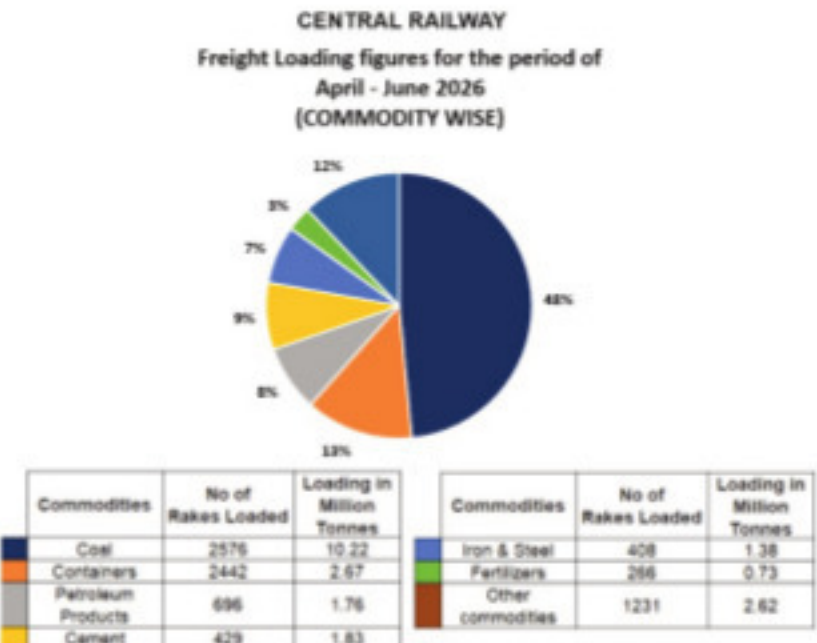
Akash Patil, currently serving as Divisional Mechanical Engineer (DME), PP Yard, Bhilai, Raipur Division of South East Central Railway (SECR), has been selected for deputation to Konkan Railway Corporation Limited (KRCL) as Deputy Chief Mechanical Engineer (Dy. CME) at Belapur for a period of three years. He is an Indian Railway Service of Mechanical Engineers (IRSME) officer.

»» Karnataka reshuffles seven IAS officers

The Karnataka government has transferred seven IAS officers in a fresh administrative reshuffle. Nakul S.S. has been appointed Secretary to the Chief Minister, while Abhiram G. Shankar has been given the additional charge of Additional Secretary (Expenditure), Finance, and Secretary (Expenditure), Finance, alongside his current responsibilities. Dr Ram Prasat Manohar will hold additional charge as Secretary, Tourism Department. Patil Yelagouda Shivanagouda has been assigned additional charge as Managing Director of Karnataka Skill Development Corporation and Karnataka Vocational Training and Skill Development Corporation. Shivaprasad P.R. has been given additional charge as Commissioner, Department of Tourism. Sheikh Tanveer Asif has been appointed Director of the Abdul Nazeer Sab State Institute of Rural Development and Panchayat Raj, Mysore.

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CR earns over ₹2100 crores through Freight loading



Central Railway registered impressive Freight Loading of 21.21 MT (million tonnes) in 8048 rakes during the period April to June 2026. This is against loading of 20.40 MT in 7608 rakes during the corresponding period last year, marking an increase of almost 4 % in respect of tonnage. It also indicates increase of 440 rakes in April-June 2026 as compared to last year. Total Revenue earned through freight loading during the period April to June 2026 amounted to Rs.2143.84 crores. For the period - April to June 2026 Of the total loading of 21.21 MT, Nagpur division has contributed loading of 12.47 MT which is 59% followed by Mumbai division with loading of 5.18 MT which is almost 24%. Contribution by other divisions include loading of 1.85 MT (9 %) by Solapur division, 1.27 MT (6 %) by Bhusaval division and 0.45 MT (2 %) by Pune division. Of the total revenue of Rs.2143.84 crores, the biggest contributor has been Nagpur division with revenue of Rs.1282.73 crores which is almost 60 % followed by Mumbai division with revenue of Rs.491.34 crores which is 23 %. Revenue from other divisions have been Rs.148.50 crores (7 %) by Bhusaval division, Rs.128.89 crores (6 %) by Solapur Division and Rs.92.39 crores (4 %) by Pune division. For the month of June-2026, Freight Loading stood at 7.02 MT (million tonnes) in 2659 rakes against loading of 6.84 MT in 2561 rakes during the same month last year indicating an increase of almost 3% in tonnage and 98 in number of rakes. The revenue earned in the month of June-2026 amounted to Rs.701.33 crores.

9	Mr. Gourav Sharma Add.: Unit-119 Vinayak Vihar Sec-A S No 53/2/1, 53/4/1 And 54P Village Daudkhedi Tehsil And District Ujjain, Ujjain 456001 (M.P.)	₹ 10,05,334/- 45,067/- 7,41,448/- 17,91,849/- as on 31/05/2026	02/07/2026	Unit- A - 119, Vinayak Vihar Sector -A, Village Daudkhedi Tehsil And District Ujjain (M.P.) Boundaries: East : Other Land West : Colony Road, North : Plot No. A-118 South : Plot No. A-120 Plot Area: 63.94 Sq.Mtr.
10	Mr. Shakti Singh Mrs. Surekha Add.: Unit-497 Chinar Lake View S No 763/5/2, Nagar Panchayat Mhow Nimach Road, Near Water Tank, Mhowgaon : Mhow 453441 (M.P.)	₹ 5,55,700/- 97,109/- 1,85,498/- 8,38,307/- as on 31/05/2026	02/07/2026	Unit-497, Chinar Lake View Colony, Phase 1, Nagar Panchayat, Mhowgaon, Mhow (M.P.) Boundaries: East : Colony Road West : Plot No. 503, North : Plot No. 496 South : Plot No. 498 Plot Area : 33.45 Sq.Mtr.
11	Mr. Vivekanand Shukla Add.: Unit-141 Ayushman Hills Hindolia, Near Choupal Sagar, A.B. Road, Mhow, Indore - 453441 (M.P.)	₹ 8,53,667/- as on 30/04/2026	02/07/2026	Unit-141, Ayushman Hills, Gram: Jamali, Tehsil : Mhow (M.P.) Boundaries: East : Colony Road West : Plot No. 152, North : Plot No. 142 South : Plot No. 140, Plot Area : 185.87 Sq.Mtr.
12	Wife/Son/Daughter/Husband of Mr. Anil Yadav [Since deceased] And other known and unknown Legal Heir(s), Legal Representative(s), Successors and Assigns of Mr. Anil Yadav [Since deceased] and Mrs. Gaytri Yadav Add.: Unit 42, Middle Part, Kalyan Sampat Vihar, S No 313/3/1, 313/4/1, Village Nenod, Gandhi Nagar, Indore 452001 (M.P.)	₹ 22,96,968/- as on 31/05/2026	02/07/2026	Unit-42, Middle Part, (Part 2), Kalyan Sampat Vihar, Village : Nenod, Indore (M.P.) Boundaries: East : Plot No. 83, West : Colony Road, North: House On Part 1 On The Remaining Part Of Plot South : House On Part 3 On The Remaining Part Of Plot Plot Area : 55.76 Sq.Mtr.
13	Mr. Santosh Rathore Mrs. Pinki Add.: Flat-508, Floor-5 Highway Karuna Sagar Block 8, Village Kanadia, Teh & Distt. Indore (M.P.)	₹ 15,13,196/- 50,102/- 15,63,298/- as on 30/04/2026	02/07/2026	Flat-508, Floor-5, Highway Karuna Sagar, Block 8, Village Kanadia, Teh & Distt. Indore 452001 (M.P.) Boundaries: East : Open Area West : Passage And Prakostha No. 505, North : Prakostha No. 507 South : Duct And Prakostha No. 509 Flat Area : 88.28 Sq.Mtr.
14	Mrs. Vasanti Tapadia Add.: Flat-320 Trishla Apartment Block A Plot 9/1/1, Vaidya Khyaliram Marg, Biyabani, Rajmohalla, M.G. Road, Indore - 452001 (M.P.)	₹ 31,99,782/- as on 31/05/2026	02/07/2026	Flat No. 320-A, 3rd Floor, Trishla Apartment Block A, Plot 9/1/1, Vaidya Khyaliram Marg, Biyabani Gali, Indore (M.P.) Boundaries: East : Mos West : Passage, North : Flat No. A-319 South : Flat No. B- 301 Flat Area : B/Up- 70.14 Sq.Mtr.
15	Mr. Vibhash Sarkar Mrs. Ananya Sarkar Add.: Flat-C 101, Floor-1, Cosmos City Divine, S No 174/2/4/2, 174/2/4/1, Gram Bicholi Mardana, Sampat Hills, M.G. Road, Indore - 452002	₹ 16,92,481/- 70,904/- 1,52,276/- 90,761/- = 29,06,422/- as on 31/05/2026	02/07/2026	Flat-C-101, Floor-1, Cosmos City, Block Divine, S No 174/2/4/2, 174/2/4/1, Gram - Bicholi Mardana, Indore (M.P.) 452001 Boundaries: East : Open Space Of The Building, West : Prakostha No. C-112 After Common Passage And Staircase, North : Open Space Of The Building South : Prakostha No. C-102 Flat Area : Super B/Up : 91.07 Sq.Mtr.
16	Wife/Son/Daughter/Husband Of Mr. Suresh Chandra Patidar [Since Deceased] And Other Known And Unknown Legal Heir(S), Legal Representative(S), Successors And Assigns Of Mr. Suresh Chandra Patidar And [Since Deceased] And Mrs. Kanchan Bai Add.: Unit-65, Plot 65 Nariman Point Phase-1 Village-Badbad, Ratlam 457001 (M.P.)	₹ 16,17,318/- as on 30/04/2026	02/07/2026	Plot No. - 65, Nariman Point Phase-1, Village-Badbad, Sr. No. 279, 280/1, And 280/2 Ratlam (M.P.) Boundaries: East : Plot No. 38, West : Colony Road, North : Plot No. 64 South : Plot No. 66 Plot Area : 111.63 Sq. Mtrs.
17	Mr. Dhananjay Tiwari Add.: Flat-F-F-15, Orchard Firs Block-B, Floor-1, Indus Satellite Greens Indore-Flats S No 48/1, 48/2, 49, 145/1, 145/2, 168, 215/1, 215/2, 214, 216, 213 Pek, 213 Pek1, 154/1 to 4 219/1 to 2, 157, Indore - 452010 (M.P.)	₹ 13,64,686/- 61,328/- = 14,26,014/- as on 30/06/2026	02/07/2026	Flat-F-F-15, 1st Floor, Orchard-Flowers, Block-B, Indus Satellite Greens, Satellite Junction Colony, Gram : Kelod Hala, Indore 452010 (M.P.) Boundaries: East : F-14 West : Open To Sky And Thereafter Colony Road, North - Open To Sky And Thereafter Colony Road South : F 16 Flat Area B/Up : 65.69 Sq.Mtr.
18	Mrs. Arti Asati Add.: Unit Plot No. 326, Sakar NRI City-II Gram - Arandia District Indore 452001 (M.P.)	₹ 3,29,264/- as on 30/04/2026	02/07/2026	Unit-Plot No.326, Sakar NRI City-II, Gram : Arandiya, Tehsil And Jila : Indore (M.P.) Boundaries: East : Plot No. 327 West : Road, North : Other Land After The Boundary Wall South :Plot No.325 Plot Area : 255.42 Sq.Mtr.
19	Mr. Gaurav Bhatia Mr. Ajay Bhatia Add.: Plot 1089, Omaxe City1 Happy Homes Balyakhedi Gram Balyakhedi Behind Omaxe City Phase I, Indore - 452001 (M.P.)	₹ 2,76,752/- as on 31/05/2026	02/07/2026	Plot No. OHHI 1089, Omaxe City, Happy Homes, Gram : Balyakhedi, Behind Omaxe City Phase I, Indore (M.P.) Boundaries: East : Plot No. 1107, West : Road, North : Plot No. 1090, South : Plot No. 1088 Area : 135.05 Sq.Mtr.
20	Mr. Bhagwati Prasad Akliodiya Mrs. Rekha Akliodiya Add.: E-102 South Part, Amrapali Township, Audyigik Kshet, Indore Sonway Bhensolay Audyigik Indore 453332 (M.P.)	₹ 21,02,845/- as on 13/05/2026	02/07/2026	Amrapali Township, Unit E 102 (South Part), Gram Sonawai Tehsil Mhow Pithampur Indore 452001 (M.P.) Boundaries: East : Plot No. E-108, West : Road, North : Remaining Part Of The Plot, South : Plot No. E-103 Plot Area : 46.46 Sq.Mtr.

*with further interest as applicable, incidental expenses, costs, charges etc incurred till the date of payment and / or realization.

If the said Borrowers shall fail to make payment to HDFC as aforesaid, then HDFC shall proceed against the above Secured Asset(s) / Immovable Property (ies) under Section 13 (4) of the said Act and the applicable Rules entirely at the risk of the said Borrower(s) / Legal Heir(s) / Legal Representative(s) as to the costs and consequences.

The said Borrower(s) / Legal Heir(s) / Legal Representative(s) are prohibited under the said Act to transfer the aforesaid Secured Asset (s) / Immovable Property (ies), whether by way of sale, lease or otherwise without the prior written consent of HDFC. Any person who contravenes or abets contravention of the provisions of the Act or Rules made thereunder shall be liable for imprisonment and/or penalty as provided under the Act.

Sd/- (Authorised Officer)
HDFC Bank Ltd.

Place : Indore, Date : 22.07.2026

Briefs

ERODE
Grandma held for newborn girl's death

A 47-year-old grandmother was arrested allegedly for killing her newborn granddaughter as she feared that her daughter and son-in-law would struggle to raise a second girl, a suspected case of female infanticide, police said on Tuesday.

HAZARIBAG (JHARKHAND)
Elephants trample man to death

A middle-aged man was trampled to death by wild elephants in Jharkhand's Hazaribag district, police said on Tuesday.
The incident took place in Barkangango village in Barkatha police station area on Monday. The victim has been identified as Chintamani Saw, a resident of the same village.

BUDAUN (UP)
'Occultist' sentenced to 10 yrs in jail

A fast-track court in Uttar Pradesh's Budaun district has sentenced an occultist to 10 years' imprisonment and imposed a fine of Rs 1.5 lakh after convicting him in a case involving abduction, wrongful confinement, rape and forced religious conversion, prosecution officials said on Tuesday.
The conviction is the first in the district under provisions relating to forced religious conversion, they said.
Special Judge (Fast Track Court for Crimes Against Women) Neha Garg on Monday convicted Shakir Hussain, a resident of Risoli village in the Bilsa area, after finding him guilty on six charges, including kidnapping, criminal intimidation, wrongful confinement, rape and forced religious conversion.

JAIPUR
Raj HC cracks whip on lawmakers' pending cases

Taking a strict stance on pending criminal cases against former and sitting lawmakers, the Rajasthan High Court has asked the high court administration and government to submit a detailed action plan to expedite the trial and case disposal.
A division bench comprising Acting Chief Justice SP Sharma and Justice Bhuvan Goel issued this order in compliance with the Supreme Court directives on ensuring the speedy conclusion of criminal cases against elected representatives.
The Supreme Court had directed the Chief Justice of the High Court to register the case as a suo moto cognisance and monitor the courts hearing these cases.

— Manish Godha

NOIDA
Missing Noida girls found in Aligarh

Three girls from a government-run children's home in Noida went missing from their school on Tuesday, and were recovered safely within hours from Aligarh, police said.
The girls, aged 10, 12 and 13, are residents of the Rajkiya Baalgrih Balika (Government Children's Home for Girls).
According to police, the girls had reached their school in Sector 51 in the institution's bus along with a female helper.
During lunch break the helper was unable to locate the girls on the school premises and informed the school principal as well as the in-charge of the children's home, following which police were alerted.

Won't leave Bihar even if defeated, says Kishor

Dheeraj Kumar
PATNA

Amid a high-pitch campaign for the Bankipur by-election, Jan Saraaj Party (JSP) founder Prashant Kishor who is making his electoral debut by entering the fray, vowed to stay in Bihar regardless of the poll result.
Kishor, pitted against BJP's Neeraj Kumar Sinha and RJD's Rekha Gupta, made the claim while talking to newsmen.
When reporters asked what he would do if he lost the by-election, Kishor shot back and said, "Even if I lose, we will see. You are not quitting journalism, so come and ask me after I lose. Opponents will keep abusing me, but I will remain in Bihar and continue working here by setting up an ashram." He added that his commitment to Bihar would remain unchanged, irrespective of the by-election result.
Indirectly targeting RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav over his reported foreign trip, the

Kishor, pitted against BJP's Neeraj Kumar Sinha and RJD's Rekha Gupta, made the claim while talking to newsmen

former poll strategist said, "I have not left Bihar. Those busy with opposition politics or other political activities may have gone traveling. I haven't left the state even for a single day."
The by-poll to the Bankipur constituency was necessitated after the incumbent MLA Nitin Nabin vacated the seat following his election to the Rajya Sabha and elevation to the post of national BJP president. BJP has held Bankipur continuously since 1995, making it one of the party's strongest bastions in Bihar. While Kishor has energised the campaign, the key question is whether he can overcome the BJP's loyal vote base.

Zero tolerance for power theft, says Bengal CM

Aritra Singha
KOLKATA

West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Tuesday announced a zero-tolerance policy regarding power theft and pending electricity dues for commercial and industrial consumers.
He instructed power department officials to reduce electricity theft to zero while assuring a humane approach for domestic consumers based on their past payment track records.
To streamline grievance redressal, the state has introduced the Bidyut Prahari application, allowing citizens to report electricity theft and track complaint status without political interference. Adhikari noted that the power sector had suffered neglect under previous administrations but stressed

Suwendu assured residents that low voltage issues in West Bengal would be resolved soon given the state's surplus power

that public service remains the current government's priority.
He assured residents that low-voltage issues in West Bengal would be resolved soon given the state's surplus power capacity.
He also proposed establishing a formal recruitment and transfer policy within the power department. The announcement follows the recent launch of the PM Surya Ghar Scheme aimed at expanding solar energy adoption.

Three members of Hyderabad family die in US road accident

PTI
HYDERABAD

Three members of a family from Hyderabad died and two others were injured in a road accident in the US state of California, according to information received by their kin here on Tuesday.
The vehicle in which the family was travelling collided with another vehicle on Monday night (Indian time), they said.
The deceased were identified as Nazia Salma, her daughter and son, while her husband Shaik Naveed and their younger daughter sustained serious injuries in the accident and were admitted to hospital.

The relatives have asked the EAM to provide emergency visas to them

Naveed from Saidabad here had gone to the United States about 10 years ago. The accident occurred when he was travelling with his wife and children.
Naveed's father, Shaik Abdul Sayeed, said when they contacted his son, they received information regarding the accident from the police there.
He requested the External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar to provide emergency visas to the family members to enable them to travel to America.
Meanwhile, Majlis Bachao Tahreek (MBT) spokesman Amjed Ullah Khan met the family members and appealed to the External Affairs Minister to facilitate immediate issuance of emergency visas to the family members so that they can travel to the US.

BJP complains to EC about PK's expenses

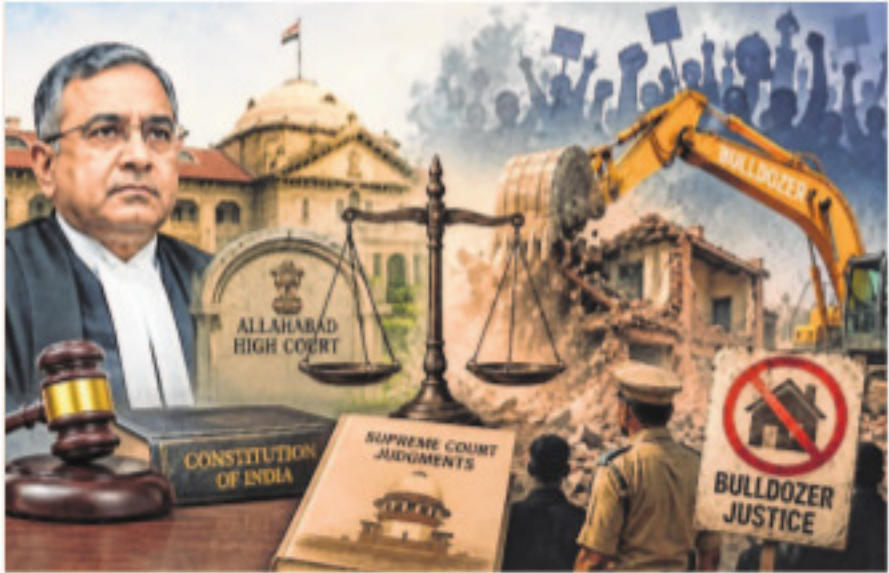
Dheeraj Kumar
PATNA

A BJP delegation on Tuesday met the Election Commission and filed a complaint against Jan Suraaj Party (JSP) founder Prashant Kishor, alleging that he was spending crores of rupees on a social media campaign for the Bankipur by-poll.
Kishor is making electoral debut by contesting the Bankipur by-poll and is pitted against BJP's Neeraj Kumar Sinha and RJD's Rekha Gupta.
The delegation included Bihar education minister Mithilesh Tiwari, MLA Jivesh Mishra, MLC Janak Ram, and BJP national spokesperson Shah Nawaz Hussain.
BJP leaders alleged that election rules were being violated through large-scale spending and demanded an investigation. After meeting officials at the state election office in Patna, Hussain told the newsmen that Kishor was "trying to influence public opinion on social media using money". He alleged that crores of rupees were being spent lavishly on election campaigning.

PULLS UP YOGI GOVT | 'Such demolitions continue with impunity despite SC judgments' Allahabad HC slams 'bulldozer justice'

FPJ News Service
MUMBAI

Justice Atul Sreedharan of the Allahabad High Court on Monday made strong observations against the Uttar Pradesh government's recent "bulldozer actions", saying the State was demolishing the houses of persons accused of offences "to satiate the perceived bloodlust of a society fed on a staple diet of bulldozer justice", reports Live Law.
"The state is certain that the society suffers from collective schadenfreude and shall applaud the state for dispensing vigilante-style summary justice, without adhering to the procedure established by law, and secures pleasure from the misfortune of the other person suffering loss," Justice Sreedharan observed. He stressed that in such a situation, it was for the constitutional courts to evolve jurisprudence that is constitutionally and legally valid.



He said that despite judgments of the Supreme Court, such demolitions continued with impunity "as though these judgments do not exist", or the state believed that defiance of the law laid down by the highest court of the land "shall not visit them with any adverse consequences".
The observations came in a 51-page opinion authored by Justice Sreedharan in a split verdict on a writ petition concerning a Hamirpur family whose properties were targeted by authorities shortly

after a relative was booked under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), the Information Technology (IT) Act, the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, and the Uttar Pradesh Prohibition of Unlawful Religious Conversion Act.
The division bench, also comprising Justice Siddharth Nandan, unanimously held that demolishing homes to punish a suspect is an illegal and retributive abuse of power.

Assam CM inaugurates 1st MBA batch of IIM Guwahati

Digjyoti Lahkar
GUWAHATI

Marking a significant milestone for higher education in the Northeast, Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on July 21 inaugurated the first MBA batch (2026-28) of the Indian Institute of Management (IIM) Guwahati.
The premier institution has commenced operations at a transit campus in Tech City, Bongora, developed at a cost of Rs 39 crore.
Mentored by IIM Ahmedabad, the first batch comprises 52 students representing 18 states. Addressing the gathering, Sarma described the inauguration as the fulfillment of a long-cherished dream for the region.
Expressing gratitude to Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, he stated that IIM Guwahati — the 22nd IIM in the country and second in the Northeast — further strengthens Assam's position as an emerging educational hub.

Ahead of UP polls, free scooty for undergrad girls

PTI
LUCKNOW

Ahead of the 2027 Assembly elections, the Uttar Pradesh Cabinet on Tuesday approved a proposal to provide free scooters to meritorious undergraduate girl students pursuing higher education in the state. The decision was taken at a Cabinet meeting chaired by Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath.
Briefing reporters after the meeting, Higher Education Minister Yogendra Upadhyay said around 50,000 girl students are expected to benefit from the Rani Lakshmi Bai Scooty Yojana this year.
He said the initiative aims to

encourage girls to pursue higher education as part of the government's women empowerment efforts.
Under the scheme, girl students from all state universities, private universities, government colleges affiliated with state universities, aided colleges and self-financed colleges will be eligible.
The benefit will be extended, based on merit, to the top 5% of undergraduate girl students who passed in the 2025-26 academic session from each institution.
The minister said the annual family income of beneficiaries should be below Rs 12 lakh, and obtaining a valid driving licence will be mandatory.



Collegium faces casual criticism from those who don't know its working: CJI

PTI
NEW DELHI

Chief Justice of India **Surya Kant** on Tuesday said the Supreme Court collegium sometimes faces "very casual criticism", particularly by those who do not know about the functioning of the judicial system.
The CJI said that while taking any decision, the collegium has so many important relevant factors which are kept in mind while short-listing judges for appointment to the constitutional courts.
He said that "one of the fac-



tors for the purpose of elevation to the Supreme Court is always the concept of inclusivity and diversity".
The CJI was speaking at a function organised by the Supreme Court Bar Association to felicitate Justice Sheel Nagu, Justice Shree Chandrashekhar,

Justice Sanjeev Sachdeva, Justice Arun Palli and Justice V Mohana, who took oath of office as judges of the apex court last month.
He said sometimes the Supreme Court collegium faced "very casual criticism, and particularly by those people who really do not know about the functioning of the judicial system and how the collegium evolves".
The CJI said he believes that judges who come to the apex court carry the responsibility of maintaining and strengthening the faith and trust of people in the judicial system.

Dhami launches four Haridwar Ganga Corridor projects

PTI
DEHRADUN

Uttarakhand Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami performed the ground-breaking ceremony and laid the foundation stone for four infrastructure projects worth approximately 235 crore under the Haridwar Ganga Corridor project on Tuesday.
At a ceremony in Haridwar, the Chief Minister performed the bhoomi puja for the

Administrative Route Development Project worth Rs 43.25 crore and laid the foundation stones for the Har Ki Pauri-Subhash Ghat Redevelopment Project worth 66.76 crore, the Basic Infrastructure Development Project in the northern area of Har Ki Pauri worth Rs 66.34 crore, and the redevelopment of the Rodi Belwala area worth Rs 58.84 crore.
Dhami described the projects, being executed by the

Uttarakhand Investment and Infrastructure Development Board (UIIDB), as part of a broader vision to develop Haridwar into a world-class spiritual and cultural city.
He said officials had been instructed to complete the projects within the stipulated timeframe while ensuring high quality. Dhami said Haridwar is a centre of faith for millions, a living symbol of Indian culture and a spiritual gateway to Sanatan civilisation.

Bihar govt schools will get land in 6 months: CM

PTI
PATNA

Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Tuesday said government schools in the state that lack permanent buildings would be provided land for their own premises within six months, after several MLAs highlighted the poor condition of government schools during Question Hour in the Assembly.

Check mental health of blackmailer, says HC

PTI
PRAYAGRAJ

Hearing a bail plea, the Allahabad High Court has directed a medical examination of the applicant, who has been accused of obtaining obscene photographs of the victim and blackmailing her, noting that he does not appear to be a person of sound mind.
The order was passed by Justice Arun Kumar Singh Deswal after he reviewed the nature of the filthy mes-

sages and social-media posts made by the applicant.
"On a perusal of the messages and social-media posts sent by the applicant, this court found that the applicant is not a person of sound mind. Therefore, the chief medical officer (CMO), Kaushambi, is directed to conduct his mental examination and keep it on record of the file of this case before the district court concerned," the judge said.
The court was hearing the bail plea of Rahul Kumar Saroj.

winning ways
Akhnoor's 27 'Ignited Minds' crack NEET: Army

PTI
JAMMU

The Army's Akhnoor Ignited Minds initiative has achieved a remarkable milestone, with all 27 students enrolled qualifying NEET here, registering a 100 per cent success rate, a defence spokesman said on Tuesday.
"This outstanding achievement is the result of the dedicated mentorship and unwavering support of the Army, public sector defence com-

pany Armoured Vehicles Nigam Limited (AVNL) and NGO National Integrity and Educational Development Organisation," the spokesman said.
He said the initiative has empowered deserving students from economically disadvantaged backgrounds by providing quality coaching, academic guidance and continuous motivation to help them realise their aspirations of pursuing a career in medicine.
The success of these students

reflects not only their perseverance, hard work and determination in overcoming financial and social challenges, but also the sustained efforts of Crossed Swords Division under Jammu-based White Knight Corps in promoting education and youth empowerment through meaningful community outreach, the spokesman said.
He said the achievement stands as a testament to the transformative impact of collaborative efforts between the Army and its partner

organisations in nurturing talent and creating opportunities for the youth of the region.
It also reinforces the Army's enduring commitment to nation-building through initiatives that foster education, self-reliance and inclusive development, the spokesman said.
Congratulating the successful candidates and their families, the spokesman said their accomplishment serves as an inspiration to aspiring students across the region.



जो कहा वो किया जो सोचा वो हुआ



क्या हिंदू क्या मुसलमान, क्या राम क्या रहीम,
क्या रविन्दर क्या रॉबर्ट सबके लिये समान कानून

मात्र **2 माह** में 27 अप्रैल 2026 को उच्च स्तरीय समिति
गठन के बाद, 21 जुलाई 2026 को विधानसभा में ऐतिहासिक मंजूरी

विधानसभा में पारित समान नागरिक संहिता

21 जुलाई 2026
विधानसभा
में पारित

सर्वसमुदाय का समर्थन

हिन्दू: 95% पुरुष
96% महिलाएं
मुस्लिम: 40% पुरुष
80% महिलाएं
ईसाई: 90% पुरुष
95% महिलाएं
सिख: 93% पुरुष
96% महिलाएं

लैंगिक समानता और अधिकार

91%
ने भेदभावपूर्ण तलाक कानून
हटाने का समर्थन किया
92%
ने बेटियों और माताओं को
संपत्ति में समान अधिकार
का समर्थन किया

ऐतिहासिक जनसमर्थन

93%
ने समान नागरिक संहिता
का समर्थन किया
92%
पुरुष और महिलाएं समान
कानून के पक्ष में

अभूतपूर्व जन-भागीदारी

सुझाव हेतु वेब पोर्टल लॉन्च
3.50 करोड़
संदेश नागरिकों को भेजे गए
10 लाख सुझाव मिले
मध्यप्रदेश के विधायी इतिहास
में पहली बार
जिला और राज्य स्तर पर
50+ वृहद बैठकें
व्यावहारिक सुझाव संकलित
1,134+

27 अप्रैल 2026 उच्च स्तरीय समिति का गठन

7 सदस्यीय उच्च स्तरीय
समिति द्वारा देश के विभिन्न
कानूनों और अन्य राज्यों के
UCC मॉडलों का गहन
तुलनात्मक अध्ययन

प्रदेश की आधी आबादी, सभी बहनों को, दिया उनका हक़



PUBLIC OUTCRY | Police detain Congress party workers along with MLA Amin Patel and Aslam Shaikh during a protest in support of Cockroach Janata Party outside Lok Bhavan

Protests grow stronger; over 900 booked, 12 FIRs

Dhairya Gajara & Poonam Apraj

MUMBAI

The outcry over educational reforms escalated on its third day in Mumbai, culminating in a massive, peaceful demonstration at Dadar's Shivaji Park and Dongri on Tuesday evening. Meanwhile, Mumbai police have booked around 900 people for participating in the unauthorised protests.

Mumbai's youngsters have actively echoed the sentiments of Delhi's Jantar Mantar and are supporting the movement launched by Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) to protest against NEET paper leak.

Driven largely by viral Instagram campaigns, over a thousand citizens and students gathered in Dadar on Tuesday to protest against NEET paper leak, demand justice for the 21 NEET aspirants who died by suicide and to seek accountability from the government.

What unfolded on Tuesday afternoon became a tense game of hide-and-seek between protesters and Mumbai police. Initial plans to gather at Azad Maidan were thwarted by heavy police deployment, while a proposed shift to Nariman Point also failed. Despite the crackdown, the Instagram-



Students gather outside Shivaji Park in support of CJP on Tuesday —Vijay Gohil

driven movement regrouped at Shivaji Park by 5pm, where the crowd swelled to more than 1,000, drawing hundreds of students and citizens despite restrictions.

One of the protesters at Shivaji Park, Faiz Abdulla, 30, said, "Until yesterday, I was asking people to not participate in any protest which did not have necessary permissions but after what happened with the students at Delhi on Monday, I could not stop myself from participating," he said.

The city police have registered 12 FIRs against around 900 individuals for allegedly violating prohibitory orders.

Around seven FIRs were

registered on Monday at Worli, Sion, Kalachowki, Bhoiwada, Dadar, Mahim and Wadala TT police stations. Earlier, five FIRs had been registered between July 18 and July 19 at Azad Maidan, Marine Drive and Shivaji Park police stations for violations of the prohibitory orders issued by the Commissioner of Police.

The highest number of people have been booked at Shivaji Park police station, where over 600 people have been booked. Around 100 people have been booked by Mahim police, 70 at Dadar and 40 have been booked at Sion. Worli police booked 21 people, about 20 individuals

have been booked by Kalachowki police, 20 at Bhoiwada and 25 were booked by Wadala TT police station.

Deputy Commissioner of Police Mahendra Pandit said that on Monday, a group of protesters attempted to stage a demonstration at Chaitya Bhoomi without permission. A case was registered at Shivaji Park police station under Section 189 of the BNS and Sections 37(1)(3) and 135 of the Maharashtra Police Act against around 300 protesters for demonstrating in a restricted area.

In Dongri, Shiv Sena UBT had a gathering to mourn the death of 21 students.

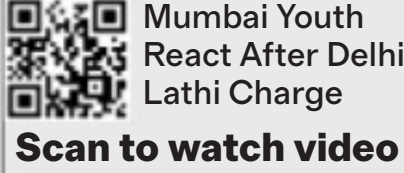
Ambedkar calls for bandh on July 23

Vanchit Bahujan Aghadi chief Prakash Ambedkar on Tuesday appealed to people to observe a statewide bandh on July 23 in protest against the Centre's education policies and the alleged police action against students and supporters during the CJP-led ongoing agitation in Delhi. "The Centre does not want people to be educated as education expands understanding and encourages critical thinking," he said.

Hunger strike by UBT नेता

Expressing solidarity with the ongoing NEET paper leak protest at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi, Shiv Sena (UBT) leader from Ambernath, Dr Janu Mankar, has joined the indefinite hunger strike. The protest is being conducted in a relay format, with participants taking turns to continue the fast.

We Are Not Anti-National:



A health worker at a city-based hospital told The Free Press Journal on condition of anonymity, "I joined the protest in Shivaji Park on Sunday and today when I came to know about the gathering at Azad Maidan, I changed at the hospital and reached the spot. There were youngsters in small groups but the police were not allowing anyone to enter the ground".

Drivers face 5-fold penalty for critical ride cancellations

Abhishek Pathak

MUMBAI

A week after the Maharashtra government implemented a aggregator policy to regulate Ola, Uber and Rapido, one of its key provisions has come into focus: A fivefold penalty for drivers who cancel rides to airports, railway stations and hospitals after accepting a booking. Introduced under the Maharashtra Motor Vehicle Aggregator Rules, 2026, the provision aims to curb last-minute cancellations on time-sensitive trips and improve the reliability of app-based taxi services. The penalty collected from drivers will be credited to the rider's app account.

Under Rule 17, a driver who cancels a ride after accepting it will pay a penalty equal to 10% of the total fare, capped at ₹100. If the driver fails to report within 10 minutes of the expected arrival time, the ride will also be treated as a driver cancellation, attracting the same ₹100 penalty. However, for bookings to airports, railway stations and hospitals, the penalty will be five times the normal driver cancellation penalty.

The rules also seek to balance accountability between drivers and passengers. A rider who cancels a trip without a valid reason must pay a penalty equal to 5% of the total fare, capped at ₹100, credited to the driver's

NEW RULES

Driver who cancels a normal ride after accepting it will be liable to pay a penalty equal to 10% of the total fare, capped at ₹100

If the driver fails to report within 10 minutes of the expected arrival time, the ride will also be treated as a driver cancellation

A rider who cancels a trip without a valid reason will have to pay a penalty equal to 5% of the total fare, capped at ₹100

account. If a cab develops a mechanical fault, the aggregator must arrange an alternate vehicle within 30 minutes in municipal limits and within 60 minutes for inter-city journeys exceeding 100km. Failure to do so will invite penalties. The measure is expected to provide relief to passengers making time-sensitive journeys.

"Many drivers accept bookings but later cancel if they get a better fare. This is especially frustrating when you're rushing to catch a flight, a train or trying to reach a hospital. A fivefold penalty is a welcome step, but it should be enforced strictly," said Ramesh Sharma, a regular app-based cab user.

SC: Local body polls can be held sans 50% quota

Mumbai: The Supreme Court on Tuesday orally said that elections of 20 zilla parishads and 211 panchayat samitis, which are yet to be held in Maharashtra, can be conducted without exceeding the reservation ceiling limit of 50%, legal portal Live Law has reported.

A bench of CJI Surya Kant, Justice Joymalya Bagchi and Justice Vipul Pancholi was dealing with a bunch of petitions related to Maharashtra local body elections, which remained held up between 2022 and 2025 over issues pertaining to reservation for Other Backward Classes (OBCs).

In May 2025, the Court had passed an interim order paving the way for the local body polls to be held in the state. Subsequently, however, certain applications were filed before it, contending that the ceiling limit of 50% reservation was breached in case of some local bodies. This led the Court to later observe that the Maharashtra authorities misconstrued its 2025 order and that the 50% limit was not to be exceeded.

The bench noted that the local body polls are not required to be conducted by the ECI. Therefore, it was for the State Election Commission to take up the issue of logistical support with the ECI.

SC noted that the local body polls are not required to be conducted by ECI

UBT moves SC on six MPs' merger with Shinde Sena

New Delhi: The Shiv Sena (UBT) faction on Tuesday approached the Supreme Court challenging Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla's decision of recognising the merger of six of its MPs with the Eknath Shinde-led Shiv Sena.

The matter was mentioned for urgent listing before a bench headed by Chief Justice Surya Kant by senior advocate Devadatt Kamat, appearing for the UBT faction.

Seeking an early hearing, Kamat told the court that the

party's functioning in Parliament had come to "an absolute standstill" after the Speaker recognised the merger during the ongoing Parliament session. "The Speaker has recognised their merger with some other

political party. This was intended for the Parliament session. I am seeking a hearing tomorrow (Wednesday)," he said. When asked about the urgency, the Supreme Court said it would consider the request for listing but did not

commit to hearing the matter immediately. "Can't promise. Will see," the bench observed.

Kamat told the bench that on July 18, the Speaker gave approval to the merger of six Shiv Sena (UBT) MPs with the Shiv Sena led by Shinde.

BMC to empanel 29 infra project tech consultants

FPJ News Service

MUMBAI

The BMC plans to empanel 29 technical consultancy firms for five years to oversee major bridge, flyover and tunnel projects, introducing a system that penalises consultants for design errors that result in repeated modifications or additional costs.

The proposal, to be tabled before the civic standing

committee on Thursday, caps consultancy fees at ₹3.5 crore for most projects and limits design variations or additional costs arising from consultant lapses to 15% of the project value. Breaching the threshold could attract a penalty equivalent to 10% of the consultancy fee, stated the proposal.

The move comes after a string of infrastructure controversies, including criticism

Caps consultancy fees at ₹3.5 cr

Limits design variations or additional costs arising from consultant lapses to 15% of project value

Breaching threshold could attract a penalty equivalent to 10% of consultancy fee

over the uneven surface of the newly inaugurated Minaltai Gore flyover in Goregaon, the Vikhroli railway overbridge opening without a central divider and pedestrian facilities and the failure of the two arms of the Gopal Krishna Gokhale Bridge in Andheri to align during reconstruction.

Of the 31 firms that submitted bids for empanelment, 29 were shortlisted after scrutiny of their technical expert-

ise and credentials. Tata Consulting Engineers, Spectrum Techno Consultants and Green Design and Engineering Services are among the short-listed firms.

The consultants will prepare project designs, identify engineering challenges before construction and recommend corrective measures during execution to prevent design failures and delays.

Officials liable for midway project cancellations: HC

Urvi Mahajani

MUMBAI

The Bombay High Court has observed that government and civic officials who take illegal decisions to abruptly cancel public projects midway should be held personally liable for the financial consequences instead of burdening taxpayers.

The observation came while a bench of Acting Chief Justice Ravindra Ghuge and Justice Gautam Ankhad was hearing a petition filed by SMS Ltd over the suspension of a ₹122-crore robotic parking project near the Mumbadevi Temple in south Mumbai.

The BMC had awarded the contract for the proposed 17-storey automated parking facility. However, work on the

The observation came while the court was hearing a plea over the suspension of a ₹122cr robotic parking project

project was stopped last year. The contractor claimed it suffered huge losses because of the sudden halt and has initiated arbitration proceedings.

"In such matters, authorities like a corporation, state instrumentalities or even the state cancel a project midway through, or issue a stop-work notice. This causes tremendous loss to the state exchequer because the project has already progressed," the bench observed.

Affected contractors are

forced to seek arbitration or damages, and any compensation awarded is ultimately paid from public funds, the court added.

Advocate Madhuri Nalluri, appearing for the BMC, informed the court that the municipal corporation was "not inclined" to stop the project.

According to the BMC, it had written to the state government several times seeking permission to resume the project from the stage where it was paused, but a decision is still awaited.

The High Court allowed the contractor to amend its petition if a fresh tender includes the same parking project. It directed the BMC and the state government to file their replies before the next hearing on August 7.

Apex court to hear spy case

New Delhi: The Supreme Court has agreed to hear a plea of Uttar Pradesh police challenging a Bombay High Court ruling absolving Brahmos aerospace engineer Nishant Agarwal of charges of espionage and the Official Secrets Act.

A bench of Justices Sanjay Kumar and Sanjeev Sachdeva issued notice on a plea of UP's Anti-Terrorist Squad (ATS) challenging the order of the high court on December 1 last year which had absolved Agarwal of major charges.

The bench, in its order dated July 13, said, "Issue notice, returnable on August 31, 2026." The case, initially filed by the Uttar Pradesh ATS and heard in Lucknow, was later transferred to Nagpur as it was considered the place of the alleged offence. Agarwal got bail in the case in 2023.

The high court, however, found that Agarwal illegally stored sensitive data.

Aggrieved by the high court order, the UP government approached the apex court challenging it.

On June 3, 2024, the Nagpur district court sentenced Agarwal to life term under the Official Secrets Act for spying for Pakistan's intelligence agency ISI.

Agarwal was also fined ₹3,000.

Maha ranks 2nd in green aviation

Dhairya Gajara

MUMBAI

Maharashtra has emerged as the second-leading state in India for green aviation infrastructure, boasting 10 operational airports running completely on 100% renewable energy. According to state-wise data submitted by the Ministry of Civil Aviation (MoCA) in the Rajya Sabha, Maharashtra is surpassed only by Uttar Pradesh, which leads the country with 12 green-powered airports.

Nationwide, a total of 106

airports – comprising 99 Airports Authority of India (AAI) facility bases and seven private or joint-venture airports – have successfully transitioned to 100% renewable energy reliance. The figures were disclosed by Minister of State for Civil Aviation Murlidhar Mohol in a written response to a question in Rajya Sabha on Monday, regarding policies promoting green energy adoption across Indian airports.

Following the inauguration of Navi Mumbai International Airport late last year,

Maharashtra currently has 16 operational airports, just three less than Uttar Pradesh's 19. Out of the 16 airports, 10 have shifted to complete use of renewable energy.

The data presented in Parliament demonstrated significant headway in decarbonising India's civil aviation footprint. While Uttar Pradesh and Maharashtra top the tally, states like Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, and Rajasthan have also made substantial strides in converting air terminals to green power.

Melghat's deadly deficit: Roads, doctors and livelihood

PART II | Govt attributes the shortage of doctors to their unwillingness to serve in remote region despite higher incentives

Urvi Mahajani

MUMBAI

Healthcare infrastructure continues to remain one of Melghat's biggest challenges. A proposed 300-bed hospital at Dharni, promised years ago, is yet to be built, while several primary health centres remain understaffed or non-functional.

"When I started practice as a lawyer, the state had promised a hospital in Dharni. My tenure as a judge is to come to an end. But the hospital has not come up," Justice Ravindra Ghuge remarked during a hearing in March.

The government has attributed the shortage of doctors to their unwillingness to serve in the remote region despite higher incentives. Advocate Jugalkishor Gilda, however, argued that doctors avoid postings because basic facilities, including accommodation, are unavailable.

The shortage of specialists has also drawn judicial attention. In December, the Bombay High Court directed the state to appoint a gynaecologist and paediatrician in every public health centre in Melghat, either on contract or through deputation. Despite the order, peti-

30 years of HC watch, Melghat woes continue

A batch of PILs was filed between 1992 and 1993, highlighting chronic malnutrition, child deaths plaguing the tribal region in Amravati dist

Urvi Mahajani

MUMBAI

While several parts of Maharashtra are battling floods following incessant rains, other regions continue to grapple with drought conditions



When I started practice as a lawyer, the state had promised a hospital in Dharni. My tenure as a judge is to come to an end. But the hospital has not come up," Justice Ravindra Ghuge had remarked during a hearing in March

—Justice Ravindra Ghuge

Melghat to a hospital in Amravati after specialist treatment was unavailable locally.

Advocate Uday Warunjikar, representing one of the petitioners, also pointed to the lack of paramedical staff, sonography machines and language

barriers between tribal patients and healthcare workers.

The issue of coordination among government departments has troubled the court for years. In a significant 2015 order, the bench noted that welfare schemes in Melghat and other sensitive tribal projects suffered because of poor coordination between departments. The court constituted a core committee to improve coordination. Petitioners, however, say the committee does not meet regularly, and an audit ordered in 2018 found little improvement.

Livelihood has remained another recurring issue. The

state recently informed the High Court that over ₹135 crore had been paid as wages in the two Melghat talukas during the past year.

Despite decades of monitoring, repeated directions and periodic reviews, the High Court continues to hear the same issues that first brought Melghat into judicial focus more than 30 years ago – a stark reminder that policy announcements and budget allocations have yet to translate into lasting change for one of Maharashtra's most vulnerable tribal regions.

(This is the last of the two-part series)



Work is underway on Mumbai's first travelator-equipped skywalk, which will provide direct connectivity between the Sant Gadge Maharaj Chowk Monorail station and the Mahalaxmi Metro station on Metro Line 3 – Salman Ansari

Kolhapur set to get international cricket stadium

Kalpesh Mhamunkar

MUMBAI

The Maharashtra Government on Tuesday signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with the Kolhapur District Cricket Association (KDCA) to build an international-standard cricket stadium and multi-sports hub in Kolhapur. The agreement was executed at Mantralaya in the presence of Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis along with Deputy Chief Minister and Sports Minister Sunetra Ajit Pawar. Under the deal, 12.76 hectares (31.90 acres) of state land at Vikaswadi in Karveer taluka has been transferred to the KDCA. Designed to meet BCCI and ICC standards, the planned stadium will accommodate nearly 35,000 spectators. The complex will also feature facilities for boxing, judo, archery, wrestling, swimming, table tennis and fencing, in addition to cricket. The project will include a modern pavilion, practice grounds, an indoor training centre, a sports science centre, a clubhouse, floodlights, a cricket museum, parking, internal roads, drainage, solar power systems and security infrastructure.

AREA
12.76 hectares
SEATING CAPACITY
35,000

PCMC ROAD COLLAPSE | Commuters forced to take a 3-4 km-long detour

Ravet-Kiwale rd caves in, residents demand repairs

Varad Bhatkhande
PIMPRI-CHINCHWAD

A key road connecting Ravet and Kiwale has remained closed for more than a week after a portion of it caved in following heavy rains, forcing commuters to take a three- to four-kilometre detour. The incident has raised questions over the quality of the road, which was constructed only a few months ago.

The road, located near Narmada Park Housing Society, caved in by around four to five feet during the heavy rains earlier this month. Residents alleged that despite the damage being reported several days ago, the Pimpri-Chinchwad Municipal Corporation (PCMC) has not started repair work. The closure has caused inconvenience to commuters from the Akurdi Station area who use the route as a shortcut to Ravet, Kiwale, Dehu Road and the bypass.

A resident of Narmada Park Housing Society said the road



is the only direct route for many people in the area. He alleged that the road collapsed because rainwater regularly accumulates at the spot and urged the civic body to undertake repairs immediately. He also questioned how a newly constructed road could develop such extensive damage within just a few months.

Responding to the issue, PCMC Assistant Commissioner and A Regional Ward Officer Nivedita Gharge said an inspection had been carried out at the site. She said the civic body has issued a notice to the concerned builder seeking an explanation. "Appropriate action will be taken after receiving the

builder's reply and a report from the civil department," she added.

According to the notice issued by the A Regional Office, municipal officials found that debris had been dumped illegally in the natural nallah bed and its buffer zone near Sector 26, Plot No. 156. The notice stated that the dumping had obstructed the

Appropriate action will be taken after receiving the builder's reply and a report from the civil department
— Nivedita Gharge, PCMC Assistant Commissioner

natural flow of rainwater and could lead to flooding in the area during heavy rainfall.

The notice directed the person concerned to remove the debris immediately, warning that legal action would be initiated under the Maharashtra Regional and Town Planning Act and relevant municipal rules if the directions were not complied with.

Meanwhile, local residents have demanded that the damaged road be repaired on a war footing to restore normal traffic movement, prevent further inconvenience to commuters and ensure such incidents do not recur.

Moshi residents give PCMC 3-mth deadline



Varad Bhatkhande
PIMPRI-CHINCHWAD

Residents of Moshi have warned that they will not allow garbage from across Pimpri-Chinchwad to be dumped at the Moshi waste depot if their long-pending demands are not addressed within three months. The warning came during a meeting held on Monday following the recent waste-to-energy plant accident that claimed several lives.

The meeting was held at the Pimpri-Chinchwad Municipal Corporation (PCMC) headquarters in the presence of Mayor Ravi Landge and Municipal Commissioner Dr Vijay Suryawanshi. Residents demanded that the civic body identify an alternative site for the Moshi garbage depot and

develop the reserved waste management site at Punawale. According to those present, the administration assured them that alternatives would be explored within three months.

The meeting was attended by Standing Committee Chairman Abhishek Barne, Law Committee Chairperson Sujata Borate, Ward Chairperson Archana Saste, corporators Sarika Gaikwad and Sarika Bohade, former Deputy Mayor Sharad Borhade, former corporators Dhananjay Alhat and Manda Alhat, social activists and a large number of Moshi residents.

Residents said the recent accident had heightened concerns over public safety and environmental hazards. They demanded strict legal action against those responsible,

adequate compensation for the families of the deceased, free medical treatment for the injured, and government or municipal jobs for one eligible member of each affected family. They also sought a permanent solution to the Moshi garbage depot issue.

Commissioner Dr Vijay Suryawanshi said the administration had taken the demands seriously and directed the concerned departments to act on them. He assured residents that the issues would be resolved in a phased manner without delaying action related to the accident.

Mayor Landge said ensuring justice for the victims' families, taking action against those responsible and resolving the concerns of Moshi residents remained the civic body's priority.

Metro Line 3 to go fully digital

Varad Bhatkhande
PUNE

Commuters travelling on Pune Metro Line 3 will be able to use multiple ticketing options, including the National Common Mobility Card (NCMC), mobile app tickets, WhatsApp QR tickets, ticket vending machines and manual ticket counters when passenger services begin.

An advanced Automatic Fare Collection (AFC) system has been installed at the 12 stations opening in the first phase to ensure faster passenger movement. Each station will have five AFC gates, including a wider gate for differently abled passengers.

Metro Line 3 will support the NCMC under the Centre's 'One Nation One Card' initiative, allowing commuters to travel on Metro Line 3, Pune Metro Lines 1 and 2, and metro networks in other cities using a

single card.

Passengers can also book tickets through the Pune Metro mobile app. Initially, the app will offer separate booking options for Maha Metro Lines 1 and 2 and Metro Line 3. After the integration of all three lines at District Court station, commuters will be able to book end-to-end journeys across the entire Pune Metro network through the same platform.

The metro will also support QR-based ticketing through WhatsApp, while ticket vending machines and manual counters will be available at every station. Multiple payment modes, including cash, UPI, debit cards and other digital payment options, will be accepted.

A spokesperson for Pune Metro Line 3 said the ticketing system has been designed to offer a seamless, technology-driven and commuter-friendly travel experience.



Jejuri temple trustee among 3 booked in fake PMC job scam

Ankit Shukla
PUNE

The Pune Police have registered a case against three persons, including a trustee of the Jejuri temple, for allegedly cheating a job aspirant of 45 lakh by promising a permanent job in the Pune Municipal Corporation (PMC) using forged appointment letters, fake official seals, counterfeit signatures of senior civic officials and fabricated PMC letterheads, officials said on Tuesday.

The complaint was filed by Shalaka Vinayak Ghoge (49), Superintendent of the General Administration Department of the PMC and a resident of Baner-Sus Road, at the Shivajinagar Police Station.

Based on the complaint, police have booked Shivanand Balasaheb Patil, a peon in the PMC's Education Department, Namita

Govardhan Bansode, and Rajendra Baban Khedekar, a trustee of the Jejuri temple. The alleged offences took place between March 2022 and July 2026 at the PMC and other locations in Pune. Patil was posted as a peon at the Khashaba Jadhav Sports Complex on Tilak Road.

According to the police, the accused lured unemployed candidates by assuring them of permanent jobs in various PMC departments. They allegedly collected huge sums of money from job seekers and prepared forged PMC letterheads, counterfeit seals, fake signatures of senior civic officials and fabricated appointment letters to make the documents appear genuine.

In one such case, the trio allegedly promised a youth from Patan a job as a Junior Engineer in the PMC and collected 45 lakh from him on different occasions. They

allegedly issued him a fake appointment order bearing forged signatures of the PMC Deputy Commissioner (General) and the Administrative Officer of the Building Department, along with the PMC's official emblem and watermark, to deceive him.

Police said the accused accepted money from candidates through both cash and cheques. Victims were repeatedly assured that their appointments had been finalised, but no jobs were actually provided.

Investigators suspect that more people may have been involved in the racket. Police are examining financial transactions, bank records, forged documents and other evidence to identify additional accused and determine the full extent of the scam.

Further investigation is underway.

Former cop gets bail in ₹30 L bribery case

Ankit Shukla
PUNE

A special court in Pune has granted bail to former Assistant Police Inspector Vaishali Totewar, who was arrested by the Anti-Corruption Bureau (ACB) for allegedly demanding and accepting a ₹30 lakh bribe in connection with an inquiry while she was posted with the Economic Offences Wing (EOW), officials said on Tuesday.

According to the prosecution, Totewar had been assigned to investigate a complaint during her tenure with the EOW. It is alleged that she

demand a bribe of ₹30 lakh from the complainant in exchange for submitting a favourable inquiry report, taking action against the opposing party, and helping the complainant regain possession of disputed land.

The ACB alleged that Totewar initially accepted ₹2 lakh from the complainant. She was subsequently promoted and transferred to another post. Following her transfer, Pune Police Commissioner Amitesh Kumar relieved her from duty. The very next day, she was allegedly caught accepting the remaining ₹28 lakh through a private intermediary, leading

to her arrest.

Seeking bail, defence counsel Adv Pratap Pardeshi argued that the alleged bribe amount was not recovered directly from Totewar and that the investigation had been substantially completed. The defence contended that further custodial interrogation was unnecessary.

After hearing both sides, Special Judge DR Shetty granted bail to Totewar on a personal recognisance bond of ₹75,000.

Adv Suhas Kolhe assisted the defence during the proceedings. Further legal proceedings in the case are underway.



Campus Kick

The FIFA World Cup may be over, but the passion for football remains alive as students play a match at the Abasaheb Garware College ground in Pune

Pic: Anand Chaini

Monsoon magic draws tourists to Mahabaleshwar, Panchgani

Rambhau Jagtap
MAHABALESHWAR

The world-famous hill stations of Mahabaleshwar and Panchgani, nestled in the Sahyadri ranges, are witnessing a massive surge in monsoon tourism, with thousands of visitors flocking to the twin destinations to experience their scenic beauty.

Pleasant weather, intermittent showers, rolling white mist draping the hills, gushing waterfalls and lush green valleys have transformed the region into a paradise for nature lovers. Tourists are arriving in large numbers to soak in the breathtaking views, enjoy the refreshing rains and experience the serene atmosphere that has earned Mahabaleshwar the title of the 'Kashmir of Maharashtra.'

Popular attractions such as Parsi Point, Bhilar Waterfall, Sydney Point and Table Land in Panchgani—Asia's second-largest volcanic plateau—as well as Arthur Seat Point and Elephant's Head Point in Mahabaleshwar are witness-



ing heavy footfall. Visitors are enjoying leisurely walks across Table Land while embracing the cool rain, drifting mist and panoramic valley views.

The pleasant weather has also boosted business for local vendors, with tourists relishing roasted corn, hot chickpeas, steaming cups of tea and other roadside delicacies while enjoying the scenic surroundings. Markets in both hill stations are bustling as visitors shop

for the region's famous strawberries, honey, jams, jellies, fruit syrups and other local products, providing a significant boost to the local economy.

However, the sharp rise in tourist arrivals has led to severe traffic congestion across both hill stations. Long queues of vehicles have become a common sight on roads leading to major tourist spots, while narrow roads and improper parking have further worsened the situ-

ation. Minor arguments among motorists have also been reported at several locations due to traffic snarls.

Despite the congestion, Mahabaleshwar and Panchgani continue to remain among Maharashtra's most sought-after monsoon destinations, offering visitors an unforgettable blend of mist-covered hills, cascading waterfalls, cool weather and breathtaking natural beauty.

Siya & Chetan planned to 'cripple' Ketan first: Cops

FPJ News Service
PUNE

The investigation into the alleged murder of Ketan Agarwal at Lohagad Fort has revealed that the accused, Siya Goyal and Chetan Chaudhary, had initially planned to seriously injure him in a staged accident before allegedly deciding to kill him, according to police sources.

Investigators said the duo first intended to leave Agarwal permanently disabled by making the incident appear accidental. Police

believe they wanted the injuries to provide a reason to cancel Agarwal and Goyal's planned Bali trip and their upcoming wedding without raising suspicion.

According to the investigation, the accused discussed staging a fake accident or robbery in which Agarwal would suffer life-altering injuries. Police claimed Goyal believed that if Agarwal lost a limb, convincing her family to call off the marriage would become easier. Investigators also alleged that she searched online to check whether slow poison could be detected dur-

ing an investigation.

Police said the duo surveyed several locations, including Tiger Point and Visapur Fort, before selecting Lohagad Fort. They allegedly visited the fort on May 31 to study the terrain but did not act. A second attempt on June 14 was also abandoned.

Investigators further claimed that between June 14 and June 18, Goyal and Chaudhary rehearsed the act at Beverly Hills in Pune before allegedly carrying out the murder at Lohagad Fort on June 18. The investigation is ongoing.

17-year-old hacked to death

Ankit Shukla
PUNE

A 17-year-old boy was allegedly hacked to death by a group of seven minors near Katraj Lake on Monday night over an old rivalry.

The deceased has been identified as Ganesh Ravindra Malve (17), a resident of Katraj village. According to the FIR, the incident occurred at around 10pm on July 20 on

the road near Katraj Katta Hotel, opposite Katraj Lake.

Police said Malve and his friend, Ganesh Ramdas Chavan (22), the complainant in the case, were waiting to collect Malve's mobile phone, which had been given for repair. At that time, a group of seven juveniles allegedly confronted Malve over an old dispute. According to the police, the accused, all minors from Katraj, allegedly acted in fur-

therance of a pre-planned conspiracy and attacked Malve with sharp-edged iron weapons, inflicting multiple injuries to his head, face and hands. He sustained grievous injuries and died in the assault. A case has been registered at the Bharati Vidyapeeth Police Station under Sections 103 (murder), 61, 189(2), 189(4), 190, 191, 191(2) and 191(3) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS),

Tourist dies after Naneghat fall

Ankit Shukla
PUNE

A tourist who fell into a deep gorge at the Naneghat mountain pass in Pune district has been found dead after an extensive search operation that continued overnight.

The deceased has been identified as Datta Vinayak Londhe (22), a resident of Pargaon Shingve in Ambegaon taluka.

According to officials, Londhe was visiting the popular tourist destination in the western part of Junnar taluka on Monday when he reportedly slipped and fell from a cliff near the viewpoint known as 'Nana's Thumb' (Nanacha Angtha) amid dense fog and strong winds.

Rescue teams, along with officials from the Forest Department, launched a search operation immediately after the incident. The youth's location was eventually traced using a thermal drone deployed by the Forest Department. On Tuesday morning, rescuers retrieved the body from the steep gorge after a challenging operation. The incident has once again highlighted the risks associated with visiting hill forts and cliff viewpoints during the monsoon season,

Briefs

VALSAD

IMD issues red alert for Valsad, Navsari

Heavy rainfall is set to intensify across South Gujarat as the India Meteorological Department (IMD) has issued a red alert for Valsad and Navsari for the next two days, warning of very heavy to extremely heavy rainfall. Surat, Tapi and Dang remain under an orange alert, while several districts are on yellow alert. The IMD has forecast widespread rain across Gujarat until July 27, driven by an active monsoon trough, cyclonic circulations and strong southwesterly winds. Authorities have advised residents in vulnerable areas to remain alert as the risk of flooding, waterlogging and rain-related disruptions remains high.

GANDHINAGAR

IPE Global signs MoU for She Works initiative

IPE Global, a leading international development consultancy, announced the signing of a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with the Gujarat Skill Development Mission (GSDM), Government of Gujarat, to advance the She Works initiative, an initiative dedicated to strengthening young women's participation in skilling and paid employment. The MoU was exchanged at the World Youth Skills Day celebrations held under the Namo Gujarat Kaushalya & Rozgar Mission (NGKRM), in the presence of Lochan Sehra, Secretary, Labour, Skill Development and Employment Department, Government of Gujarat. As per the press release, under the five-year, non-financial partnership, IPE Global will provide pro bono technical assistance to GSDM to strengthen the delivery of state skilling schemes and expand employment outcomes for young women.

RAJKOT

11 eateries sealed, 476 kg of stale food destroyed

The Food Department of the Rajkot Municipal Corporation (RMC) carried out a major enforcement drive against food adulteration and unhygienic practices across the city, inspecting 64 food establishments and restaurants. During the drive, officials destroyed 476 kg of stale and inedible food on the spot after finding serious hygiene violations and unfit food items. The civic body also issued show-cause notices to 29 establishments for violating hygiene, food storage and licensing norms, and collected administrative penalties amounting to Rs 75,500. As part of the action under the Food Safety and Standards Act (FSSAI), officials collected four food samples for laboratory analysis and sealed 11 establishments that were found to have serious violations.

SURAT

SMC water supply to be disrupted

Residents in several parts of Surat will face disruption in water supply on July 23 as the Surat Municipal Corporation (SMC) has announced a temporary shutdown of the Dindoli Water Distribution Station for planned electrical maintenance by Dakshin Gujarat Vij Company Limited (DGVC-L). According to the civic body, DGVC-L will undertake installation and maintenance work on the 11 KV power supply system at the Dindoli Water Distribution Station campus in the South-East Zone (Limbayat). As a result, water supply from the Dindoli Pumping Station will remain suspended or available at very low pressure between 10:30 am and 5:00 pm. The disruption will affect several residential areas in the Limbayat, Udhna-A and Udhna-B zones.

EMISSION

Gujarat records its biggest annual carbon emission reduction in FY 2025-26 as renewable energy generation reaches an all-time high of 67,655 million units

Gujarat prevents 179 million tonnes of carbon emissions in five years

FPJ News Service

GANDHINAGAR

Gujarat has achieved a major milestone in its clean energy journey by recording the highest-ever annual reduction in carbon emissions during FY 2025-26. The state prevented 49.79 million tonnes of carbon dioxide equivalent (mtCO₂e) from entering the atmosphere while generating a record 67,655 million units of green power, reinforcing its position as a national leader in renewable energy and climate action.

The achievement comes on the back of rapid expansion in solar, wind and other renewable energy sources, supported by the Gujarat government's ambitious green energy policies.

"The state's consistent investment in renewable energy is helping reduce dependence on fossil fuels while pre-



moting sustainable economic growth and environmental conservation," officials said.

Over the last five years, Gujarat has prevented a cumulative 179 million tonnes of carbon emissions, a remarkable achievement considering the state generates nearly 442 million tonnes of greenhouse gases annually. The reduction is equivalent to almost 40% of Gujarat's annual

greenhouse gas emissions, highlighting the growing impact of its clean energy initiatives.

Environmental experts said carbon emission reduction has direct benefits beyond climate protection. Lower emissions improve air quality, reduce pollution-related health risks and help mitigate the impact of extreme weather events such as heatwaves, floods and erratic rainfa-

MANTRA joins UNEP global textile sustainability project

FPJ News Service

SURAT

Surat has achieved another milestone on the global stage, with the city's textile expertise receiving recognition from the United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP). Rajinikanth S. Bachkaniwala, President of MANTRA, an institution supported by the Ministry of Textiles, Government of India, has been invited to serve as an expert reviewer for a prestigious global research project on textile sustainability.

The invitation was extended by Laila Petri of Future Earth Lab, which is leading the UNEP-backed study titled "Assessment of Pathways to Sustainability and Circularity in Textiles." The project aims to identify sustainable pathways for the global textile industry through 2050.

The selection of Bachkaniwala reflects his extensive contribution to the textile sector and highlights Surat's growing influence in shaping global sustainability policies.

"This invitation is a proud



moment not only for MANTRA but also for Surat and the Indian textile industry. It reflects the confidence the global community has in our expertise and practical experience," Bachkaniwala said.

The research project will examine the environmental, social and economic impact of the textile industry over the next 25 years. It will also evaluate opportunities to build a circular economy across the entire textile value chain, including Manmade Cellulosic Fibre (MMCF) production.

Future Earth Lab has sought technical feedback, in-

dustry insights and production-related data from MANTRA to ensure that the study reflects practical industry realities and supports evidence-based policymaking.

"The participation of Indian experts will help ensure that the global assessment represents the challenges and opportunities faced by major textile-producing nations," the project team noted.

Industry leaders believe the recognition reinforces Surat's transformation from being only a textile manufacturing hub to becoming a key contributor to global sustainability initiatives.

ll. "Renewable energy is one of the most effective tools to combat climate change because it significantly reduces reliance on coal and other fossil fuels," environmental experts noted.

The state's progress has been driven by key initiatives, including the Integrated Renewable Energy Policy 2026, Green Hydrogen Policy and Gujarat Pumped Storage Policy. These programmes have accelerated investment in clean energy infrastructure while strengthening Gujarat's transition towards a low-carbon economy.

The Energy Department, along with Gujarat Urja Vikas Nigam Limited (GUVNL), Gujarat Energy Development Agency (GEDA) and Gujarat Power Corporation Limited (GPCL), has played a pivotal role in expanding renewable energy generation across the state.

LiDAR alone won't save Surat from floods, expert warns SMC

Melvyn Thomas

SURAT

The Surat Municipal Corporation's (SMC) decision to rely on LiDAR technology for flood protection has drawn sharp criticism from urban flood management experts, who argue that the move risks creating a false sense of preparedness while ignoring the real causes of flooding in the coastal city.

Urban Flood Management Specialist Dr. Pankaj Gandhi has warned that although LiDAR (Light Detection and Ranging) is a powerful technology for mapping land elevations and creating three-dimensional terrain models, it is not a complete flood management solution for Surat, where flooding is driven by a complex combination of rainfall, tidal influence, Tapi River flows, siltation, drainage failures and climate change.

"LiDAR is an excellent survey tool, but it is only one piece of the puzzle. Using LiDAR alone for flood prevention is scientifically inadeq-

BJP MP Govind Dholakia slams Surat roads, exposes civic failure

FPJ News Service

SURAT

The BJP's much-publicised model of governance in Surat has come under intense scrutiny after Rajya Sabha MP and diamond tycoon Govind Dholakia publicly exposed the city's crumbling road infrastructure. His viral video from the Ichhapore-to-Surat Airport stretch has not only embarrassed the Surat Municipal Corporation (SMC) but has also raised uncomfortable questions about the accountability of the BJP's own administration.

As per the report published in a local website, travelling to Surat Airport on July 19, Dholakia recorded the muddy, pothole-ridden road from his moving vehicle and remarked, "Surat is in a shameful condition. No one's stomach water is moving," expressing frustration over the civic apathy.

The video quickly spread across social media, trigger-



ing criticism from citizens and the opposition. Many questioned why a ruling party MP had to resort to recording videos to highlight problems that thousands of commuters face every day.

Dholakia's personal assistant, Bhavesh, later clarified that the video was originally shared privately with Mayor Maya Mavani, Standing Committee Chairman Rajan Patel, Municipal Commissioner M. Nagarajan and city BJP president Paresh Patel.

"Govind Kaka had sent

the video only to improve the situation and alert the administration. We do not know how it reached social media," he said.

The controversy has become particularly significant because the damaged road connects Surat Airport and the Surat Diamond Bourse, one of the world's largest diamond trading hubs. Industrialists have repeatedly complained that poor infrastructure damages Surat's global reputation and inconveniences investors and business visitors.



uate and may lead to flawed planning," Dr. Gandhi said.

According to the expert, Surat's biggest flood threats arise from the interaction between intense rainfall, high tides in the Arabian Sea, the backwater effect in the Tapi River, blocked stormwater drains and rapid urbanisation. None of these dynamic factors can be fully analysed through LiDAR mapping alone.

Dr. Gandhi pointed out that LiDAR cannot assess the underwater condition of riverbeds, creek depths or sediment accumulation, which directly affect the water-carrying capacity of the Tapi

River. He said hydrographic surveys and echo sounding are essential to understand these hidden risks.

He also noted that the technology cannot inspect underground stormwater pipelines for blockages, damaged sections, illegal connections or pumping station performance.

"Surface mapping does not reveal what is happening below the ground. A city floods because its drainage system fails, not because its terrain is unknown," he said.

The expert further stressed that LiDAR cannot predict tidal backwater effects, simu-

Bhiwandi company director sent to Lajpore jail in ₹10 lakh cheque bounce case

FPJ News Service

SURAT

A director of a Maharashtra-based company has been sent to Lajpore Central Jail, Surat, after a court rejected his plea seeking cancellation of a Non-Bailable Warrant (NBW) in a cheque dishonour case involving financial transactions worth crores of rupees.

The accused, identified as Kailashkumar Satyanarayan Khator, had approached the Chief Judicial Magistrate Court in Surat through his advocate seeking relief. However, the complainant opposed the application, arguing that the accused had allegedly avoided court proceedings for nearly five years.

Senior Advocate Naresh Gohil, representing the complainant, submitted that a person who repeatedly remains absent from legal proceedings cannot seek cancellation of an NBW without personally appearing before the court.

"The accused must first submit to the jurisdiction of the court before seeking cancellation of the warrant," Gohil argued.

Accepting the objection, the court directed the accused to appear personally. After hearing

The accused, identified as Kailashkumar Satyanarayan Khator, had approached the Chief Judicial Magistrate Court in Surat through his advocate seeking relief.

both sides, Chief Judicial Magistrate M.N. Patkar rejected the application and ordered judicial custody at Lajpore Central Jail.

The case was filed by Accurate Transheat Pvt. Ltd., Sachin, Surat, a manufacturer of textile dyeing and printing machinery. The company claimed that Khator Fibres & Fabrics Ltd. had purchased machinery and spare parts worth around ₹4.63 crore but failed to clear outstanding dues.

The company had issued multiple cheques towards the pending liability, but they were dishonoured.

Court dispute turns violent, two injured in knife attack

FPJ News Service

AHMEDABAD

An attempt to settle a pending court case outside the legal system turned violent in Ahmedabad's Sherkotada area on Monday evening, leaving two cousins injured after they were allegedly attacked with knives and sticks. Police have registered a criminal case against four accused, including three identified persons, who are currently absconding.

The incident reportedly followed a four-month-old dispute between two groups at an egg stall in Hirawadi. A case had already been registered at Sherkotada Police Station after the earlier clash.

According to police, autorickshaw driver Harendra Sureshbhai Guddekar (37) and his cousin Rahul Gajendrabhai Guddekar were approached on July 20 by the accused, who allegedly wanted to settle the case through a compromise.

However, Rahul refused the proposal, stating that the matter was already before the court.

"The dispute was pending before the court, and there was no question of withdrawi-



ng it," police quoted the complainant as stating.

The refusal allegedly led to an argument, following which the accused attacked the two men. Police said one accused allegedly used a sharp weapon and injured Rahul on his forehead, while Harendra suffered an injury on his ankle when he intervened.

The complaint further stated that the attackers assaulted both victims with sticks and issued threats before fleeing the spot.

Residents informed emergency services, and both injured men were taken to Ahmedabad Civil Hospital through 108 ambulances.

Police have registered a case under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), including charges related to causing hurt with a dangerous weapon, assault, criminal intimidation and common intention.

resilience

IIT Gandhinagar uses AI to build climate-resilient roads for India's future

FPJ News Service

GANDHINAGAR

Every monsoon, damaged roads are blamed on heavy rainfall. However, researchers at the Indian Institute of Technology Gandhinagar (IITGN) have revealed that a hidden enemy begins affecting roads much before the first raindrop falls — extreme temperature changes that create stress inside concrete pavements.

To tackle this challenge, IITGN researchers have developed an artificial intelligence-based framework that can help design stron-

ger and region-specific rigid pavements capable of handling changing climate conditions.

Rigid pavements, made using concrete slabs, are widely used for highways, airports and increasingly for urban roads due to their ability to withstand heavy traffic loads. However, repeated heating and cooling cycles caused by sunlight, night temperatures and seasonal changes create internal stress, leading to cracks and reduced road life.

"If rigid pavements in different parts of a state experience different levels of



thermal stress, it is not logical to build them using the same design recommendations," said Dr Sumit Nandi, lead author of the study

and former postdoctoral fellow at IITGN.

The research focused on Gujarat, a state with diverse climatic conditions rang-

ing from humid coastal regions to extremely hot inland areas. Researchers analysed weather data from 126 grid locations using the ERA5 climate database and studied temperature patterns from two periods — 1961-1991 and 1992-2022.

Using advanced thermal modelling and machine learning algorithms, the team identified five different thermal zones across Gujarat. These zones showed varying temperature stress patterns, proving that a single road design approach cannot work effectively across the entire state.

"Gujarat does not exhibit one-size-fits-all rigid pavement thermal behaviour. A design suitable for one region may not withstand local climate conditions elsewhere," said Dr Sushobhan Sen, Assistant Professor at IITGN's Department of Civil Engineering.

The study simulated concrete pavement designs with different slab thicknesses and surface properties to understand how roads respond to heat. Researchers found that climate-specific designs could improve durability, enhance road safety and reduce

long-term maintenance expenses.

The research was published in the ASCE Journal of Transportation Engineering, Part B: Pavements and aligns with India's infrastructure development initiatives, including PM Gati Shakti and the Bharatmala Pariyojana.

Experts believe the AI-based approach could eventually be expanded nationwide to create customised pavement designs for different climatic regions, helping India build smarter and more resilient road networks.

NEWS in SHORT

SANGAREDDY



Garlic bags looted after lorry overturns

Several garlic bags were allegedly taken away by locals after a lorry carrying the consignment overturned on NH-161 near Mamidipalli village in Kandli mandal on Tuesday. The lorry was travelling from Maharashtra to Hyderabad when it hit a road divider and overturned. The driver suffered serious injuries and was shifted to a nearby hospital by police after they reached the spot. As there was no one to guard the overturned vehicle, some locals reportedly removed garlic bags from the lorry. Police inspected the accident site and began taking necessary action. Further details regarding the incident are awaited.

KHAMMAM

Wife attacked inside PS

A woman was injured after her husband allegedly attacked her with a knife inside Enkuru Police Station on Monday evening. The victim, Bhukhya Rajani of Sathanigudem, was reportedly attacked by her husband Bhukhya Rambabu of Errabodu Thanda. The couple, who have been married for around 16 years, have a son and were living separately for the past few months due to marital disputes. Earlier, Rambabu allegedly confronted Rajani at the SBI branch in Enkuru and picked a quarrel with her. While she was at the police station to lodge a complaint, he allegedly attacked her with a knife, leaving injuries on both her hands. Police overpowered Rambabu, booked him under an attempt-to-murder case, and shifted Rajani to the Government Hospital in Khammam for treatment.

HYDERABAD



Mother, child rescued from stalled lift

A woman was injured after her husband allegedly attacked her with a knife inside Enkuru Police Station on Monday evening. The victim, Bhukhya Rajani of Sathanigudem, was reportedly attacked by her husband Bhukhya Rambabu of Errabodu Thanda. The couple, who have been married for around 16 years, have a son and were living separately for the past few months due to marital disputes. Earlier, Rambabu allegedly confronted Rajani at the SBI branch in Enkuru and picked a quarrel with her. While she was at the police station to lodge a complaint, he allegedly attacked her with a knife, leaving injuries on both her hands. Police overpowered Rambabu, booked him under an attempt-to-murder case, and shifted Rajani to the Government Hospital in Khammam for treatment.

Bhatti unveils El Niño preparedness plan

METRO INDIA NEWS | HYDERABAD

Deputy Chief Minister Bhatti Vikramarka on Tuesday said the Telangana government is preparing a comprehensive action plan to minimise the impact of global climatic changes, including El Niño, on agriculture, drinking water and power supply.

Addressing the state-level seminar, "From Pacific Ocean Warming to Telangana Preparedness," organised by the Planning Department at Ravindra Bharathi, he said the government's aim is not only to implement administrative measures but also to create public awareness so that families and villages can prepare in advance.

Bhatti said scientific studies are being conducted to understand how temperature changes in the equatorial Pacific Ocean influence rainfall, water bodies and local conditions in Telangana. Based on these findings, the government is formulating strategies to ensure adequate drinking



Bhatti said scientific studies are being conducted to understand how temperature changes in the equatorial Pacific Ocean influence rainfall

water, irrigation, and water availability for livestock and wildlife.

He said awareness would be created at the individual, vil-

lage, mandal and district levels to improve preparedness. To protect farmers from drought-related losses, the government is promoting less water-intensive crop patterns based on expert recommendations.

The Deputy Chief Minister also said the state is adopting efficient energy management strategies to meet higher electricity demand during El Niño. Increased daytime use of low-cost solar power, combined with systematic thermal power management, will help maintain grid stability while reducing costs.

Plan of action

Statewide El Niño action plan: Telangana is preparing a comprehensive strategy to minimise the impact of El Niño on agriculture, drinking water and power supply through advance planning.

Scientific, data-driven approach: The government is using scientific studies to assess how Pacific Ocean warming affects Telangana's climate and is preparing contingency plans for water, irrigation and livestock needs.

Farmer and energy preparedness: The state will promote low-water crop patterns to reduce farmers' losses and optimise solar and thermal power management to meet higher electricity demand during El Niño conditions.

Ponnam challenges BJP chief to bring central funds for Telangana

METRO INDIA NEWS | HYDERABAD

Transport and BC Welfare Minister Ponnam Prabhakar on Tuesday criticised BJP State president N. Ramchander Rao, accusing him of making baseless allegations to gain political mileage instead of addressing Telangana's concerns.

In a statement, the Minister challenged Ramchander Rao to secure Central financial assistance to help the State tackle drought-like conditions caused by El Niño. Rather than

criticising the State government, he said, the BJP leader should use his position to obtain funds for Telangana's welfare.

Ponnam Prabhakar alleged that since Ramchander Rao is not a member of any elected House, he was making statements ahead of the Assembly session to remain politically relevant.

The Minister said the State government would introduce the CURE Bill in the Assembly, where all political parties, in-



cluding the BJP, would have an opportunity to present their views through their elected

representatives instead of creating controversy outside the House.

He also asked the BJP to clarify its stand on providing houses to poor families in the GHMC limits and urged the party to press the Union government for additional housing funds. The Minister asserted that Central funds allocated to Telangana were the State's constitutional entitlement from taxpayers' contributions, not an act of charity by the Centre.

Badminton star Kidambi Srikanth meets CM Revanth

METRO INDIA NEWS | HYDERABAD

Renowned badminton player Kidambi Srikanth called on Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy at his Jubilee Hills residence in Hyderabad on Tuesday.

The courtesy visit comes on the heels of Srikanth's impressive performance at the US Open (BWF Super 300) tournament, where he finished as the runner-up.

During the interaction, the Chief Minister commended the Ace shuttler for his continued contribution to Indian sports and wished him success in his upcoming international tournaments.



Governor unveils BP Acharya's 'Obtuse Angle'

METRO INDIA NEWS | HYDERABAD

Telangana Governor Shiv Pratap Shukla released the new edition of "Obtuse Angle", a collection of cartoons by former IAS officer BP Acharya, at Lok Bhavan on Monday. The book presents cartoons drawn by Acharya reflecting his four-decade-long journey in the bureaucracy, capturing experiences, observations and moments from his public service career.

The latest edition of the book is now available in paperback format, making the cartoon collection accessible to a wider readership. Through his cartoons, Acharya

portrays various aspects of administrative life with humour and social commentary.

Acharya, who is also a trustee of the Kakatiya Heritage Trust, presented publications of the Trust to Governor Shukla during the event. Other trustees of the Trust, including Prof Panduranga Rao and Sridhar Rao of Warangal, were also present on the occasion.

The release highlighted the blend of art, public administration and heritage promotion, with Acharya's cartoons offering a unique perspective on his long association with government service and institutional work.



Excise Dept stands by family

METRO INDIA NEWS | HYDERABAD

Employees of the Telangana Prohibition and Excise Department extended financial assistance of Rs 3.46 lakh to the family of late Chirra Ekambaram, an outsourcing Data Entry Operator in the Revenue (Excise) Department at the Dr B.R. Ambedkar Telangana Secretariat, who passed away due to a sudden cardiac arrest on July 8.

Excise Department extended financial assistance of Rs 3.46 lakh to the family of late Chirra Ekambaram

The assistance was handed over by Excise Commissioner Hari Kiran, IAS, to the deceased employee's wife, Swapna Latha, at Abkari Bhavan. The Commissioner also made a personal financial contribution as a humanitarian gesture.

The relief fund was raised through contributions from members of the Telangana Prohibition and Excise Gazetted Officers' Association and Non Gazetted Ministerial and Executive staff. The Gazetted Officers' Association contributed Rs 2.75 lakh, while the Ministerial staff contributed Rs 71,000, according to Excise Gazetted Officers Association President and Secretary T Laxman Goud and Chandrashekar respectively.

The Telangana Employees JAC appreciated the department's compassionate initiative and urged the government to provide an outsourcing employment opportunity to a member of the bereaved family.



Balkampet Yellamma Kalyana Mahotsavam held with grandeur

METRO INDIA NEWS | HYDERABAD

The celestial wedding (Kalyana Mahotsavam) of Goddess Yellamma was celebrated with grand fervour at Balkampet Temple on Tuesday, drawing thousands of devotees.

Ministers Konda Surekha and Ponnam Prabhakar presented silk clothes and mutyala talamburalu to the deity on behalf of the State government.

Prominent dignitaries, including Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy's wife Geetha, Union Minister G. Kishan Reddy's wife Kavya Reddy, MLAs Danam Nagender, Talasani Srinivas Yadav, Naveen Yadav, and Government Whip Addanki Dayakar attended the celebrations. Endowments Commissioner Hanumantha Rao and Temple Chairman



Saibaba coordinated extensive arrangements. Local administration ensured uninterrupted power, drinking water supplies, and streamlined queue lines to enable smooth darshan for all visiting devotees. District Collector Dr. Priyanka Ala, DCP (traffic)

Kajal Singh, Joint Commissioner Ramakrishna Rao, EO Vinod Reddy, and officials and staff from various departments, including Electricity, GHMC, HMWSSB, Medical, Revenue, Endowments, and Police, participated in this grand wedding festival.



BJP Opposes CURE Act, Indiramma Housing Scheme

METRO INDIA NEWS | HYDERABAD

BJP Telangana president N. Ramchander Rao on Tuesday alleged that the Congress government was imposing an additional financial burden on Hyderabad residents through the proposed Core Urban Region Economy (CURE) Act and the Indiramma Housing Scheme.

Addressing a press conference, Rao claimed the CURE Act would enable annual property tax hikes of up to five per cent and separate charges for water and sewerage services. He alleged that the proposed legislation diluted the spirit of the 74th Constitutional Amendment, lacked accountability, and was introduced without consulting Resident



Welfare Associations or the public.

Criticising the Indiramma Housing Scheme, Rao said collecting a Rs.10,000 earnest money deposit (EMD) and a Rs.100 application fee from applicants for only 7,680 flats was unfair to the poor. He alleged that the government was using the scheme to collect money from applicants and claimed it could generate nearly Rs.1,000 crore.

The BJP leader demanded that vacant government-built houses be allotted to eligible beneficiaries free of cost and sought a probe into why they remain unoccupied. He also accused the Congress government of taking credit for houses built under the Centre's Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana (PMAY) and said the BJP would oppose the proposed legislation both inside and outside the Assembly.

‘Devadula pumps to run 24x7’

METRO INDIA NEWS | HYDERABAD

Irrigation and Civil Supplies Minister N. Uttam Kumar Reddy on Tuesday announced that the Telangana government has begun implementing key decisions taken during the recent Group of Ministers' review of the Devadula Lift Irrigation Scheme, with nine pumping units set to operate round the clock from Tuesday night to maximise water lifting from the Godavari River.

Speaking to media persons at the Secretariat, the Minister said the Government's immediate focus was to ensure water security for farmers and drinking water needs across the State rather than engage in political arguments. He said engineers had been instructed to operate all nine pumping units at full capacity to fill 22 reservoirs benefiting nine districts, helping address the emerging water scarcity caused by deficient rainfall.

Uttam Kumar Reddy said every operational decision was being guided by technical requirements and the need to protect water availability dur-



ing the uncertain monsoon season. He reiterated that safeguarding farmers' interests and ensuring drinking water security remained the Government's highest priority.

Responding to criticism from BRS leader T. Harish Rao, the Minister accused the BRS of attempting to divert public attention from the failures of the Kaleshwaram Lift Irrigation Scheme. He said those responsible for key engineering and administrative decisions that resulted in the structural problems at the Medigadda barrage must first explain their actions before criticising the Government's efforts on Devadula.

The Minister questioned the decision taken during the previous BRS Government to re-

place the original sheet pile foundation proposed in the Detailed Project Report with a secant pile foundation at Medigadda. He said records placed before the Judicial Commission highlighted the design change and asserted that the BRS must be held accountable for the engineering decisions that led to the present condition of Kaleshwaram.

Uttam Kumar Reddy also demanded that Harish Rao respond to BRS MLC K. Kavitha's public allegation that Kaleshwaram contractors had paid Rs 1,400 crore to the BRS, stating that the people deserved a clear explanation.

Reiterating the Government's commitment to Devadula, the Minister said land acquisition, statutory clearances and construction activities were being expedited on mission mode to complete the project by December 2027. Once completed, the scheme is expected to provide irrigation to nearly 5.6 lakh acres while substantially strengthening drinking water security across northern Telangana.



BENGALURU

2 held for printing fake Rs 500 notes

Two men, including an inter-state accused, were arrested for allegedly printing and circulating fake Rs 500 currency notes, police said on Tuesday.

The accused have been identified as Arvind (47), a native of Mysuru, and Venkata Subramanian (around 60), a resident of Chennai, they said.

Police claimed to have seized 338 counterfeit Rs 500 currency notes, a photocopy machine, a laptop, a car, mobile phones and other incriminating materials, with the total value of the seizure estimated at Rs 3.29 lakh, police said.

On July 3, the Kumbalagodu Police received a tip-off that a tenant residing in a BDA apartment within the police station limits was circulating counterfeit currency notes, police said.

According to police, acting on specific intelligence provided by the informant, they detained a suspect near Kanchanapura Cross. During interrogation, the accused allegedly confessed to printing counterfeit currency notes and selling them to an associate based in Chennai.

On July 4, the accused was produced before the jurisdictional court, which granted 10 days of police custody for further investigation.

BENGALURU

Multiple ED raids in ISIS case

The Enforcement Directorate on Tuesday conducted searches at multiple locations in Karnataka as part of a money laundering probe in a case linked to radicalisation of youth to join banned international terrorist group ISIS, officials said.

They said about eight locations in and around Bengaluru were raided by the central agency. The action is being undertaken as per the provisions of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA).

The investigation stems from a National Investigation Agency (NIA) FIR related to ISIS recruitment involving Iqra Welfare Trust, Guidance for Mankind and certain individuals.

The NIA has chargesheeted five persons alleging that the accused-- all affiliated with the banned terrorist organisation ISIS/ISIL/Daesh-- entered into a criminal conspiracy to radicalise and motivate impressionable Muslim youth of Bengaluru to join the ISIS.

These accused identified, radicalised, and recruited youths through a Muslim "personality development" workshop called "Iqra Camp" and a weekly study circle called "Quran Circle" that grew out of it; raised and channelled funds; and facilitated the illegal travel of recruits to Syria via Türkiye to join the ISIS and fight against the government of Syria.

These acts have been mentioned in the NIA chargesheet as "waging war against Syria, n Asiatic Power in alliance with the Government of India."

MYSURU

Three arrested for gang-rape of tribal woman

Three men have been arrested on charges of allegedly abducting and gang-raping a tribal woman from West Bengal, police said on Tuesday.

The 30-year-old woman was allegedly abducted by the trio near the private bus stand in T Narasipura town of Mysuru district, taken to a lodge near Mooguru village where she was allegedly gang-raped, robbed of cash and two mobile phones.

She was later abandoned near her residence, according to a First Information Report (FIR) registered by the T Narasipura police.

The accused have been identified as Kiran, Kishore and Ryan, residents of T Narasipura.

The FIR, registered on July 19 under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), said the alleged offences took place on the intervening night of July 18 and 19.

Police have booked the case against three accused and have taken up investigation.

According to the FIR, the driver of a grey-coloured car showed her a piece of paper and asked for an address near the private bus stand.

Since it was written in Kannada, the woman expressed her inability to read it.

FREE FOOTPATHS | **Attackers not hardworking poor people: Minister**

GBA officials assaulted during anti-encroachment drive, 10 held

NT Correspondent
BENGALURU

Street vendors allegedly attacked Bengaluru municipal officers and employees who had gone to clear encroachments from a footpath in Shivaji Nagar on Tuesday.

When a team of GBA officials reached Shivaji Nagar, some people allegedly turned violent, dragging Assistant Executive Engineer Gowtham and a few other officials onto the road before assaulting them.

They also allegedly pepper-sprayed another official, Ruchitha.

"Accused persons have been arrested by the police. The main instigator, Basavaraj Pudukote, will also be arrested soon. All of them will be booked on charges of attempt to murder," a police officer said.

Acting on the directions of Bengaluru Development Minister Krishna Byre Gowda, officials of the Greater



Police and GBA officials cleared the footpath during the footpath clearance drive at Shivajinagar in Bengaluru on Tuesday. A few GBA officials were beaten up during the drive. | Satish B

Bengaluru Authority have been carrying out a drive to remove encroachments from pavements.

Condemning the attack, Gowda said he had directed the police to take stringent action against those responsible.

"The attackers are not hardworking poor people

earning their livelihood. They are anti-social elements. Assaulting government officials while they are implementing the directions of the Hon'ble Supreme Court is a serious violation of the law. We stand firmly with officers discharging their public duty in accordance with the law," the minister told reporters in



New Delhi.

According to Gowda, the driver of a tractor and the operator of an earthmover engaged in the encroachment removal drive were injured and hospitalised in the attack.

"Police have arrested 10 people. I have asked the police to invoke the Goonda

Act against Pudukote. Those who attacked our staff with pepper spray will be booked on charges of attempted murder," the minister said.

Reacting to the incident, Bengaluru Police Commissioner Seemant Kumar Singh said strict action would be taken against those responsible.

Mysuru man kills wife, two daughters; kills self

NT Correspondent
MYSURU

A 49-year-old man allegedly killed his wife and two daughters before dying by suicide in Mysuru district on Tuesday, police said.

The incident occurred at New Maruti Layout in Hunsur town, they said.

Police said Harish was engaged in the real estate business.

According to the police, Harish allegedly killed his 36-year-old wife, Nishith, and their daughters, aged 14 and eight, before hanging himself.

Adhesive tape found covering the mouths of his wife and daughters indicated that they may have died of suffocation. However, the exact cause of death will be ascertained only after the post-mortem examination,

police said.

According to the police, he left a suicide note stating that he would be found hanging in an upstairs room.

The purported note mentioned property documents kept in a locker, specified the location of the keys, and requested the police to hand them over to a person named in the note.

A preliminary inquiry revealed that he had sent his mother to his grandmother's house three days earlier, a police official said.

The Hunsur City police visited the spot and conducted an inspection.

Speaking to reporters, Mysuru Superintendent of Police Mallikarjun Baldandi said information about the deaths was received at around 12.12 pm.

Nothing wrong in issuing PRC, says Deputy CM G Parameshwara

NT Correspondent
BENGALURU

Karnataka Deputy Chief Minister G Parameshwara on Tuesday defended the state government's decision to issue Permanent Resident Certificates (PRCs), saying the initiative was aimed at helping genuine residents in the SIR of electoral rolls and should not be politicised.

Addressing reporters here, Parameshwara said the certificates would benefit people who are unable to produce older electoral records required during the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, while asserting that the process was being carried out strictly in accordance with the law.

"The Government had decided to issue Permanent Resident Certificates (PRCs)



based on applicants having been born in Karnataka. Most people have been asked to provide details from the 2002 electoral rolls. Around 50 to 60 per cent of people may have such records. However, some may not possess those records. The PRC will be helpful to such individuals," he said.

Parameshwara said caste certificates had been issued by Tahsildars even earlier

and questioned the criticism over the government's latest move.

"We need to formalise this process. A certificate will be issued if applicants provide evidence that they have lived in Karnataka for 10 years. Can we marry off our daughters to Bangladeshis? No. We are neither acting against the Union Government nor violating any law. We are proceeding strictly in accordance with the law," he said.

On the state's drought situation, he said, "The decision must benefit farmers and ordinary citizens. It should also support those who are forced to migrate in search of work due to a lack of employment. We will take a decision after considering all these factors".

He said Deputy Commissioners had already been instructed to assess drought-

like conditions in taluks and submit reports, following which further action would be taken.

Rejecting the BJP's criticism of the government's drought management, Parameshwara said Rs 5 crore had been released to every district for drinking water arrangements, Rs 329 crore was available in the Personal Deposit (PD) accounts of Deputy Commissioners, and the government had also announced an allocation of Rs 1 crore for every taluk.

"BJP leaders should understand all these measures and speak responsibly," he said.

In the midst of Special Intensive Revision of the electoral roll in progress in the state, Chief Minister D K Shivakumar on Sunday announced delivering PRC at the doorstep.

'Cabinet expansion to see more young faces'

NT Correspondent
BENGALURU

The much-awaited expansion of the Karnataka Cabinet will happen once the Congress high command clears the list of proposed names and gives the go ahead, and young faces may be given priority, Deputy Chief Minister G Parameshwara indicated on Tuesday.

Several aspects, including opportunities for fresh and young faces are under consideration during discussions with the party leadership, the senior leader said.

Amid buzz that the Cabinet expansion is likely soon, Chief Minister D K Shivakumar, his predecessor Siddaramaiah and state Congress chief B K Hariprasad are in Delhi for discussions with the Congress high command.

"They (CM, Siddaramaiah and Hariprasad) have gone to Delhi, if the high command approves following the discussion, the cabinet expansion will happen," Parameshwara told reporters here.

When asked whether the cabinet expansion would happen before the Assembly session early next month, he said, after discussions if the high command permits, the exercise will be done immediately.

"Once the high command says yes and clears the list, the Governor will be informed and considering his availability, his time will be sought (for the swearing-in of new ministers)," he added.

Triple murder: Cops seek chat logs; accused used Chatbot

NT Correspondent
BENGALURU

The Bengaluru Police have written to an AI tool company seeking details of chat history after the investigation into the recent triple murder case revealed that the prime accused used the assistance of an AI chatbot to execute the murders, which he had been planning for nearly six months, officials said on Tuesday.

The murders were reported on June 22 this year at an apartment in Seegehalli under the limits of K R Puram Police Station, where Somasundar (52), his wife Muthulaxmi (48), and their younger daughter Supriya (19) were found stabbed to death.

Days after the murders, the deceased couple's elder daughter Shwetha (24) and her live-in partner Kenneth (25), who fled the spot after committing the crime, were arrested separately from

Puducherry, where they had been taking shelter to evade arrest, police said.

The investigation revealed that the alleged motive behind the murders appeared to be financial disputes and strained family relations, with Shwetha harbouring grievances against her mother for being "controlling," they said.

According to police, Shwetha had allegedly borrowed Rs 50 lakh from her mother, Muthulaxmi, for Kenneth to start a cloud kitchen business. The money was spent, and she feared how it would be repaid.

While Kenneth and Shwetha allegedly acted in tandem, the entire planning and execution of the murders were carried out by Kenneth, who consulted an AI chatbot at every stage, including seeking information on how to kill, dispose of bodies, removing bloodstains, and whether the furnace built

by him for the planned cloud kitchen business here could be repurposed to incinerate the bodies, a senior police officer said.

During interrogation, Kenneth confessed to police that a trivial issue had triggered him to eliminate Shwetha's family members. He also admitted that he depended heavily on the AI chatbot for guidance throughout the six months of planning the murders, the officer said, adding that it had acted as an accomplice in the crime.

Following the detailed interrogation, the officer said investigators have written to the parent AI company seeking digital evidence of Kenneth's chat history with the AI tool to corroborate his version.

Meanwhile, psychological assessments conducted during the probe revealed that Kenneth suffered from severe social isolation.



Members of Bengaluru City Youth Congress protesting against Delhi police lathicharge and demanding the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the NEET issue during their protest, in Bengaluru on Tuesday. | Satish B

SHOWCASING IDEAS

Egyptian museum architect to design Bengaluru's innovation museum

NT Correspondent
BENGALURU

Heneghan Peng Architects Consortium, which designed the Grand Egyptian Museum, has won the bid to design Bengaluru's Museum of Innovation, Startup & Technology, officials said on Tuesday.

The Design and Technical Agency for the MIST-a public-private partnership between UnboxingBLR and the Karnataka Department of Electronics, Information Technology and Biotechnology-was selected through a two-stage global Quality and Cost-Based Selection process, they said.

Among the six shortlisted consortia, Heneghan Peng Architects Consortium emerged as the successful bidder, officials said.

According to the UnboxingBLR Foundation, the consortium's internationally acclaimed portfolio features the Grand Egyptian Museum, Fulham Town Hall in London, the Salt Works Complex in Germany and the National Gallery of Ireland.



MIST and Innoverse are twin institutions being developed within the repurposed Switchgear Factory Shed at the NGEF campus in Bengaluru.

The six shortlisted DTAs presented their proposals before a high-powered jury on July 11 at the Accel Launchpad.

The presentations were reviewed by Karnataka Minister for IT, BT and e-Governance Priyank Karge, along with the MIST and Innoverse boards and jury members, on July 12, UBLR said in a state-

ment.

UBLR is a Bengaluru-focused not-for-profit organisation working with multiple stakeholders to conceptualise and execute city-scale projects.

It said MIST, legally registered as the Karnataka Technology Innovation Museum Foundation, is a public-private partnership between the UnboxingBLR Foundation, which holds a 51 per cent stake, and the Karnataka ITBT Department, which holds the remaining 49 per cent.

The museum will showcase

The architect has previously done the Egyptian Museum, and Fulham Town Hall.

ments Consortium and Flying Elephant Studio Consortium emerged as the two finalists, with Heneghan Peng Architects Consortium eventually winning the bid. Its partners include Cadence Architects (Bengaluru) and DROO Da Costa Mahindroo Architects (London, Paris and Melbourne).

Heneghan Peng is the only architectural firm to feature in the TIME100 Most Influential Companies 2026 list, it added.

"We are proud that some of the biggest names in the global museum design sector participated in the competition for the MIST project. The winning consortium has outstanding credentials to build a world-class museum in Bengaluru," said Prashanth Prakash, chairman of KTIMF and UnboxingBLR.

The global selection process for the DTA was launched in January 2026 and attracted 13 consortia comprising 30 firms-20 Indian and 10 international-to lead the project's master planning and conduct the DTA design competition.

3-day India int'l travel mart to take place in B'luru from July 23

NT Correspondent
BENGALURU

A three-day India International Travel Mart (IITM) will be held from July 23 at Tripura Vasini Palace Ground in Bengaluru.

Organisers said IITM is focused on eight countries and 26 international destinations, besides destinations in 26 Indian states. It will be showcasing a wide range of tourism products - from leisure, adventure, and wellness travel to meetings, destination weddings, and responsible tourism.

The countries participating include Japan, Sri Lanka, Malaysia, Vietnam, Thailand, UK, Nepal, Dubai, Turkey, Singapore, Bhutan, Indonesia, etc. Karnataka is the host state for IITM 2026 and the partner states are Odisha Tourism, Kerala and Rajasthan, while Punjab, Chhattisgarh and Madhya Pradesh Tourism are the Feature States.

"IITM is showcasing diverse travel options like pilgrimages, adventures, culture, wildlife, and more.

From Indian rhinoceros to Rajasthan's festivals to Odisha's heritage sites, to Tamil Nadu's rich temple heritage, the event enriches holiday choices than ever before," the organisers said in a statement.

Rohit Hangal, Director, Sphere Travelmedia and Exhibitions, said India's travel and tourism sector continues to witness remarkable growth, driven by increasing domestic travel, expanding international connectivity and changing traveller preferences.

"IITM Bengaluru provides an ideal platform for destinations and travel brands to connect with the travel trade, build strategic partnerships and showcase innovative tourism products to one of India's most significant travel markets," Hangal said.

He added that India International Travel Mart - Bengaluru continues to play a vital role in shaping travel aspirations and strengthening business ties between stakeholders in the tourism ecosystem.

OVERTURNED | Supreme Court struck down Kerala High Court order for govt supervisor

SC scraps govt Waqf oversight

**HD Bureau
NEW DELHI**

The Supreme Court on Tuesday freed the Kerala State Waqf Board from government supervision, restoring the radical administrative principle that a statutory body should be allowed to manage its own daily affairs.

A three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant removed the Kerala High Court’s direction requiring the Board to function under the



Judges ruled that statutory autonomy does not require a government official carrying a supervisory clipboard

supervision of a Joint or Additional Secretary. The judges indicated that courts could still intervene if the Board’s conduct crossed the constitutional

threshold from ordinary confusion into “egregious” interference or mismanagement. The order immediately relieved officials who had feared that every Board

meeting would require the presence of a government representative trained to nod carefully, check attendance and ask whether tea expenditure counted as a major policy decision.

The High Court had issued its interim direction on July 15 while considering challenges to the Board’s composition. It found that the body appeared not to comply with Section 14 of the Unified Waqf Management, Empowerment, Efficiency and Development Act, 2025,

because two non-Muslim members had not been appointed.

Until the dispute was resolved, the High Court restrained the Board from taking major administrative decisions, making policy choices or incurring capital expenditure. It also placed its functioning under bureaucratic supervision, effectively converting an independent statutory institution into a school excursion waiting for a responsible adult.

The Supreme Court deleted the supervision

requirement while leaving other questions before the High Court. It asked the High Court to decide the pending case expeditiously, a judicial expression traditionally understood to mean the matter has officially moved from one stack of urgent files to another stack labelled extremely urgent.

Lawyers for the Board argued that appointing a government official to oversee its daily work amounted to replacing statutory autonomy with administrative surveillance.

High Court renews protection for Monalisa

**HD Bureau
KOCHI**

Kerala High Court on Tuesday restored interim police protection for Monalisa Bhosle after she submitted a written request to the appropriate police station and provided information enabling officers to locate her.

Justice Bechu Kurian Thomas directed the authorities to continue providing adequate protection to Bhosle, who has alleged death threats, intimidation and an online hate campaign following her marriage to actor Mohammed Farman Khan.

Congress revolt topples Pala municipal chief

**HD Bureau
KOCHI**

Pala’s six-month-old municipal administration collapsed on Tuesday after 17 councillors removed chairperson Diya Binu Pulickakandam, ending the tenure of Kerala’s youngest civic chief and exposing deep divisions within the United Democratic Front.

A no-confidence motion introduced by the opposition Left Democratic Front was approved without dissent at a special council meeting attended by 17 of the municipality’s 26 members. All those present supported the motion, exceeding the 14 votes required for its passage.

The LDF’s 12 councillors were joined by four Congress members and independent councillor Maya Rahul, the municipal vice-chairperson. The Congress councillors — Lisikutty Mathew, Biju Mathews, Tony Thaiparambil and Rajitha Prakash — attended the meeting despite a UDF directive to stay away and voted for Diya’s removal.

The rebellion transformed an opposition motion into a decisive defeat for the ruling arrangement. Congress councillors Riya



Four councillors defied the party whip, joining the opposition and an independent to carry the no-confidence motion

Chiramkuzhy and Sebastian J Panakkal did not attend. Three Kerala Congress councillors aligned with the UDF — Sonia Chitted, Biju Varikkani and Siji Tony — were also absent, along with Kerala Democratic Party councillor Princy Sunny.

Diya, 21, took office in December after a fractured municipal verdict left neither major coalition with a majority. She was elected with 14 votes and became the country’s youngest municipal chairperson, bringing national attention to a council shaped by independents, family influence and coalition bargaining.

Her victory followed the election of three members of the Pulickakandam family from adjoining wards.

KV Thomas in Delhi cost Keralites ₹1 crore

**HD Bureau
NEW DELHI**

The Kerala government spent more than ₹1 crore on the honorarium and staff salaries of Prof K V Thomas during his tenure as the state’s Special Representative in New Delhi, establishing that maintaining contact with the national capital requires both diplomatic skill and a comfortably staffed payroll.

The expenditure was disclosed by the Public Information Officer of Kerala House in response to a Right to Information application filed by a Kochi-based activist. The reply has offered taxpayers

a rare numerical glimpse into a post whose daily output is usually measured in meetings, introductions, follow-up calls and photographs featuring furniture designed for senior officials.

Thomas was appointed to the Cabinet-rank position in January 2023. The former Union minister and long-serving parliamentarian was entrusted with representing Kerala’s interests in New Delhi, coordinating with Union ministries and helping the state secure attention for projects, proposals and problems that might otherwise wander indefinitely through government corridors.



The government later fixed his monthly honorarium at ₹1 lakh. It also permitted the appointment of two assistants, an office attendant and a driver, ensuring that every representation made on Kerala’s behalf could be supported by sufficient representation.

Officials have not published a complete catalogue of

The capital liaison mission has demonstrated that public service can be prohibitively expensive

breakthroughs produced by the arrangement. This has strengthened the position’s strategic importance, because work that cannot be easily described is often considered too sensitive to quantify.

Supporters say Thomas brought decades of political experience, ministerial contacts and institutional knowledge to the job.

Critics have asked whether Kerala needed a Cabinet-rank intermediary in a city already occupied by MPs, ministers, civil servants, a resident commissioner and an entire Kerala House equipped to interact with the Union government.

Administrative experts have clarified that each of these people performs a distinct function. MPs raise matters in Parliament, officials process files, ministers negotiate with other ministers, and the Special Representative ensures nobody feels that the delegation lacks a Special Representative.

Thomas had initially sought an honorarium rather than a regular salary.

Minister summons DGP on Ram fiasco

**HD Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM**

Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala directed State Police Chief Ravada A Chandrasekhar to determine how Crime Branch officers committed the procedural irregularity of locating Dr M Kodanda Ram, taking him into custody and producing him before a court without first securing broader administrative consensus on whether arrests should involve arresting people.

Ram, former head of Dental Anatomy at Kannur Dental College in Ancharakandy, was detained in Karnataka on Monday. He is the prime accused in the case concerning the death of 22-year-old first-year BDS student R. L. Nithin Raj, who fell from a college building on April 10 and died in hospital.

Officials said the inquiry would establish whether the arrest team had been improperly influenced



Investigators will find out how officers goofed up requirements of arrest as demanded by courts, leading to suspicion of police help

by such operational distractions as rejected anticipatory-bail petitions, judicial observations, an active criminal case and the accused’s alleged movement across Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka.

“The police must not act merely because every legal indicator points in the same direction,” a senior Home Department official said. “There are files, sub-files, opinions, revised opinions and opportunities to await instructions that were already issued.”

Murali accuses Vijayan of defending land grab

**HD Bureau
KOCHI**

The controversy over the Democratic Youth Federation of India’s home-packed lunch programme continued on Tuesday, with Health Minister K. Muralreedharan accusing Pinarayi Vijayan of defending organisations that allegedly occupy public space under the cover of philanthropy.

Muralreedharan said the government had no objection to patients and caregivers being fed. Its concern, he explained, was that the food might arrive beneath banners, near flags or through volunteers possessing identifiable political opinions. Rice, curry and pickle would remain acceptable, provided they were stripped of ideology before entering hospital premises.

The minister’s clarification followed several versions of the government’s position.

Shwetha Menon reclaims AMMA presidency

**HD Bureau
KOCHI**

Actor Shwetha Menon has withdrawn her resignation as president of the Association of Malayalam Movie Artistes, asserting that figures associated with Malayalam cinema’s alleged “power group” will not be permitted to take control of the organisation while she can continue leading it.

Menon’s decision deepens a leadership dispute that has divided



Her return intensifies a battle over control, accountability and the influence of entrenched groups within Malayalam cinema

AMMA since its stormy annual general body meeting on June 21. She

resignations after criticism of the administration, disputes over financial records and an attempt to establish an ad hoc panel.

She has since challenged the validity of that process, maintaining that the resolution to replace the elected leadership did not receive the two-thirds majority required under the association’s rules. Menon said only 243 members were present at the meeting and questioned whether a pre-prepared

resolution could legally displace office-bearers elected for a fixed term.

Her latest intervention shifts the dispute from a debate over administrative performance to a wider confrontation over who exercises influence inside Malayalam cinema’s leading actors’ body. Menon has portrayed her stand as a defence of AMMA against forces seeking to capture its leadership by misleading members and bypassing established procedures.

Planning Board recast in think tank role

**HD Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM**

The United Democratic Front government has reconstituted the Kerala State Planning Board, appointing former Union cabinet secretary K M Chandrasekhar as vice-chairperson and directing the institution to expand its role as a policy think tank.

Chief Minister V D Satheesan will chair the Board, which has initially been formed



with five ministers representing different constituents of the ruling coalition. The non-ministerial expert members, including specialists expected from industry,

Former cabinet secretary returns with a mandate to connect development priorities, public expertise and fiscal discipline

shipping and other strategic sectors, will be named separately.

Industries and Information Technology Minister P K Kunhalikutty, Power Minister Sunny

Joseph, Water Resources Minister Mons Joseph, Forest Minister Shibu Baby John and Transport Minister C P John have been included as ministerial members. The composition gives coalition partners a direct role in shaping development priorities while covering several infrastructure-intensive departments.

Chandrasekhar returns to a position he held during the 2011-16 UDF administration led

by Oommen Chandy. His appointment indicates that the government wants the Board to move beyond its conventional work of preparing plans, reviewing schemes and coordinating expenditure proposals.

The former civil servant was Union cabinet secretary under the United Progressive Alliance government and joined the Kerala Planning Board after retiring from service in 2011.

offgrid

Thamarassery residents deploy curtains against midnight visitor

**HD Bureau
KOCHI**

Fear has gripped parts of Thamarassery after CCTV footage showed a naked, face-covered stranger approaching houses at night, ringing doorbells and fleeing before residents could answer.

The unidentified man has reportedly appeared during the small hours, when most households are asleep and even neighbourhood WhatsApp administrators

are operating with reduced accuracy. His method appears simple: approach a home without clothing, conceal the only body part useful for identification, press the bell and disappear into the darkness.

Residents said the incidents had transformed the familiar sound of a doorbell from a signal announcing relatives, couriers or people collecting money for local celebrations into an emergency alert



capable of mobilising an entire family.

Several households have begun reviewing security-camera recordings each morning before checking

the weather, milk packets or family messages. CCTV systems once installed mainly to identify thieves are now being assessed for their ability to distinguish

between an intruder, a wandering neighbour and a man whose commitment to minimalism has exceeded legal limits.

Local concern intensified after footage circulated online, allowing thousands of people outside the affected streets to inspect every blurred frame and announce that the suspect was definitely somebody they had never met.

Unofficial investigative teams formed immediately across messaging

groups. Some members enlarged screenshots until individual pixels became the principal suspects. Others analysed the man’s posture, running style and doorbell technique, producing conclusions ranging from “young and athletic” to “possibly someone with knees”.

One resident said families were no longer opening doors without first conducting a full security conference behind the curtain.

“We ask who it is, check the camera, switch on every outdoor light and contact three neighbours,” he said. “By the time we complete the procedure, even genuine visitors have reconsidered why they came.”

The stranger’s reported decision to cover his face while leaving the rest of himself exposed has generated particular confusion. Residents described it as an unusual privacy policy

that protects biometric information while releasing all other available data.

Security experts routinely advise householders not to confront suspicious intruders, to secure doors and windows, preserve camera footage and contact police. Thamarassery residents have added another precaution: keeping curtains closed in case the suspect’s objective is less burglary and more deeply unwanted performance art.



A mismatch of words & actions

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has every reason to celebrate the achievements of India's young innovators. The successful launch of Vikram-1 by a Hyderabad-based start-up is a milestone not merely in the country's space journey but also in the evolution of its entrepreneurial ecosystem. Conceived, engineered, and launched by a team whose average age is just 28, the mission demonstrated that India's youth can dream big, plan meticulously, and execute flawlessly. Appropriately named Aagaman (Arrival), the mission announced to the world that a new generation of Indian talent has truly arrived. Speaking on the opening day of the monsoon session of Parliament, the PM proudly highlighted the youthful profile of the team behind Vikram-1. His admiration was understandable. Every Indian shared that sense of pride.

Yet, on the very day those words were spoken, another image of India's youth was unfolding on the streets of New Delhi. At Jantar Mantar, thousands of students protesting against the government's inability to conduct public examinations in a credible manner were met not with dialogue but with police batons. It was a deeply disturbing spectacle. The protesters had gathered peacefully to demand accountability and the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan. Instead, they were subjected to a lathi charge that left many injured, including students who had travelled from states as distant as Maharashtra and Gujarat. Similar demonstrations were reported elsewhere, reflecting widespread frustration rather than isolated discontent. Earlier, the government had

The youth who launch rockets and the youth who march for educational justice are not two different Indias.

forcibly shifted Sonam Wangchuk, who was fasting, to a hospital. The anger of the students is neither manufactured nor unreasonable. Months of uncertainty over examinations, repeated postponements, allegations of question-paper leaks, and the erosion of confidence in the examination system have left countless young people anxious about their future. Reports of students taking their own lives, following the disruption of the NEET examination, underline the human cost of these administrative failures. Even the CBSE examinations have not escaped criticism over alleged lapses.

Instead of addressing these concerns with empathy, the government has chosen to stand firmly behind the minister. Modi's recent birthday greetings praising Dharmendra Pradhan's performance and Defence Minister Rajnath Singh's assertion that resignations are alien to the BJP only reinforce the impression that political solidarity is taking precedence over public accountability. A democracy cannot afford such contradictions. The youth who launch rockets and the youth who march for educational justice are not two different Indias. They are the same generation, driven by ambition, aspiration, and a belief that merit should prevail. If one group deserves applause for taking India to space, the other deserves to be heard when it asks for fairness on earth. Praising the nation's youth is meaningful only when their voices are respected, their concerns addressed, and their dignity protected.

Sindhu shows class is forever

PV Sindhu's maiden Japan Open title is more than another glittering addition to an already decorated career. It is a timely reminder that champions are defined not merely by the medals they collect but also by their ability to reinvent themselves after setbacks. At a stage when questions had begun to surface about her consistency and future among the world's elite, Sindhu has answered in the only language that matters in sports—performance.

Winning the Japan Open, beating long-time rival Akane Yamaguchi and lifting a BWF Super 750 title at the age of 31, becoming the first Indian and the oldest woman to claim the crown, is no mean feat considering that she was struggling in the last couple of years. It is the double Olympic medallist's first title since the Syed Modi International in 2024 and her first BWF Major win since the 2019 World Championship gold.

For an athlete who has already won two Olympic medals, a World Championship title, and numerous international honours, expectations have always been unusually high. Every early exit has been magnified and every dip in form dissected. Injuries, changes in coaching staff, and the relentless physical demands of the modern badminton circuit have made the past two seasons particularly challenging. Yet, rather than allowing doubts to take root, Sindhu has quietly rebuilt her game. The triumph in Japan reflects not just technical excellence but also mental resilience, an attribute that has long distinguished her from many of her contemporaries.

The significance of this victory extends beyond the trophy itself. Japan has traditionally hosted one of the most competitive tournaments on the badminton calendar, attracting the world's finest players. Winning such an event demands consistency over an entire week, tactical adaptability, and exceptional fitness. Sindhu demonstrated all three. More importantly, she showed a renewed hunger that had appeared to wane amid recurring injuries and inconsistent results.

Indian badminton has evolved remarkably over the past decade. From being dependent on a handful of stars, the country now boasts a wider pool of talent capable of competing on the global stage. Yet, Sindhu remains its most recognisable ambassador. Her success inspires countless young players, particularly girls, to dream beyond national championships and aspire to international glory. Every major title she wins reinforces India's reputation as a serious badminton nation.

However, one victory, however significant, cannot mask the broader challenges confronting Indian sport. Elite athletes require sustained institutional support, scientific coaching, sports medicines, and long-term planning rather than episodic attention that peaks around Olympic cycles. Sindhu's perseverance is admirable, but it should not become an excuse for administrators to rely solely on individual brilliance.



Guest Column

PROF. GANESH KAWADIA

Nine years after the introduction of the Goods and Services Tax (GST), India's indirect tax regime has largely achieved its objective of creating a unified national market. Compliance has improved, technology has strengthened tax administration and collections continue to touch record levels. In June 2026 alone, GST revenues crossed Rs 1.94 lakh crore, registering nearly 14% growth over the corresponding month last year. For the entire FY2025-26, total GST collections stood at Rs 22.3 lakh crore, more than 8% higher than the previous year.

Against this encouraging national picture, Madhya Pradesh presents a striking anomaly. The state's GST collections declined by around 5% in June 2026. This reversal is particularly surprising because the state had been performing strongly only a year earlier, recording 7% growth in June 2025 and an impressive 18% in July 2025. The sudden downturn naturally raises an important question: why is Madhya Pradesh losing revenue when India's GST system appears stronger than ever?

The emerging paradox

The answer becomes clearer when one compares the performance of different states.

Manufacturing and logistics-driven states continued to record robust growth in June 2026. Uttar Pradesh registered a 19% increase in GST collections, Assam 17%, Punjab 14%, Gujarat 12% and Maharashtra 9%. By contrast, Tamil Nadu saw collections decline by 2%, while Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh both recorded a fall of 5%.

This pattern appears to contradict one of the fundamental principles of GST.

GST is a destination-based tax. Unlike the earlier indirect tax system, revenue is intended to accrue primarily to the state where goods are finally consumed rather than where they are produced. Since Madhya Pradesh has a large consumer base and imports a substantial quantity of goods from manufacturing states, it should theoretically have been among the biggest beneficiaries of the GST framework.

Instead, it has become one of the states witnessing declining collections. This is the paradox that deserves closer examination.

Why it is happening

Two major policy developments explain the present situation.

The first is the GST rate rationalisation undertaken in September 2025. To simplify the tax structure and stimulate demand, the GST Council reduced the number of principal tax slabs to two - 5% and 18%. Hundreds of commonly used products, including food items, textiles, soap and several household essentials, were shifted to the lower tax bracket.

The objective was sound. Lower taxes reduce prices, encourage consumption and support economic growth. However, every policy has distributional consequences.

The products shifted to the 5% slab happen to constitute a substantial share of household expenditure in Madhya Pradesh. Since the state derives a significant portion of its GST revenue from mass-market consumption, lower tax rates immediately translated into lower tax collections. Consumers benefited, but state revenues declined.

For a consumption-oriented economy, the impact was far greater than for states where tax collections are driven pri-

marily by manufacturing activity.

The shrinking GST pool

The second reason is less visible but equally important.

Madhya Pradesh receives GST revenue through two channels. One comes from taxes collected on transactions taking place within the state. The other comes through its share of Integrated GST (IGST), which is collected on interstate trade and subsequently distributed among destination states.

This arrangement was designed to ensure that consumer states remained financially secure even if goods were manufactured elsewhere. However, recent policy changes have weakened this safety net.

Since lower GST rates now apply to many goods moving across state borders, the overall interstate tax pool has become smaller. Simultaneously, reforms in the GST refund mechanism introduced from October 2025 allow eligible businesses to receive up to 90% of certain refunds within seven days. These refunds are processed before revenues are distributed among states.

Consequently, Madhya Pradesh faces a double loss. It earns less revenue from local consumption because tax rates have fallen, while it also receives a smaller allocation from interstate GST collections because the common pool itself has shrunk.

Ironically, the very mechanism designed to protect consumption-driven states has become another source of fiscal pressure.

Not a compliance problem

It is important not to misinterpret these numbers.

The decline in GST collections does not necessarily indicate that Madhya Pradesh's economy has weakened. Nor does it suggest widespread tax evasion or de-

teriorating compliance. In fact, GST compliance has generally improved across the country, supported by digital invoicing, e-way bills and data analytics.

The state's lower collections are primarily the result of national policy choices aimed at reducing inflation, encouraging consumption and improving the ease of doing business.

Understanding this distinction is essential because the policy response must address structural realities rather than assume administrative failure.

The way out

The state government must adopt a long-term fiscal strategy instead of reacting only to short-term fluctuations.

First, it should strengthen revenue sources that remain under its direct control. Excise duty on liquor, stamp duty on property transactions and royalties from Madhya Pradesh's abundant mineral resources can provide greater fiscal stability.

Second, expanding the GST base is equally important. Bringing more small businesses into the formal economy will increase the volume of taxable transactions. Even if tax rates remain lower, a broader base can generate higher overall revenue.

Third, Madhya Pradesh should place a strong case before the GST Council. If national tax reforms deliberately reduce GST rates to stimulate economic growth, then compensation mechanisms should adequately protect states that depend heavily on consumption. Otherwise, consumer states end up bearing a disproportionate share of the fiscal burden created by national policy.

Finally, the state must focus on changing the structure of its economy.

Looking beyond consumption

The current situation exposes a deeper economic reality. Madhya Pra-

desh consumes far more manufactured goods than it produces. As long as the state remains primarily a consumer market, it will continue to depend heavily on tax revenues generated elsewhere.

Long-term fiscal resilience therefore lies in expanding manufacturing, promoting value-added industries, strengthening logistics infrastructure and attracting greater private investment. Every new factory established within the state generates employment, increases local production and broadens the tax base.

The experience of states such as Gujarat, Maharashtra and Uttar Pradesh demonstrates that sustained industrial growth ultimately translates into stronger and more stable tax revenues.

The GST paradox, therefore, is not merely about declining collections. It is a reminder that taxation reflects the underlying structure of an economy. National tax reforms have unintentionally placed greater pressure on consumer-oriented states like Madhya Pradesh. The challenge now is not to resist reform but to adapt to it by strengthening domestic production, widening the tax base and building a more diversified economy.

If this transition is managed well, the present decline in GST collections may eventually be remembered not as a setback, but as the turning point that encouraged Madhya Pradesh to evolve from being primarily a market for goods produced elsewhere into one of India's major manufacturing and value-added economies.

The writer is a distinguished economist and former Head of the School of Economics at Devi Ahilya University (DAVU), Indore. An expert in fiscal policy and regional equity, he has published extensive research on MP's economic growth, tax mobilization and fiscal consolidation.

Despite improved rainfall, Kharif crop concerns persist

Depending on how the situation unfolds in the next six weeks, New Delhi may be forced to review its food and renewable energy policies

Weather Watch Group shows that the progress of area coverage for Kharif crops continues to lag last year's level. Across crops, the overall decline in planted area was 4.2 million hectares as of July 19. Acreage for coarse cereals and pulses is still lower than it was this time last year by 1.5 million ha and 1.2 million ha, respectively. Oilseeds and cotton, too, lag in planted area by about 6%.

With the delayed onset and tardy progress of the southwest monsoon, the planting window is now closed. Any further planting is subject to weather risk even for short-duration crops like moong, maize, and bajra.

The weekly sowing report from the Union Ministry of Agriculture is a compilation of reports filed by state governments. Usually, there is a lag in data collection and dissemination. By early August, one

may be able to gather a reasonably good idea about the planted area and, by implication, the crop prospects. It is becoming increasingly clear that the spatial distribution of rainfall for the rest of this month and for the whole of August will be crucial. At the same time, it is not clear whether El Nino would strengthen further and reduce the quantum of precipitation in August. With these uncertainties, it would be premature—indeed speculative—to talk about harvest prospects at this point in time.

It is worth remembering that monsoon-dependent agriculture usually does not spring major surprises. That said, the country has to brace for lower production of rice, coarse cereals, pulses, oilseeds, and cotton. The harvest size may be lower than not just the target but also from the last Kharif

levels. Looming production shortfalls, tightening supply-demand fundamentals, and food inflation cannot be wished away.

The situation is exacerbated by renewed hostilities in the Persian Gulf region. While the so-called 'truce' was always fragile and uncertain, military action in the last few days has once again drawn attention to the closure of passage through the critical Strait of Hormuz. With the recurrence of supply chain disruption even before normalisation was achieved, energy prices have again spiked. Brent is above \$90 a barrel.

The combination of climate and geopolitics means that New Delhi must get ready to address the looming food inflation and fuel inflation. It is going to be a daunting challenge. It is a matter of solace that we have adequate buffer stocks of rice and wheat, but that's

not everything. Traditionally, September to November are festival months when demand for food spikes.

Depending on how the situation unfolds in the next six weeks, New Delhi may be forced to review its food policy and renewable energy policy. The diversion of feedstock, like sugarcane, maize, and rice, for ethanol may have to be curtailed. Non-Basmati rice exports may be restricted in order to ensure domestic availability. The larger imports of vegetable oils, pulses, and cotton are, of course, a given. Customs duty on unrefined vegetable oils (10% ad valorem at present) and specified pulses may be waived for the time being. New Delhi has its task cut out.

G. Chandrashekhara is a senior journalist, policy commentator and commodity markets specialist. Views are personal.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Deportation Of Indians

Deportation of 18,000 Indians is on the cards, as Trump's administration has identified around 18,000 undocumented Indians. Ironically, undocumented Indians will get no chance to appeal, plead or engage a lawyer, and the number could swell much higher as Trump's ICE (Immigration Customs and Enforcement) teams have been conducting raids in full swing. India needs to tighten security so that people don't leave the country illegally.

Yashaswi Bairagi, Ujjain

Silence A Tool

Silence is a sign of strength and wisdom. It helps us think clearly, control our emotions, and make better decisions. In difficult situations, silence often prevents unnecessary arguments and misunderstandings. It also allows us to listen carefully and understand others. In today's noisy world, a few moments of silence can bring peace and improve our mental well-being. Therefore, silence is a powerful tool for personal growth and inner calm.

Isha Kolekar, Ujjain

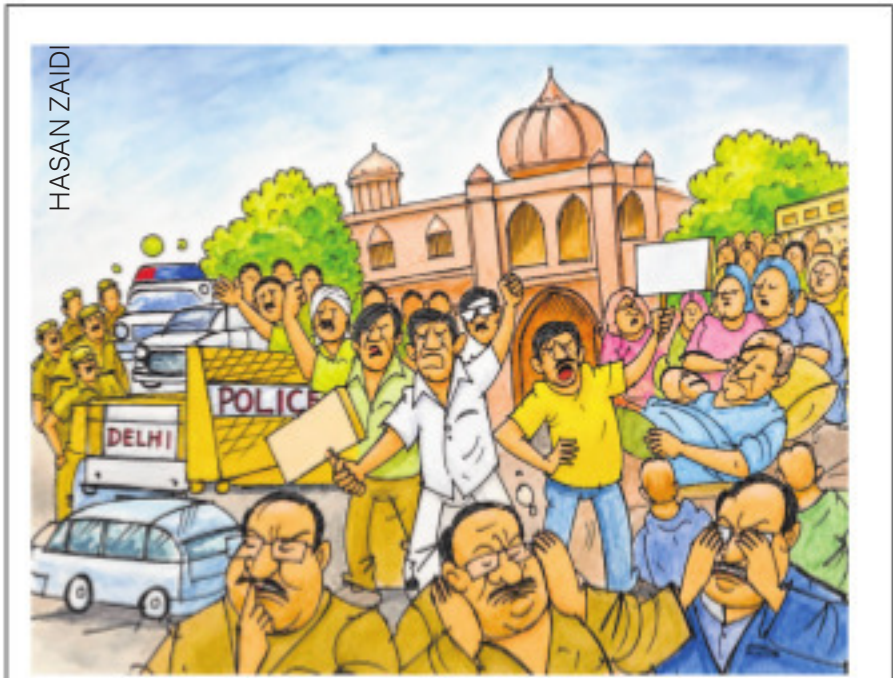
Congrats, Sindhu

Congratulations to PV Sindhu on her historic Japan Open title win. Her victory, achieved after overcoming injuries, setbacks, and intense competition, is a timely inspiration ahead of the Commonwealth Games and Asian Games. Sindhu has proved that success may not come quickly, but it certainly rewards those who remain patient, disciplined, and committed to their goals. Her journey reminds every aspiring sports person that perseverance is the true foundation of greatness. May this remarkable triumph motivate India's athletes to chase excellence and bring more laurels to the nation in the upcoming international events.

Mayank Lobhane, Indore

AI University

Karnataka's decision to establish India's first government-backed AI University will strengthen research, innovation and industry collaboration. The initiative can prepare a skilled workforce for the country's expanding



Think Of Students' Future

The meeting between BJP representatives and JP Nadda has yielded little, raising questions over the 22-day delay and the Prime Minister's silence. With eminent personalities endorsing the students' genuine concerns and the protests largely remaining peaceful, the government must act immediately. India's educational credibility is at stake. If confidence in Indian degrees declines globally, the loss will affect every student, including the children of today's politicians, and may become irreversible.

R.S. Narula, Patiala

artificial intelligence sector.

Aarna Jain, Ujjain

AI learning

Artificial intelligence can make education more personalised and accessible.

However, technology should complement critical thinking, creativity and classroom learning rather than replace the role of teachers and independent reasoning.

Anushka Joshi, Ujjain

Success mantra

Success builds confidence, creates opportunities and inspires others. However, lasting achievements come through discipline, perseverance, humility and continuous hard work rather than luck alone.

Garima Sen, Ujjain

Peace first

Escalating military action between the US and Iran threatens regional stability and global peace. The international community should prioritise diplomacy and dialogue to prevent further escalation and minimise humanitarian and economic consequences.

Divyanshi Prajapat, Ujjain

Farmer plight

The proposed Bidadi township threatens fertile farmland and thousands of farming families. The Karnataka government should reconsider land acquisition and prioritise livelihoods, environmental protection and meaningful dialogue over politically driven development projects.

Dr Vijaykumar H K, Raichur

Maritime law

Recent tensions over the Strait of Hormuz underline the need to uphold international maritime law. India should play a more active diplomatic role in defending freedom of navigation through multilateral forums.

A. Myilsami, Coimbatore

Messi inspires

Argentina's dramatic comeback against England showcased Lionel Messi's enduring brilliance. His leadership and creativity have set up a thrilling World Cup final against Spain, where another memorable performance is eagerly awaited.

A.P. Thiruvadi, Chennai

Climate concerns

Medical experts should scientifically assess whether Karnataka's climate and pollen levels worsen asthma. Reliable research can guide vulnerable patients while helping develop better public health strategies for respiratory illnesses.

PVP Madhu Nivriti, Secunderabad

Briefs

SKOPJE
N Macedonia sign pacts with India

India and North Macedonia agreed on Tuesday to double bilateral trade during President Droupadi Murmu’s historic state visit. Following delegation-level talks with President Gordana Siljanovska-Davkova, both nations pledged enhanced cooperation across key sectors, including IT, agriculture, pharmaceuticals, tourism, and filmmaking. President Murmu also announced India will double training slots for North Macedonia under the ITEC programme and welcomed the country’s intention to join major Indian-led global climate initiatives.

DUBAI
Doval holds talks with Saudi leaders

National Security Advisor Ajit Doval met with top Saudi leadership in Riyadh to review bilateral ties and address escalating tensions in West Asia. During his third visit to the Kingdom this year, Doval discussed regional stability, energy security, and the protection of crucial maritime corridors following new regional shipping threats.

ISLAMABAD
Pakistan forms crypto probe unit

Pakistan’s Federal Investigation Agency (FIA) has established a specialized cryptocurrency investigation unit to combat money laundering and terrorism financing, according to media reports Tuesday. Housed within the agency’s National Command and Control Centre, the unit will specifically probe the use of virtual assets in criminal activities, supporting inter-agency coordination and intelligence fusion. The initiative aligns with Pakistan’s ongoing reform efforts to maintain global anti-money laundering and counter-terrorist financing standards following its 2022 removal from the FATF grey-list.

HANOI
Bus crash fire kills seven in Vietnam

A overnight sleeper bus crash in southern Vietnam left seven people dead and five injured early Monday, authorities reported. The vehicle veered off the road near Dong Nai City around 2:30 am, striking two embankments before flames erupted from beneath and rapidly engulfed the passenger cabin. Driver Tran Thanh Hai attempted to evacuate passengers, but the fire spread too quickly.

ATHENS
Tourists stabbed near Acropolis

A 60-year-old man stabbed and wounded two Greek American tourists near the Acropolis on Tuesday morning in an apparently random attack, police reported. The victims—a 53-year-old man with a serious arm injury and a 48-year-old woman with a leg wound—were hospitalized with non-life-threatening injuries. Police detained the assailant at the scene, noting he appeared to suffer from psychological problems. The popular archaeological site remained open and operational following the early morning incident.

MILITARY ESCALATION | **Tehran attacks tanker & fires missiles at American military assets in Bahrain, Kuwait and Jordan**

US pummels Iran for 10th consecutive night

AP DUBAI

Iran attacked a tanker in the Strait of Hormuz early Tuesday, forcing its crew to abandon the ship, while the United States conducted yet another round of airstrikes targeting the Islamic Republic as they struggle over control of the key waterway.

The 10 consecutive nights of US airstrikes haven’t compelled Tehran to loosen its grip on the strait, through which about a fifth of all crude oil and natural gas traded once passed in peacetime.

“Iran and groups supportive of Iran may target other US interests overseas or at locations associated with the United States and Americans throughout the world,” the US State Department said in a new warning to Americans.

Meanwhile, the US military identified two soldiers who were killed in Jordan in attacks that left a third person missing. Separately, the military confirmed another death in Iraq on Saturday during the “controlled detonation” of a

Iranian minitser meets Munir in Pak to salvage interim US deal

Islamabad: An Iranian official began meetings Tuesday with mediators in Pakistan as diplomats sought to salvage the collapsed interim deal between Iran and the United States, even as both countries continued to launch attacks for a 10th day of renewed fighting. Iran’s Interior Minister Eskandar Momeni met Pakistan’s army chief Field Marshal Asim Munir, two officials said. The officials spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorised to discuss the matter publicly. Authorities did not immediately release details of the meeting. Momeni is also expected to meet Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif later Tuesday. **-AP**

downed Iranian drone.

President Donald Trump took to social media on Monday to warn that “Every time Iran kills an American Soldier they will pay for that killing many times over!” Trump was planning to attend a ceremony on Tuesday evening at Dover Air Force Base, where at least one service member’s remains were due to arrive.

Tehran rains missiles, drones on neighbours
Iran’s armed forces said Tuesday that they have carried

out missile and drone strikes against the US bases, assets and infrastructure in Bahrain, Kuwait and Jordan following another round of US attacks on Iran.

Iran’s Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) said in statements carried by its official news outlet Sepah News that its aerospace forces targeted US air defence systems, radar facilities, communications infrastructure and other military assets in Bahrain and Kuwait, as well as US military facilities in Jordan, Xinhua News Agency reported.

Philippines and China spar over violence near disputed shoal

Agencies BEIJING/MANILA

Philippine President Ferdinand Marcos Jr summoned China’s ambassador to Manila on Tuesday after a violent confrontation in the South China Sea, reciprocating a similar diplomatic summons issued by Beijing earlier in the day.

The incident occurred on July 20, 2026, near the disputed Second Thomas Shoal. Manila reported that Chinese personnel struck a Filipino sailor on the head with a wooden baton and damaged a navy boat.

The China Coast Guard claimed that two rubber boats dispatched from the grounded warship BRP Sierra Madre intentionally rammed a Chinese patrol vessel and that Filipino personnel attacked officers using oars and sticks.

Meanwhile, the US strongly condemned Beijing’s conduct, calling it dangerous, aggressive, and destabilising. State Department spokesperson Tommy Pigott reiterated Washington’s commitment to its treaty ally and reaffirmed the 2016 international arbitral ruling that invalidated China’s expansive maritime claims in the region.

Trump counters Mamdani, says Bibi won’t be arrested on US soil

Agencies WASHINGTON

US President **Donald Trump** said on Monday that Israeli Prime Minister **Benjamin Netanyahu** will not be arrested during his upcoming visit to the US, countering statements by New York City Mayor Zohran Mamdani.

Mamdani stated in a podcast interview that the city’s legal department is actively evaluating what local law permits regarding the execution of an International Criminal Court (ICC) arrest warrant against Netanyahu. The ICC issued the warrant in 2024



over alleged war crimes during the Gaza conflict.

“Benjamin Netanyahu will not be arrested, in any way, shape, or form, while in the United States of America,” Trump wrote on social media, praising Israel for its role in the Iran war. Neither the US nor Israel are members of the ICC.



Netanyahu usually visits New York every September to address the UN General Assembly. Israel rejected the ICC warrant as bogus and condemned Mamdani’s remarks. During his mayoral campaign, Mamdani insisted he would order police to arrest Netanyahu if he entered the city.

China’s live-fire exercise in Pacific Ocean angers Japan

AP TOKYO

Japan expressed concern after a Chinese navy destroyer conducted live-fire drills off a remote Japanese island in the Pacific Ocean on Sunday during its joint exercise with Russia, officials said Tuesday.

The Chinese Luyang III-class guided-missile destroyer conducted a live-fire exercise off Japan’s southernmost island of Okinotori, hours

after the Japanese navy spotted it operating alongside two other Chinese warships and a Russian frigate, the Japanese Joint Staff said.

Chief Cabinet Secretary Minoru Kihara told reporters Tuesday that his government conveyed concerns that the live-fire drills posed a potential safety threat to nearby vessels. He noted that ships near the area received a notice from the Chinese warships just before the drills started.

Indian diplomats at UN mission still displaced 3 weeks after evacuation

PTI NEW YORK

Indian diplomats at the Permanent Mission of India to the UN are still displaced from their premises three weeks after evacuation orders were issued for them after structural damage was reported in a high-rise under-construction building.

The building of the Permanent Mission of India to the United Nations, located

ASEAN holds security talks amid W Asia, SCS crises

AP MANILA

Southeast Asia’s top diplomats opened three days of talks in the Philippine capital on Tuesday with an agenda topped by their most daunting security problems and a backdrop of unfolding crises led by the resurging war in Iran and a violent skirmish in the disputed South China Sea.

The foreign ministers of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations met behind closed doors in Manila before issuing a joint statement calling for an immediate halt to fighting in the Middle East and the full and safe reopening of the Strait of Hormuz.

“We expressed serious concern over the rapidly evolving situation in the Middle East, particularly the renewed hostilities involving the United States of America and the Islamic Republic of Iran,” the ASEAN ministers said.

The ministers also said they reaffirmed the obligations of states to peacefully resolve their differences and respect national sovereignty and territorial integrity.

Southeast Asia, a bustling region of more than 680 million people, relies heavily on Middle East oil and gas.

Starmer’s loyalists fired, PIO ministers in Team Burnham

PTI LONDON

British Prime Minister Andy Burnham finalised his top team within hours of taking charge at 10 Downing Street and promoted British Indian minister for artificial intelligence (AI) Kanishka Narayan to the Cabinet, and purging allies of predecessor Keir Starmer from the government.

Burnham, who was invited to form the government by King Charles on Monday, set about unveiling the team of ministers who will join him around the Cabinet table soon after.

Lisa Nandy is another Indian-origin minister who holds on to her department, with additional responsibilities as Secretary of State for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport.

Narayan said his elevation, as Minister for AI, falling jointly within the Cabinet Office and the Department for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade, is a sign of the new PM’s “deep commitment to AI’s importance”.

“AI is likely the most significant technology in human history. Its impact will dwarf



other things. The best case for it is compelling beyond our dreams: a reindustrialised Britain, stronger national security, public services transformed for the better,” said Narayan, who was elected as the first Indian-origin member of Parliament from Wales in the July 2024 general election.

“The risks, too, are real: it is right that the British public shares those worries, for jobs, for the pace of change. The central fact is that it is happening. Nations have a narrow window to decide whether they shape AI or get shaped by it. Britain is in that window right now,” he said.

The 36-year-old Bihar-born Labour MP for the Vale of Glamorgan, who held the AI brief as a junior minister in former prime minister Keir Starmer’s team, pledged to act with “pace and ambition” and “focus relentlessly on securing British influence in shaping AI”.

Israel building miles-long earthen barrier inside Gaza

AP CAIRO

The Israeli military is quietly but quickly building a giant earthen barrier separating the over 50 per cent of the Gaza Strip it controls from the rest of the territory, according to satellite imagery, further entrenching the division of the tiny Palestinian enclave.

More than 23 kilometres have been constructed in recent months, running through Palestinian communities demolished by the military. That is equivalent to more than half the length of the coastal strip, which is some 40 kilometres long and 11 kilometres wide, and home to over 2 million Palestinians.

When presented with the satellite images, Israel’s military confirmed to The Associated Press it has built a physical barrier in the area of the so-called yellow line, the boundary to which Israeli troops withdrew under the October ceasefire deal with Hamas. The line was envisioned in the US-backed agreement as a temporary division of the territory pending a fuller Israeli withdrawal.

But as the truce stagnates, it appears Israel is digging in, heightening Palestinian fears that the line is morphing into a border.

100 migrants on way to Europe dead or missing off Mauritania, says UN

AP NOUAKCHOTT

The United Nations refugee agency said Tuesday it is “extremely saddened” after well over 100 people died or went missing from boats off Mauritania last week while trying to make their way to Europe.

The agency said 144 people were dead or missing after two incidents between July 14 and 18. It said 387 people were rescued.

Mauritania’s coast guard has said 122 people went missing off the coast near the capital, Nouakchott. It said the boat carrying 160 people from Gambia toward the Canary Islands ran out of fuel and was stranded at sea for 25 days.

In a separate incident, the coast guard said it rescued 179 people who had boarded a boat from Senegal on Saturday.

The difference in the numbers given was not

Five drown in Ohio river

Powell: Five adults drowned in the Scioto River on Sunday night after attempting to rescue a struggling swimmer during a family fishing outing, authorities confirmed Monday. The victims included two sets of parents, leaving multiple young children orphaned.

immediately clear.

Mauritania’s waters have become a major route for people from sub-Saharan Africa seeking a better life in Europe as economic opportunities remain scarce at home.

The route toward the Canary Islands is “one of the world’s deadliest” with long distances and unseaworthy and overcrowded boats, the UN agency said in a statement.

Trump admin opens probe into Harvard’s financial aid

AP WASHINGTON

The Justice Department is investigating whether Harvard University is allowing Chinese donors to create scholarships that exclude American students, adding to the barrage of federal inquiries the Trump adminis-

tration has opened in its battle against the Ivy League school.

Justice Department officials announced the new review Monday, saying Harvard’s foreign funding disclosures “raised concerns” about possible discrimination against US students. The agency did not specify which scholarship programmes are

being targeted and emphasized it “has not reached any conclusions.”

The investigation is aimed at Harvard’s “China-based financial aid programs,” the Justice Department said. The agency said Chinese donors have given money to Harvard to support financial aid programmes limited to students

from certain countries. That restriction could amount to illegal discrimination based on country of origin, the department said.

“Schools cannot take federal dollars and then turn around and accept money from foreign sources to give financial aid that deliberately excludes American citizens —

doing so is illegal, and we will stop it wherever we find it,” said Harmeet Dhillon, who leads the department’s Civil Rights Division. Harvard said it was reviewing the Justice Department notice.

“Harvard follows the law for required reporting of donations,” the university said in a written statement.

new study
Spouse’s dementia ups partner’s risk

Agencies SYDNEY

Partners do not simply grow old together, they often grow more alike.

Decades of shared routines, environments and experiences leave couples with increasingly similar health profiles, a pattern long recognised for obesity, diabetes and heart disease and stroke.

Could dementia now belong on that list? A new nationwide study from

Taiwan suggests the answer is yes -- but not for the reason many headlines might imply.

In this study involving almost one million married adults, researchers found that when one spouse developed dementia, the other was significantly more likely to receive the same diagnosis.

This observation itself is not entirely new.

Smaller studies have reported similar findings over the past decade. What



distinguishes this study is its scale and ability to explore how age, income and family circumstances shape that

risk.

Researchers analysed health-care records enrolled in Taiwan’s national health insurance program between 1998 and 2022.

The study included more than 190,000 people whose spouse had a new diagnosis of dementia and compared them to more than 760,000 people who did not have dementia or a spouse with dementia. Participants were matched according to age, sex, income and residential location before being fol-

lowed over time to determine whether they subsequently developed dementia themselves.

The analyses also accounted for participants’ medical conditions, health-care use and family size. This meant the researchers could ask a more sophisticated question: will someone whose partner has dementia still be more likely to get a diagnosis themselves, even after accounting for the factors couples already share? The answer was yes.

sp Briefs

NEW YORK
Golden snapshot
Topps will release a trading card featuring an iconic photo of a young Lionel Messi holding infant Lamine Yamal. The image, taken during a UNICEF fundraiser years ago, has gained legendary status as Yamal emerges as one of football's brightest stars.

MADRID
Stamp of glory



Spain's World Cup triumph is now immortalised on a commemorative postage stamp. The special issue features La Roja's crest with two stars, marking the nation's 2010 and 2026 FIFA World Cup titles, celebrating a landmark moment in Spanish football history.

MADRID
Adeyemi arrives
Barcelona will officially unveil German forward Karim Adeyemi on Wednesday. The 24-year-old joins from Borussia Dortmund as the Spanish champions' second major summer signing, adding pace and versatility to Hansi Flick's attacking options.

GARISSA
Whistle of hope



Somali refugee Janay Issack Adhan, a 41-year-old mother of 12, is breaking cultural barriers by coaching football in Kenya's Dadaab refugee camp, using the sport to steer young people away from drugs, crime and dangerous migration.

IPSWICH
Towering new keeper
Premier League side Ipswich Town have signed 6ft 6in Dutch goalkeeper Kayne van Oevelen on a five-year deal. The 22-year-old joins from FC Volendam after impressing in the Eredivisie despite the club's relegation.

BERLIN
Laimer stays
Bayern Munich have extended Austria international Konrad Laimer's contract until 2029. The versatile 29-year-old, who has won two Bundesliga titles with Bayern, remains a key figure in Vincent Kompany's squad.

BCCI DROPS MASSIVE OVERHAUL | Bowlers face match ban for deliberate infractions; declarations, wicketkeeping rules also revamped

NO-BALL, NO-GAME

PTI
BENGALURU
The BCCI has introduced sweeping changes to the playing conditions for the 2026-27 domestic season, headlined by a stringent new rule that will see bowlers suspended for the remainder of the match if they deliberately bowl a front-foot no-ball or a non-landing delivery. The revised law, adopted from recommendations by the Marylebone Cricket Club (MCC), replaces the earlier provision under which the offending bowler was barred only from bowling in that innings. The decision on whether the delivery was deliberate will rest with the on-field umpires under Law 41.8. "Bowler suspended for deliberate front foot no ball cannot bowl in the whole match," the BCCI said in a circular circulated to all state associations.

RULE BREAKDOWN

1. Deliberate No-Ball - Match Ban
Offending bowler suspended for the remainder of the match
Earlier rule: Barred only from bowling in that innings
Decision rests with on-field umpires (Law 41.8)
Applies to deliberate front-foot no-balls and non-landing deliveries

2. Final Over Must Be Completed
Even if a wicket falls during the final over
MCC
felt previous rule unfairly denied teams the opportunity to send in a new batter late in the day

3. No Declaration or Forfeiture in Final Innings
Intended to prevent contrived results
Preserves the integrity of first-class cricket

4. Wicketkeeping Gloves - Relaxed Rule
Gloves need to remain

5. Head Coaches on Field
Allowed to enter the field during drinks breaks in domestic one-day matches
Aligns with similar proposal under consideration by the ICC

KEY RULE CHANGES

RULE	CHANGE
Deliberate no-ball	Match-long suspension for offending bowler
Final over completion	Over must be completed even if a wicket falls
Declaration/forfeiture	Banned in final innings to prevent contrived results
Wicketkeeping gloves	Need to stay behind stumps only at delivery, not throughout run-up
Coaches on field	Head coaches allowed on field during drinks breaks in domestic one-day matches

IMPACT ON DOMESTIC CRICKET

RULE	EXPECTED IMPACT
Deliberate no-ball ban	Stronger deterrence against intentional errors
Final over completion	Fair opportunity for batting team late in the day
No declaration in final innings	Prevents contrived results; protects integrity
Wicketkeeping glove rule	Reduces unnecessary no-balls; more stumpings
Coaches on field	Better communication during drinks breaks

Bowler suspended for deliberate front foot no ball cannot bowl in the whole match."

BCCI Circular

Madrid painted Red

A KING'S WELCOME | Two million fans erupt in euphoria as Spain's World Cup heroes parade through capital in historic celebration



IAN S
MADRID
Nearly two million fans flooded the streets of Madrid to celebrate Spain's second FIFA World Cup title as the newly crowned champions received a heroes' welcome after their 1-0 extra-time victory over Argentina in the final. Spain, who lifted the trophy thanks to Ferran Torres' extra-time winner in New Jersey, returned home to a grand reception led by King Felipe VI and Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez, both of whom had travelled to witness the final. "The unity of this team has been extraordinary," King Felipe VI said while congratulating the world champions.

CELEBRATIONS
The celebrations gathered momentum as the players boarded an open-top bus from Moncloa Palace, with an estimated 1.8 million supporters lining Madrid's streets. The parade culminated at the iconic Plaza de Cibeles, where another 120,000 fans awaited the champions amid live performances by Spanish pop stars. The jubilant squad lifted the World Cup trophy before thousands of chanting supporters, with defender Marc Cucurella entertaining the crowd by playing the drums. Celebrations continued until nearly midnight despite temperatures soaring above 35°C.

Champions' Parade
(Top) World Cup-winning heroes parade through the streets of Madrid with the coveted trophy, greeted by thousands of jubilant fans celebrating La Roja's historic 2026 FIFA World Cup triumph
(Bottom) Spain's World Cup-winning squad proudly poses with the FIFA World Cup trophy after arriving at Madrid airport, receiving a heroes' welcome AP/PTI

ARGENTINA STILL STANDS



Fans embrace defeated heroes with open arms
IAN S
EZEIZA

Argentina's FIFA World Cup 2026 runners-up received a rousing heroes' welcome on returning home despite their heart-breaking 1-0 extra-time defeat to Spain in the final. A red carpet, military band and thousands of passionate supporters turned the team's arrival into an emotional celebration. Coach Lionel Scaloni and the squad were greeted by the Grenadier Regiment at Ezeiza Airport before boarding an open-top bus to the Lionel Andrés Messi Training Centre. Fans waving blue-and-white flags, beating drums and wearing Lionel Messi's iconic No. 10 jersey lined the route, thanking the team for its inspiring campaign.

MESSI ABSENT
Lionel Messi, who is widely expected to have played his final World Cup match, did not travel with the squad after the Argentine Football Association confirmed that several players would return separately.

FIFA launches probe as Argentina stars accused of attacking Spain players

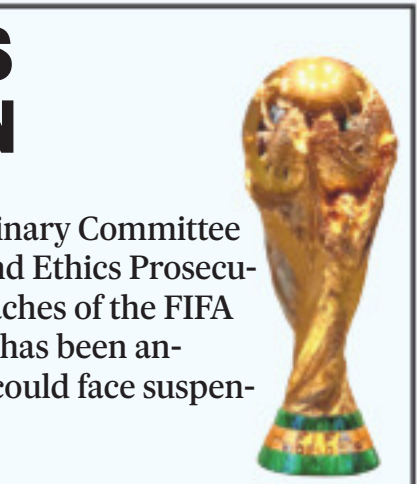
AP
EAST RUTHERFORD (US)
Spain's 1-0 extra-time victory over Argentina in the FIFA World Cup 2026 final has been overshadowed by a post-match brawl, with FIFA launching a disciplinary investigation into clashes that erupted during the champions' on-field celebrations.

The flashpoint came moments after Spain lifted their second World Cup trophy. Video footage showed Argentina midfielder Leandro Paredes allegedly grabbing Spain defender Eric García by the throat before shoving substitute Gavi to the ground when he intervened. Spain captain Rodri also appeared to be struck in the stomach by Nahuel Molina, while Nicolas Otamendi was seen confronting his former Manchester City teammate.

FIFA STATEMENT:
"The disciplinary committee has appointed a Disciplinary and Ethics Prosecutor to investigate potential breaches of the FIFA Disciplinary Code."

Argentina coach Lionel Scaloni and several players stepped in to calm the situation before it escalated further.

FIFA CONFIRMS INVESTIGATION
FIFA confirmed that its Disciplinary Committee has appointed a Disciplinary and Ethics Prosecutor to investigate potential breaches of the FIFA Disciplinary Code. No timeline has been announced, but players involved could face suspensions or other sanctions.



CONTROVERSY BEYOND THE BRAWL
The tense finish followed an emotional final in which: Enzo Fernandez was sent off after receiving a second yellow card in stoppage time
Argentina were reduced to 10 men before Ferran Torres scored the decisive

winner in the 106th minute
Argentina's players stood with their backs to the podium while Spain lifted the World Cup trophy
Spain had earlier formed a guard of honour for the runners-up during the medal ceremony



SEVEN STARS SHINE | Anahat cruises, Saanvi survives epic thriller as seven Indians stamp authority

RACQUETS IN OVERDRIVE

IAN S

NIAGARA-ON-THE- LAKE

India enjoyed a flying start to the World Squash Junior Championships 2026, with seven players advancing to the next round, led by women's top seed Anahat Singh, who continued her quest to become the country's first junior world champion.

Anahat outclassed Australia's Lilly Wilson 11-2, 11-1, 11-3, while Saanvi Kalanki battled past the Netherlands' Elcke Mols in a gripping five-game contest 11-9, 9-11, 11-8, 7-11, 11-6.

Anika Dubey eased past Japan's Anna Kuwahara 11-7, 11-3, 11-5, while Rudra Singh advanced after receiving a walkover from Nigeria's Khadija Abdullaheem.

In the boys' draw, Aryaveer Dewan, Yusha Nafees and Gurveer Singh made winning starts after first-round byes. Aryaveer defeated Germany's Levi Visser in straight games, Yusha blanked Brazil's Matheus Frabetti 11-1, 11-1, 11-1, and Gurveer overcame Ireland's Christian Dromgoole in four games. Purav Rambhia, however, bowed out against England's Ronnie

Hickling.

The individual championship runs until July 25, followed by the team competition from July 26-31.

BRIEF SCORES

Women's Draw – First Round

Player	Result	Opponent	Score
Anahat Singh	Won	Lilly Wilson (Australia)	11-2, 11-1, 11-3
Saanvi Kalanki	Won	Elcke Mols (Netherlands)	11-9, 9-11, 11-8, 7-11, 11-6

Anika Dubey	Won	Anna Kuwahara (Japan)	11-7, 11-3, 11-5
Rudra Singh	Won	Khadija Abdullaheem (Nigeria)	Walkover

Boys' Draw – First Round

Player	Result	Opponent	Score
Aryaveer Dewan	Won	Levi Visser (Germany)	Straight games
Yusha Nafees	Won	Matheus Frabetti (Brazil)	11-1, 11-1, 11-1
Gurveer Singh	Won	Christian Dromgoole (Ireland)	Four games
Purav Rambhia	Lost	Ronnie Hickling (England)	-



India U-19 tighten grip as Manal's 150 rocks Lanka

MANAL & OJHA SHOW | 150, 111 & 289 - India U-19 dominate with bat and ball as Sri Lanka crumble to 122/8 on Day 2

PTI

COLOMBO

India U-19 seized complete control of the second Youth Test after Manal Chauhan's magnificent 150 and a disciplined bowling display left Sri Lanka U-19 struggling at 122/8 at stumps on Day 2.

Resuming on 253/3, India piled up 411 all out, with overnight batter Manal converting his fifty into a career-best 150 off 244 balls (20 fours, 1 six). He received excellent support from Kushagra Ojha (111) as the duo

stitched a 155-run fourth-wicket partnership, following the 122-run stand between Ojha and skipper Yashobardhan Chauhan (78) on Day 1.

Although India lost their final six wickets for 134 runs, Manal anchored the innings superbly before becoming the ninth wicket to fall.

The Indian bowlers then took charge, reducing Sri Lanka to 122/8, with Pranav Raghavendra (2/28), C. Venkata (2/23) and Rohit Yadav (2/4) sharing six wickets.

BRIEF SCORES

SRI LANKA UNDER-19 - 122 for loss of eight wickets (Sigera 31, Rohit 2-4, Venkata 2-23, Raghavendra 2-28) trail **INDIA UNDER-19 - 411 all out** (Manal 150, Ojha 111, Yashbardhan 78, Gimhan 3-102) by 289 runs

Dulnith Sigera (31) was the hosts' top scorer before being bowled by Rohit.

India now hold a commanding 289-run first-innings lead and are firmly on course for victory.

INDIA STORM OFF THE BLOCKS

IAN S

MUSCAT

India made a dream start to the FIH Youth Hockey5s Asian Championship 2026, with both the sub-junior men's and women's teams registering emphatic victories on the opening day in Muscat, Oman. The women's side thrashed Kazakhstan 8-3, while the men's team outplayed Bangladesh 7-3 to begin their campaigns on a winning note.

The Indian women were led by Diya, who struck a superb hat-trick (14', 15', 20'), while Sandeepa Kumari (2 goals), Nousheen Naz (2) and Nilam Topno (1) completed the rout. India dominated from the outset, building a commanding lead before Diya sealed the victory with three second-half goals.

Anuj, Gaurav lead charge in MP Snooker C'ship

Our Sports Reporter

INDORE

Top cueists continued to impress at the 40th MP State Snooker Championship as Anuj Verma, Gaurav Tandon, Nikhil Dariyani and Ovesh Khan advanced to the next round with convincing victories at the Billiards Academy, Nehru Stadium.

Organised under the aegis of the Madhya Pradesh Billiards and Snooker Association (MPBSA), the championship witnessed several closely fought contests. Anuj Verma edged past Akshay Jain 2-1, while Gaurav Tandon overcame Pratik Sharma 2-1. Nikhil Dariyani also sealed a 2-1 win over Sandeep Mandwani, and Ovesh Khan progressed to the next stage.

Among other results, Sumit Bhanage outclassed Shahrulkh Khan 2-0, Mithilesh W defeated Md. Saffan 2-1, Amit



DAY II RESULTS

Anuj Verma beat Akshay Jain 2-1, Gaurav Tandon beat Pratik Sharma 2-1, Nikhil Dariyani beat Sandeep Mandwani 2-1, Ovesh Khan advanced, Sumit Bhanage beat Shahrulkh Khan 2-0, Amit Tomar beat Harsh Boyat 2-0, Rishabh Pitalia beat Anant Tiwari 2-1, Irfan Kash beat Ishan Saundar 2-0, Ritik Jain beat Milan Singh 2-0

Tomar beat Harsh Boyat 2-0, Rishabh Pitalia got the better of Anant Tiwari 2-1, Irfan Kash overcame Ishan Saundar 2-0, while Ritik Jain registered a comfortable 2-0 victory over Milan Singh.

NDPS prodigy Prayan qualifies for nationals

Class V student finishes runner-up in MP U-11 Chess Championship, books national berth



Our Sports Reporter

INDORE

Prayan Chopra, a class V student of New Digambar Public School (NDPS), has earned a place in the National Under-11 Chess Championship after finishing runner-up at the Madhya Pradesh U-11 State Chess Championship 2026 held in Dewas.

Organised by the Dewas District Chess Association, the tournament featured 148 players from across Madhya Pradesh. Displaying exceptional composure and tactical brilliance, Prayan secured second place, earning a trophy,

Rs 1,800 cash prize, and qualification for the national championship, where he will represent the state.

"Prayan's achievement reflects his dedication and the quality guidance of our coaches. We wish him success at the national level," said the NDPS management.

School chairperson Sindhu Sudhakar Mendke, principal Winston Gomez, and manager DM Thokar congratulated Prayan, while appreciating the efforts of sports coordinator Seemant Srivastava and coaches Himanshu Saxena, Prakash Yadav, and Nikki Parihar.

Kshitij, Kiyan & Sujay top podium

Our Sports Reporter

INDORE

Kshitij Singh Gaur, Kiyan Porwal and Sujay Jain clinched titles in their respective categories as the Second International Chess Day Trophy, carrying a Rs 1 lakh prize purse, concluded after six rounds of intense competition at Shri Cloth Market Vaishnav Higher Secondary School.

Organised jointly by the Unite Indore Chess Club and Shri Vaishnav Sports Academy, the state-level tournament also crowned Sejarshree Choubey (U-10 Girls), Swara Surya (U-15 Girls) and Tanvi Chandak (U-20 Girls) as champions.

Chief guest Nandkishore Pahariya and MP Olympic As-

BRIEF SCORES

CATEGORY WINNER

U-10 Boys	Kshitij Singh Gaur
U-10 Girls	Sejarshree Choubey
U-15 Boys	Kiyan Porwal
U-15 Girls	Swara Surya
U-20 Boys	Sujay Jain
U-20 Girls	Tanvi Chandak

sociation vice-president Om Soni felicitated the winners, praising the tournament for providing young players with valuable competitive exposure.

Event Director Kamal Verma said the titles were decided after six closely fought rounds, with several categories settled on tie-breaks. A total of 62 players were rewarded with cash prizes, trophies, medals and certificates.

DC win back-to-back IPSC team crown

CHECKMATE DOMINATION | Captain Rishabh Kumar makes history with fourth straight individual title

Our Sports Reporter

INDORE

Daly College etched its name in Indian school chess history by winning the All India IPSC Under-19 Team Chess Championship 2026 for the second consecutive year, while captain Rishabh Kumar claimed the individual national title for the fourth straight year, completing a remarkable double triumph.

Hosted by Emerald Heights International School, the championship saw Daly College remain unbeaten en route to the team gold. The side defeated Mayo College, Yadavindra Public School, DPS Mathura Road, and Mod-



ern School by an identical 2.5-1.5 margin.

Rishabh led from the front with a perfect 4/4 in the team event. He was ably supported by Mohammad Ashaj Ahmed (2.5/4), Samanyu Shukla (2.5/4), Ranveer Bhatia (1/2) and reserve player Abir Kumar.

In the individual cham-

pionship, Rishabh Kumar once again dominated the field, scoring 6.5/7 to remain unbeaten and lift his fourth consecutive IPSC national crown (2023-2026). He defeated six opponents, including top seed Vivian Jha of DPS R.K. Puram, with his only draw coming against team-

mate Mohammad Ashaj Ahmed. The feat also earned him selection as captain of the IPSC Under-19 team for the SGFI National Championship for the fourth successive year.

RISHABH'S LEGACY

Year	Achievement
2023	IPSC Individual Champion
2024	IPSC Individual Champion
2025	IPSC Individual Champion
2026	IPSC Individual Champion (4th in a row)

"This historic achievement reflects the dedication, discipline and excellence of our players. We are proud of the team and wish them success at the SGFI Nationals," said Daly College principal Dr Gunmeet Bindra.

Indore gears up for National MMA showdown

MMA MISSION | National Championship, World Cup trials & grand International Fight Night set to rock the city

Our Sports Reporter

INDORE

Indore is set to host the 9th National Mixed Martial Arts (MMA) Championship from

July 24 to 26, bringing together top fighters from across the country in a mega event that will also serve as the selection trials for India's team for the Georgia World Cup.

Organising committee chairman Prabal Pratap Singh Tomar and Secretary Bhagirath Rathore said the championship, themed around women's empowerment and

child protection, aims to promote self-defence and confidence among women while providing Indian fighters a pathway to the international stage.

The three-day event will culminate with a Grand International Fight Night on July 26, featuring international bouts and a special musical performance by Sajid-Wajid Khan. Bol-

lywood personalities, including filmmaker Madhur Bhandarkar, actors Rajat Bedi and Vicky Kajla, along with noted Haryanvi singers, are expected to attend.

Hangzhou WC sets Asian Games tone
HANGZHOU: India's shooters will face their final major test before the Asian Games when the ISSF World Cup begins in Hangzhou on Wednesday,

with continental powerhouse China providing the perfect benchmark ahead of the Aichi-Nagoya Games (September 19-October 4).

वसई-विरार शहर महानगरपालिका

मुख्य कार्यालय, विरार, विरार (प.),
ता. वसई, जि. पालघर - ४०१ ३०३.

दूरध्वनी: ०२५०-२५२५१०१/०२/०३/०४/०५/०६
फॅक्स: ०२५०-२५२५१०७

ईमेल: vasaivirarcorporation@yahoo.com

जाहिर ई-निविदा सूचना
(निविदा द्वितीय मुदतवाद)

वसई विरार शहर महानगरपालिका कार्यक्षेत्रातील घनकचरा व्यवस्थापन विभागातर्फे डी.बी.एफ.ओ.टी. (DBFOT) तत्वावर २० वर्षांच्या कालावधीसाठी शहरात निर्माण होणारा राडारोडा (Construction & Demolition Waste) गोळा करून संकलन, वाहतुक, प्रक्रिया आणि पुनर्वापर सुविधीची रचना, बांधकाम, संचालन व देखभाल आणि विल्हेवाट लावणे या कामाकामी जाहिर ई-निविदा सूचना प्रसिध्द करण्यात आलेली होती.

सदर कामाची व्याप्ती व ठेकेदारांचा प्रतिसाद लक्षात घेता, या निविदा प्रक्रियेस द्वितीय मुदतवाद देण्यात येत आहे.

सुधारित वेळापत्रकाचा तपशील खालीलप्रमाणे आहे:

१. ऑनलाईन ई-निविदा स्वीकृतीची अंतिम दिनांक :- दि. ०५/०८/२०२६ रोजी सायं. ५.०० वाजेपर्यंत.

२. ऑनलाईन ई-निविदा उघडण्याचा दिनांक :- दि. १०/०८/२०२६ रोजी दु. ३.०० वाजेपर्यंत.

सदर निविदेबाबतच्या अटी, शर्ती व सविस्तर शुध्दिपत्रकाचा तपशील महाराष्ट्र शासनाच्या <https://mahatender.gov.in> या संकेतस्थळावर उपलब्ध आहे. ई-निविदा प्रक्रियेत कोणत्याही तांत्रिक अडचणीसाठी, कृपया वसई विरार शहर महानगरपालिकेच्या घनकचरा व्यवस्थापन विभागाशी संपर्क साधा किंवा aarogyheadoffice@gmail.com वर ईमेल करा.

दिनांक : २१/०७/२०२६
स्थळ : विरार

सही/-
(अर्चना दिवे)
उप-आयुक्त,
घनकचरा व्यवस्थापन विभाग
वसई विरार शहर महानगरपालिका

जायक क्र.: व.वि.श.म./घ.क.व्य./५९९/२०२६

PIRAMAL FINANCE LTD.
CIN: L65910MH1984PLC032639

Registered Office: Unit No.-601, 6th Floor, Piramal Amliti Building, Piramal Agastya Corporate Park, Kamani Junction, Opp. Fire Station, LBS Marg, Kuria (west), Mumbai-400070 -T +91 22 3802 4000

Branch Office: 503-505 Floor, Airen Heights Sch No.54,PU-3, Vijay Nagar, Indore- 452010

Contact Person:1. Piramal Finance Ltd - 022-69482444

E-Auction Sale Notice - Subsequent Sale

Pursuant to taking possession of the secured asset mentioned hereunder by the Authorized Officer of Piramal Finance Ltd (Formerly Piramal Capital & Housing Finance Ltd.) under the **Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002** for the recovery of amount due from borrower's, offers are invited by the undersigned for purchase of immovable property, as described hereunder, which is in the possession, on 'As is Where is Basis', 'As is What is Basis' and 'Whatever is There is Basis', Particulars of which are given below:

Loan Code/Branch/ Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s)	Demand Notice Date and Amount	Property Address- final	Reserve Price	Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) (10% of RP)	Outstanding Amount (21-07-2026)
Loan Code No.: HLSA000649D4, Satna (Branch), Anita Singh (Borrower), Dinesh Pal Patel (Co Borrower 1)	Dt: 24-02-2025, Rs. 24,73,218.89/-, (Rs. Twenty Four Lakh Seventy Three Thousand Two Hundred Eighteen Only and Eighty Nine Paise)	All The Piece And Parcel of The Property Having An Extent:- Arazi Khasra No. 1443/1/2 Area 100'70 =7000 Sq.ft/ 850.55 Sq. Mtr/ 0.085he. Total Area 7000 Sq.ft/ 850.55 Sq.mtr/ 0.085he A Part of Area Admeasuring 7000 Sq.ft/ 850.55 Sq.mtr (House Construction Thereon) Situated At Mouza Gunour Patwari Halka No. 17, Nagar Panchayat Gunour Ward No. 12 Tehsil- Gunour Dist Panna Madhya Pradesh Boundaries: North: Proposed Road, South: Arazi of Virendra Tiwari, East: Plot of Mukesh Soni, West: Arazi of Ramkishan Tiwari	Rs. 21,70,800/- (Rs. Twenty One Lakh Seventy Thousand Eight Hundred Only)	Rs. 2,17,080/- (Rs. Two Lakh Seventeen Thousand Eighty Only)	Rs. 30,42,531/- (Rs. Thirty Lakh Forty Two Thousand Five Hundred Thirty One Only)
Loan Code No.: HLSA00057BED, Rewa (Branch), Vinayesh Gupta (Borrower), Anjali Gupta (Co-Borrower 1)	Dt: 24-01-2025, Rs. 11,92,169/-, (Rs. Eleven Lakh Ninety Two Thousand One Hundred Sixty Nine Only)	All The Piece And Parcel of The Property Having An Extent :- Khasra No. 1141/1, Admeasuring Area of 111,524 Sq. Mt (Out of Total Area of 0.2394 Hectarein Part 17/5/2394, Land Mouza Kota Gram Panchayat Kota Vikas Khand Simour, Rewa, Madhya Pradesh 486445 Boundaries: North: Sujit Kumar Gupta Land, South: Seller Remaining Rubka (Acreage), East: 12 Ft Proposed Road Given By The Purchaser, West: The Land of Rakishor Kushwaha (Property Type As Per Sale Deed is Plot) Boundaries As:- North:- Remaining Land of Vinayesh Gupta Afterward Plot of Dubey Ji West:- Land of Sajjan Singh Kushwaha East:- 12 Feet Road South:- Land of Sujet Gupta	Rs. 9,39,600/- (Rs. Nine Lakh Thirty Nine Thousand Six Hundred Only)	Rs. 93,960/- (Rs. Ninety Three Thousand Nine Hundred Sixty Only)	Rs. 14,99,212/- (Rs. Fourteen Lakh Ninety Nine Thousand Two Hundred Twenty Only)
Loan Code No.: BLSA0000AC59, Chhindwara (Branch), Ramesh Kumar (Borrower), Santoshi Sharma (Co Borrower 1)	Dt: 16-09-2024, Rs. 10,00,691.8/-, (Rs. Ten Lakh Six Hundred Ninety One Only and Eighty Paise)	All The Piece And Parcel of The Property Having An Extent:- Khasra No. 37/211, A Vacant Na Plot Measuring 675 Sq.ft This Plot is Located In Mangalipeth (Ambedkar Ward No. 22) For Residential Purposes, Located More Than 20 Meters From The Main Road In The Rest of The Ward, The Plot is Adjacent To National Highway of Other District Road, Details of Mouza Land Village: Mangalipeth (Ambedkar Wardno. 22) P H No. 103, R N M Seoni Part 02 Bhagat Singh Ward, Ambedkar Nagar, Near Hanuman Temple Tehsil Seoni District Seoni Madhya Pradesh 480661 Boundaries: North: Others Land, South: Others Land, East: Others Land, West: Kalpith Rasta	Rs. 8,58,600/- (Rs. Eight Lakh Fifty Eight Thousand Six Hundred Only)	Rs. 85,860/- (Rs. Eighty Five Thousand Eight Hundred Sixty Only)	Rs. 14,23,704/- (Rs. Fourteen Lakh Twenty Three Thousand Seven Hundred Four Only)
Loan Code No.: 08200003889 & 08200003890, Jabalpur (Branch), Rohit Bawaria (Borrower), Anamika Rituraj (Co Borrower 1)	Dt: 27-10-2023, Rs. 31,12,257/-, (Rs. Thirty One Lakh Twelve Thousand Two Hundred Fifty Seven Only) & Dt: 27-10-2023, Rs. 2,73,802/-, (Rs. Two Lakh Seventy Three Thousand Eight Hundred Two Only)	All The Piece And Parcel of The Property Having An Extent:- Plot No. 21, House No. 461, Basni Mangalm Kh No- 27/67 N B No. 1, Mouza- Rampur, Ramnag Colony, ward No-4 Ton & Dis- Jabalpur Madhya Pradesh:- 482001 Boundaries As:- North:- House of Mr. Satish Ji West:- Colony Road East:- Other House (Neighbours Property) South:- House of Mr. Ramesh Sahu Ji	Rs. 44,55,000/- (Rs. Forty Four Lakh Fifty Five Thousand Only)	Rs. 4,45,500/- (Rs. Four Lakh Forty Five Thousand Five Hundred Only)	Rs. 40,70,147/- (Rs. Forty Lakh Seventy Thousand One Hundred Forty Seven Only) & Rs. 3,68,447/- (Rs. Three Lakh Sixty Eight Thousand Four Hundred Forty Seven Only)
Loan Code No.: 00800012148, Indore - Vijay Nagar (Branch), Shalini Nahta (Borrower), Pramod Nahta (Co Borrower 1)	Dt: 29-01-2019, Rs. 9,45,060/-, (Rs. Nine Lakh Forty Five Thousand Sixty Only)	All The Piece and Parcel of The Property having an extent :- Shop No. 301, Royal Market House No. 2, Kanungo Bakhal Near Gopal Mandir, Rajwada, Indore, Indore-452002	Rs. 2,70,000/- (Rs. Two Lakh Seventy Thousand Only)	Rs. 27,000/- (Rs. Twenty Seven Thousand Only)	Rs. 25,91,688.4/- (Rs. Twenty Five Lakh Ninety One Thousand Six Hundred Eighty Eight Only and Forty Paise)
Loan Code No.: 08200012149, Indore - Vijay Nagar (Branch), Shalini Nahta (Borrower), Pramod Nahta (Co Borrower 1)	Dt: 29-01-2019, Rs. 10,32,326/-, (Rs. Ten Lakh Thirty Two Thousand Three Hundred Twenty Six Only)	All The Piece And Parcel of The Property Having An Extent:- PH No-34, Arazi Khasar No- 398/3, Ward No- 43 Chirahul Mandir Ward, Near Shiv Temple, Krishna Naga Tehsil- Huzur Dist:- Rewa Rewa Madhya Pradesh 486001 Boundaries As:- North- Road West- H/o- Shri Rakesh Kushwaha East- Plot- R.I. Saheb South- H/o- Shri P.K. Kushwaha	Rs. 7,83,000/- (Rs. Seven Lakh Eighty Three Thousand Only)	Rs. 78,300/- (Rs. Seventy Eight Thousand Three Hundred Only)	Rs. 20,71,657.47/- (Rs. Twenty Lakh Seventy One Thousand Six Hundred Fifty Seven Only and Forty Seven Paise)
Loan Code No.: 00800014761, Indore - Vijay Nagar (Branch), Neelambar Kumar (Borrower), Deepa Pandey (Co Borrower 1)	Dt: 17-08-2024, Rs. 7,96,900/-, (Rs. Seven Lakh Ninety Six Thousand Nine Hundred Only)	All The Piece And Parcel of The Property Having An Extent:- All That Part And Parcel of Property Bearing Plot No. R-84, Area of 46.48 Sq.mtr, Survey No. 784/2 (Totally Admeasuring of 20.234 Hectare) P.H.No. 4/1, Super City Mhow Tech, Gram Mhowgaon, Mhow Neemuch Road, Mhowgaon, Indore Madhya Pradesh- 453441 Boundaries As Follows: East: Road West: Plot No. Q-84 North: Plot No. R-83 South: Plot No. R-85.	Rs. 6,00,000/- (Rs. Six Lakh Only)	Rs. 60,000/- (Rs. Sixty Thousand Only)	Rs. 9,99,979.67/- (Rs. Thirty Two Lakh Twenty Nine Thousand Five Hundred Seventy Nine Only and Sixty Seven Paise)

DATE OF E-AUCTION: 07-08-2026, FROM 11.00 A.M. TO 1.00 P.M. (WITH UNLIMITED EXTENSION OF 5 MINUTES EACH).

LAST DATE OF SUBMISSION OF BID: 06-08-2026, BEFORE 4.00 P.M.

For detailed terms and conditions of the Sale, please refer to the link provided in www.piramalfinance.com/e-auction.html or email us on piramal.auction@piramal.com

STATUTORY 15 DAYS SALE NOTICE UNDER SARFAESI ACT TO THE BORROWER/GUARANTOR / MORTGAGOR

The above-mentioned Borrower/Guarantor are hereby noticed to pay the sum as mentioned in section 13(2) notice in full with accrued interest till date before the date of auction, failing which property will be auctioned/sold and balance dues if any will be recovered with interest and cost from borrower/guarantor.

The Borrowers attention is drawn towards sub-section 8 of section 13, of the act, in respect of the time available, to redeem the secured asset.

Borrowers in particular and public in general may please take note, that in case the auction scheduled herein fails for any reason whatsoever then the secured creditor may enforce its security by the way of private treaty.

Date : July 22, 2026,
Place: MPF

Sd/- (Authorised Officer),
Piramal Finance Limited

ALPHA TRIANGLE

Beginning at the top move towards the bottom seven letter word by adding a letter at each step and rearranging. A correct and different word must be made at each step answering to the clue given.

1 Curved letter

2 Thus

3 Drunkard

4 Playthings

5 Cold and hard, in a way ?

6 Snobbish

7 Powerful business-men

S

S

S

S

S

S

S

Solution to Alpha Triangle

S, So, Sot, Toys, Stony, Snooty, Tycoons.

Go Figure

Place the four numbers in the first, third, fifth, and seventh boxes and whatever operators you care to use in the second, fourth, and sixth boxes in the correct order to get the answer. Use the numbers only once. Operations should be carried out sequentially. BODMAS rule does not apply.

The operators:

÷

×

+

-

Easy

= 7

3

6

6

8

Medium

= 8

2

3

3

5

Hard

= 23

4

6

6

7

Our Solutions:

Hard - 6 × 4 + 6 - 7 = 23

Medium - 3 / 3 + 5 + 2 = 8

Easy - 6 + 6 + 3 - 8 = 7

L M T E S G N I L A C O V

S Y T G K N R E C H O R D

T R R C T O U O K T S P B

Y A E I I S U F U T U A X

L T C R C S X O N P N N G

E I N Q T S U E J D O P E

V U O I O E M M A N E V H

I G C U L U E N E R A B A

T N N D R L C G F E A B R

S D D T O I A O E S A T M

E I S D N T R Y S I O V O

F N Y G S M A N D O L I N

I J A M S E S S I O N U Y

Bluegrass

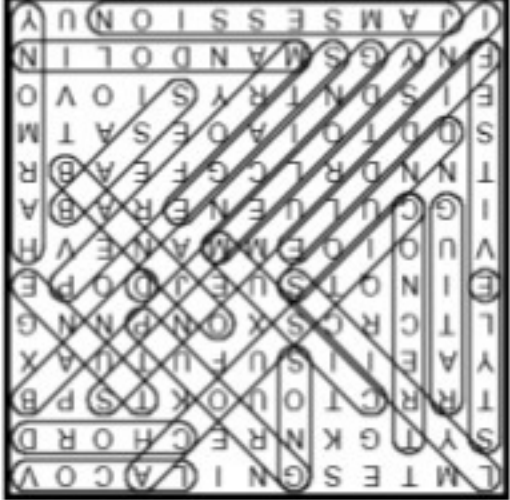
Can you find the words connected in one way or the other with the theme indicated by the title in today's Word Search?

The words may be read horizontally, vertically or diagonally either forwards or backwards, but always in straight lines. Use a ruler to cross them through as you find them.

Acoustic Band Banjo Bass Chord Concert Dancing Festive Fiddle

Group Guitar Harmony Instruments Jam Session Lyrics Mandolin Melody

Music Perform Song Sound Stage Style Tune Vocal



BULL'S EYE

How many words of four or more letters can you make from the letters shown? Each word can use a letter only once and must contain the central letter. There should be at least one 7-letter word. British English Dictionary is used as reference.

N

A

O

T

C

U

C

Ratings:
05 average; 06 good; 07 outstanding.

SOLUTION :
ACCOUNT, cant, coat, coca, count, taco, toucan

Crossword #1932

11 15 22 26 28

12 16 18 19

13 20 21

14 17

23 24 25

27 29 30 31 32

33 34 35 36 37 38 39 40

41 42 43 44 45 46 47

48 49 50

51 52 53

Across

1 Wealthy person (sl.)

4 Cry in despair

8 Mining hole

11 Prefix meaning equal

12 Bay

14 Large, abbr.

15 Fifth sign of the Zodiac

16 Demise

17 Ultimo, in short

18 Was aware of?

20 Palindromic boy

22 Tell ____ : fib? (1,3)

24 Largest of the grasses

26 Rod

27 Beg

28 Breakfast staple

29 Looks closely at

30 ____ de mer (seasickness)

33 Left-hand page

34 Swiss river - change of "area"?

35 Grunts

37 Part of a flower

38 Flightless bird

39 Egyptian symbol of life

41 French for 'Duke'

42 Musical drama

45 Submachine gun

48 Spanish cheer

49 Wilt

50 Increase the number of rotations per minute?

51 Camera type

52 Hankers after

53 One, no matter which

Down

1 ____ admirari : wonder at nothing, in Latin?

2 Sugar suffix

3 Reservation

4 Large or expanded

5 Once more

6 Arun : Bollywood singer?

7 Allow or permit

8 Dwarf planet

9 InnuIt dwelling

10 9th letter of the Hebrew alphabet

13 Dylan ____ : famous poet?

19 Maiden-name

21 To Be Determined

22 Highest in cards

23 Fall behind

24 Invoke God's favour on

25 Flight prefix

27 Impudent

29 Length of time

30 U.P. city

31 Part of verb to be

32 NASA vehicle

33 Promise

34 Inquire of

35 Skeletal head

36 More agreeable

39 Town in MP

40 Siestas

41 Parties

43 Peer

44 Equal opportunity employer abbr

46 Japanese Buddhist philosophy

47 Creeper

SUDOKU

7 6 9

5 2 4

1 5

4 7 9

9 3 1

5 4 2

6 8

8 4

9 7 1

WHAT TO DO: Fill in the grid so that every row, every column and every 3x3 box contains the digits 1 to 9. Every puzzle has only one correct solution.

YOUR DAY By Vinayak Vishwas Karandikar



ARIES: A day to stay calm and channelise energy constructively. Today you may clear loan instalments or insurance premiums, bringing financial relief. People associated with the occult sciences, the surgical field, butchery, and research will benefit. Property-related matters or repair work at home or for vehicles will bring improvement. Focus on rest, mindfulness, and timely care to maintain balance and vitality. Lucky no.: 6; Lucky colour: Pink



TAURUS: Balancing professional responsibilities and personal commitments will bring clarity. Necessary spending on health, properties, travel, or businesses will support long-term stability. People in tourism, security services, the technical field, and police services will benefit. Minor physical discomforts will ease with rest and proper care. Lucky no.: 9; Lucky colour: Red



GEMINI: Success and gains will come through consistent effort and determination. Expenses related to health, friends, or travel will support well-being and relationships. People in the technical field, security services, the police force, law, and the property business will achieve success. Open communication will help restore warmth with relatives and friends. Paying attention to diet and routine will support comfort. Lucky no.: 8; Lucky colour: Black



CANCER: A favourable day, bringing progress in personal and professional matters. Spending on sports, children, or entertainment will add joy and creativity. People in the technical field, the entertainment sector, sports, and the maintenance field will see success. Gentle guidance and patience will help manage children-related matters. Light exercise and relaxation will support physical ease. Lucky no.: 3; Lucky colour: Yellow



LEO: A productive day for travelling, learning, and expanding perspectives. Planned expenses for businesses, education, travel, or property will support growth. People in education, land dealings, and the automobile sector will succeed. Family discussions will lead toward understanding and unity. Balanced routines will promote sound rest and digestion. Lucky no.: 1; Lucky colour: Orange



VIRGO: Positive outcomes will emerge through wise adjustments and patience. Spending on broking, maintenance, or premium services will strengthen security. Brokers, occultists, surgeons, insurance agents, and people in the tourism sector will benefit. Careful communication will help maintain family harmony. Attention to posture, diet, and rest will improve comfort. Lucky no.: 2; Lucky colour: White



LIBRA: Maintaining balance and calm will support smooth progress at work and home. Expenses on spouses, businesses, family, or premium services will be productive and supportive. People working in banquet halls, event management, the technical field, the occult, and the fitness industry will benefit. Gentle exercise and vocal care will support well-being. Lucky no.: 6; Lucky colour: Pink



SCORPIO: A day to stay composed and focused in both the professional and personal spheres. Spending on health, education, or businesses will contribute to long-term progress. People associated with the police force, repair shops, the construction field, and garages will succeed. Family discussions will pave the way for clarity and unity. Regular meals and rest will improve comfort. Lucky no.: 2; Lucky colour: Silver



SAGITTARIUS: A day to act thoughtfully and stay emotionally balanced. Expenses related to premium services, travel, entertainment, or sports will enhance lifestyle and enjoyment. People associated with martial arts, gyms, security services, and the surgical field will see success. Patience and empathy will help resolve family matters smoothly. Proper rest and care will support physical comfort. Lucky no.: 9; Lucky colour: Red



CAPRICORN: A good day for learning, enjoying, and personal development. Expenses on education, houses, or vehicles will support stability. People in education, the construction field, and the repairing field will benefit. Cooperation will help maintain family harmony. Balanced routines will support strength and comfort. Lucky no.: 5; Lucky colour: Green



AQUARIUS: A productive day to study, travel, and have professional focus. Spending on office maintenance, houses, or travel will support efficiency. People associated with sports, barber shops, butcher shops, armed forces, and the property business will succeed. Managing work demands thoughtfully will help maintain domestic balance. Stretching and rest will help ease minor discomforts. Lucky no.: 7; Lucky colour: Grey



PISCES: A pleasant day for learning, enjoying, and travelling. Expenses on children, education, or travel will support growth and experiences. People associated with the police force, butchery, barber shops, and the technical field will benefit. Patience and understanding will nurture family harmony. Attention to oral and throat care will support comfort. Lucky no.: 2; Lucky colour: White

Upanishad Dampatyam

Dr. Ainavolu Srinivas

We have treasure houses of wisdom called Upanishads. Literal meaning of the term Upanishad is "near sitting". Thus, we sit near the wise person and get the wisdom transferred. Whether words can transfer wisdom, how the experience comes to us, whether the experience in one go itself reaches Purnam (complete/abundant) are some of the questions to seek answers for.

Yagyavalka was a sage whom we learn in Brihadaranyaka Upanishad. The sage had two wives. After advancing in the material life, Yagnavalka summons his two wives and says that he shall divide the property in their names and retire into the woods for pursuing the ultimate seeking. One wife named Katyayani agrees to the arrangement. The other wife named Maitreyi asks a simple but straight question to her husband and Guru that whether such wealth is sufficient to become immortal. Sage answers in negative. Then she requests him for the true path and refuses to take her share of wealth. Yagyavalka mentors her. The saying that 'Atmanastu Kamaya Sarvam Priyam Bhavati' is from here.

The material and spiritual paths are two possibilities. One is called Pravritti marga, meaning the worldly engagement and navigating life. Second is called Nirvriti marga, meaning seeking the ultimate by renouncing the world. Which is better, people may have their own views. One thing to remember is, we may be in this world but worldliness need not engulf us. We shall stay untouched by the Samsara.

(Dr. Ainavolu Srinivas is a Mumbai-based teacher of Management and Sanatana)

Fenugreek seed treatment

Fenugreek seeds are known for their ability to reduce hair fall and add shine to your locks. Soak a handful of fenugreek seeds in water overnight. Grind them into a smooth paste the next morning and apply it to your scalp and hair. Leave it on for 30 minutes and then rinse it off. This remedy can help strengthen your hair and control excessive shedding.

Aloe vera magic

Aloe vera is a powerhouse ingredient that can work wonders for your hair during the monsoon. Its hydrating and nourishing properties help combat dryness and frizz. Extract fresh aloe vera gel and apply it to your scalp and hair. Leave it on for 30 minutes before rinsing it off with a mild shampoo. Regular use will help moisturize your hair and promote a healthy scalp.

Curd for dandruff

Dandruff can be a common problem during the monsoon. Curd, with its antifungal properties, can help combat dandruff effectively. Apply fresh curd to your scalp and hair, massaging gently. Leave it on for about 30 minutes and then wash it off with a mild shampoo. Regular use will help reduce dandruff and restore the pH balance of your scalp.

Neeta Senacha

The monsoon season brings relief from the scorching heat but also poses unique challenges for maintaining healthy hair. The increased humidity, incessant rain, and dampness can lead to various hair problems such as frizz, hair fall, dandruff, and lackluster locks. However, fret not, as there are numerous home remedies and care tips that can help you keep your hair in excellent condition even during the rainy season. In this article, we will delve into the world of natural remedies and essential care tips specifically tailored for monsoon hair care. These remedies are easy to follow, cost-effective, and utilize readily available ingredients to restore and nourish your hair from within. From aloe vera and fenugreek seed treatments to coconut milk and curd applications, we will explore the magic of these natural ingredients in combating common monsoon hair woes. Alongside these remedies, we will also highlight essential care tips including proper cleansing, conditioning, and protective measures to ensure your hair remains strong, lustrous, and resilient throughout the monsoon season.

Nourishing coconut milk

Coconut milk is an excellent natural ingredient for nourishing your hair during the monsoon. Extract fresh coconut milk and apply it to your scalp and hair. Gently massage for a few minutes and leave it on for 30 minutes to an hour. Rinse it off with a mild shampoo. The proteins and essential fats in coconut milk will moisturize your hair, making it soft and manageable.

Herbal rinse with tea water

Rinsing your hair with tea water is a simple yet effective remedy to add shine and reduce frizz. Brew some black or green tea and allow it to cool. After shampooing, rinse your hair with the tea water. Leave it on for a few minutes before rinsing it off with plain water. This natural rinse will add luster to your hair and minimize frizz.

Onion juice for hair growth

Onion juice is known for its hair growth-promoting properties. Extract the juice from an onion and apply it to your scalp. Leave it on for 30 minutes to an hour before washing your hair with a mild shampoo. The sulfur compounds in onions stimulate hair growth and help maintain a healthy scalp environment.



Beat the Humidity: Essential monsoon tips for strong, gorgeous hair

Essential care & maintenance tips

Keep hair dry & avoid rainwater

Monsoon rainwater carries pollutants and toxins that weaken hair roots. If your hair gets wet in the rain, wash it promptly with a mild, sulfate-free shampoo and dry it thoroughly. Avoid tying up damp hair to prevent fungal growth and foul odor.

Adopt a minimalist styling routine

Minimize the use of heat-styling tools like straighteners and blow dryers, which strip natural moisture and worsen humidity damage. Air-dry hair using a microfiber towel or soft cotton T-shirt instead of rough terrycloth towels.

Balanced diet and hydration

A balanced diet and hydration are key to healthy hair. Include nutrient-rich foods like leafy greens, fruits, nuts, and lean proteins in your meals. These provide vitamins, minerals, and proteins that support hair health, promoting growth and strength. Stay hydrated by drinking enough water throughout the day to prevent dryness and breakage. Well-hydrated hair and scalp are more resilient and are less prone to dryness and breakage.

Switch to a wide-toothed wooden comb

Hair is weakest when damp. Avoid brushing wet hair immediately. Use a wide-toothed wooden comb to gently detangle from the ends upward, reducing static, frizz, and mechanical breakage.

Opt for lightweight oil treatments

Heavy oiling during humid weather can trap moisture and sweat on the scalp, clogging pores. Instead of heavy scalp oils, use light oils like Argan or Jojoba strictly on the mid-lengths and ends as a pre-shampoo protective layer.

Sitting All Day? An Oncologist explains how a sedentary lifestyle may increase cancer risk

Dr. Amit Chakraborty

Head and Neck Cancer Surgeon, SSO Hospital Mumbai

Long hours of sitting, lack of physical activity, unhealthy eating habits, and weight gain can quietly increase the risk of several cancers. From breast and colon cancer to oral, head and neck, and thyroid cancers, lifestyle plays an important role in cancer prevention. Here are expert-backed tips to stay active and reduce your risk.

Now, many people are spending long hours sitting at a desk, attending virtual meetings, travelling, or using digital devices. So, people tend to remain seated for 8-10 hours a day with very little physical activity. While this may seem harmless, a sedentary lifestyle can affect overall health and increase the risk of several chronic diseases, including certain cancers. Staying physically active helps maintain a healthy weight, improves immunity, reduces inflammation, and supports hormone balance, all of which play an important role in preventing cancer.

How can prolonged sitting increase cancer risk?

When the body stays inactive for long periods, it burns fewer calories, making it easier to gain weight. Excess body fat can increase chronic inflammation, alter hormone levels, and affect insulin metabolism. Over time, these changes may allow abnormal cells to grow and multiply.

Physical inactivity and obesity can lead to a higher risk of cancers such as breast, colon, endometrial (uterine), kidney, or esophageal cancer. A sedentary lifestyle can also contribute to poor overall health, which may indirectly increase the risk of oral, head and neck, and thyroid cancers, especially

when combined with other risk factors such as tobacco use, alcohol consumption, unhealthy eating habits, obesity, and lack of regular exercise. While sitting alone does not directly cause these cancers, maintaining an active lifestyle supports better overall health and may help lower the risk.

Tips to reduce sedentary behaviour:

Stand up and stretch every 30-60 minutes during work, take short walking breaks between meetings, walk while talking on the phone whenever possible, use the stairs instead of elevators, exercise every week, include activities such as brisk walking, cycling, yoga, swimming, or strength training, eat a balanced diet rich in fruits, vegetables, whole grains, maintain a healthy weight and stay well hydrated, void tobacco in all forms and limit alcohol intake, as these are major risk factors for oral and head and neck cancers. Go for regular health check-ups and seek advice if you notice



symptoms such as a mouth ulcer that does not heal, persistent hoarseness, difficulty swallowing, a neck swelling, or an unusual lump in the thyroid region. A desk job does not have to lead to a sedentary lifestyle. Small daily changes, such as standing more often, walking regularly, exercising, and following healthy habits, can improve overall health and reduce the risk of several cancers, including breast, colon, oral, head and neck, and thyroid cancers. Staying active is one of the simplest and most effective ways to protect your well-being.

Dr. Gagandeep Singh

MBBS, Founder – Redial Clinic / Specialist in Reversing Diabetes, Hypertension, Obesity & PCOS without Medication

A 26-year-old came to see me last year, lean, active on Instagram with gym photos, running a half marathon the previous winter. His fatty liver diagnosis came as a complete shock, to him and honestly to the physician who first flagged it, because he ticked none of the boxes people associate with liver disease. He didn't drink. He wasn't overweight. He exercised, or thought he did, four times a week.

This scenario has become common enough in my practice that I no longer find it surprising, even though patients almost always do. Non-alcoholic fatty liver disease among young, lean Indians is not a contradiction; it's a pattern with a clear metabolic explanation, and one that's increasingly well documented in the Indian population specifically.

Why young Indians are developing fatty liver without drinking alcohol

Indians, more than many other ethnic groups, tend toward a body composition sometimes described as "thin-fat," carrying a higher percentage of visceral and ectopic fat relative to their overall body weight and BMI. This means someone can look lean by conventional standards while still storing meaningful fat around and within organs, including the liver. A normal BMI offers false reassurance here in a way it doesn't in other populations.

Diet plays an outsized role in why this shows up so early now. The shift toward refined carbohydrates, sugary beverages, and ultra-processed snacks among young, urban Indians has accelerated faster than most people's awareness of the metabolic consequences. A diet heavy in white rice, maida, and sugar, even without excess total calories, drives the liver to convert that glucose into fat through a process called de novo lipogenesis. Add long sedentary hours at a desk, disrupted sleep from late nights and screen exposure, and chronic stress, and you have a near-perfect storm for insulin resistance to take hold quietly.

The exercise many young patients do also deserves a second look. Cardio alone, without resistance training, doesn't build the muscle mass needed to meaningfully



improve insulin sensitivity. I've seen patients running regularly who still carry significant liver fat, because running burns calories in the moment without necessarily correcting the underlying insulin resistance that's accumulating fat in the liver between workouts.

What I tell these patients is that the fix isn't punishment through more cardio or extreme calorie restriction. It's rebuilding the metabolic foundation: reducing refined carbohydrate intake, prioritising protein through eggs, chicken, fish, or paneer, and adding structured resistance training a few times a week. Good sleep and lower stress matter here too, more than most young patients expect, since both influence the same insulin pathways that determine whether the liver stores fat or clears it. These changes address the insulin resistance directly rather than chasing calories burned.

If you're young, active, and were told your liver ultrasound showed some fat despite not drinking, don't dismiss it as a lab error or something that only happens to older, heavier patients. It's an early warning, arriving at an age when reversal is still relatively straightforward. That's worth taking seriously, not despite your age, but because of it.

The Persistent Threat of Salmonella Typhi: Anatomy and clinical management of typhoid fever

Namrata Sharma

Typhoid fever remains a major global public health challenge, causing an estimated 11 to 20 million cases and over 100,000 deaths annually. Caused by the bacterium Salmonella enterica serovar Typhi, this systemic infection thrives in areas with inadequate sanitation and limited access to clean drinking water. Understanding its biological path of destruction, progressive clinical features, and evolving treatment paradigms is critical for healthcare providers, public health officials, and medical researchers alike.

1 Pathophysiology and transmission mechanisms

The journey of Salmonella Typhi from environmental contamination to severe systemic disease follows a precise cellular and vascular path:

Primary mode of transmission: Ingestion of water or food contaminated by the feces or urine of infected patients or asymptomatic chronic carriers.

Gastrointestinal invasion: Ingested bacteria survive the acidic environment of the stomach and reach the small intestine.

The pathogens cross the intestinal epithelial barrier by invading Microfold (M) cells located within Peyer's patches.

Reticuloendothelial dissemination:

Once inside the submucosa, the bacteria are engulfed by tissue macrophages. Instead of being destroyed, S. Typhi survives and replicates inside the macrophage vacuoles.

Infected immune cells travel through the lymphatic system to the mesenteric lymph nodes and into the thoracic duct.

2 Clinical progression: the four-week course

Without prompt antibiotic intervention, typhoid fever develops over four distinct, weekly clinical stages:

Primary and secondary bacteraemia:

The initial entry into the bloodstream creates a transient primary bacteraemia, spreading the infection to the liver, spleen, bone marrow, and gallbladder.

Following a 7- to 14-day incubation period, continuous bacterial replication triggers a heavy secondary bacteraemia, marking the onset of clinical symptoms.

Week 1: Onset and systemic toxicity

Step-ladder fever: Body temperature climbs incrementally each day, eventually plateauing at 39°C–40°C (103°F–104°F).

Relative bradycardia: A characteristic pulse-temperature dissociation where the heart rate remains unexpectedly low relative to the high fever.

Early symptoms: Persistent frontal headache, general malaise, dry cough, abdominal pain, and muscle aches.

Week 2: Sustained fever and cutaneous manifestations

Continuous High Fever: The fever remains elevated with minimal diurnal fluctuation.

Rose spots: Transient, blanching, rose-coloured maculopapular lesions appear on the trunk and abdomen in 10% to 30% of infected individuals.

Gastrointestinal symptoms: Classic "pea-soup" diarrhoea occurs, though severe constipation is frequently seen in adult patients.

Abdominal features: Significant abdominal distension accompanied by measurable enlargement of the liver and spleen (hepatosplenomegaly).

Week 3: Peak complications and high mortality

The "Typhoid state": Persistent endotoxemia causes central nervous system dysfunction, leading to apathy, confusion, or low-muttering delirium.

Intestinal haemorrhage: Necrosis of the hyperplastic Peyer's patches causes severe lower gastrointestinal bleeding.

Intestinal perforation: Erosion through the wall of the terminal ileum releases bowel contents into the peritoneal cavity, causing acute peritonitis and requiring emergency surgery.

Multiorgan failure: Elevated risks of septic shock, severe dehydration, and toxic myocarditis.

Week 4: Convalescence or the carrier state

Defervescence: In surviving patients, body temperature gradually declines over several days, and clinical parameters normalize.

Relapse risk: Approximately 10% of untreated patients experience a relapse within two to three weeks of apparent recovery.

Chronic carriage: Between 2% and 5% of patients become chronic, asymptomatic carriers—harboring the bacteria long-term in the gallbladder and continuously shedding it in their stool.

3 Diagnostic strategies and laboratory testing

Accurate, timely diagnosis requires selecting the appropriate laboratory test based on the duration of the illness:

Blood culture:

Timing: Highest yield during Weeks 1 and 2.

Diagnostic Role: Considered the gold standard for early confirmation; essential for establishing antimicrobial sensitivity profiles.

Bone marrow culture:

Timing: Highly sensitive across all stages of infection.

Diagnostic Role: Retains a ~90% sensitivity rate even after the initiation of antibiotic therapy, though its invasive nature limits routine use.

Stool and urine cultures:

Timing: Most effective during Weeks 3 and 4.

Diagnostic Role: Primarily used to confirm resolution, detect convalescent shedding, or identify chronic carriers.

Serological testing:

The traditional Widal test measures agglutinating antibodies against O and H antigens, but high rates of false positives limit its clinical reliability. Modern rapid tests (e.g., Typhidot) offer alternative serological options in resource-limited settings where culture facilities are unavailable.



4 Treatment paradigms and antimicrobial resistance

Treating typhoid fever has become increasingly complex due to the rapid spread of Multidrug-Resistant (MDR) and Extensively Drug-Resistant (XDR) strains of S. Typhi.

Pharmacological regimens

First-line therapy for uncomplicated typhoid: Oral Azithromycin (10–20 mg/kg/day for 7 days) is widely used due to extensive fluoroquinolone resistance in endemic regions.

Severe or hospitalized infections: Intravenous Ceftriaxone (2 g/day for 10–14 days) or intravenous Ciprofloxacin (only when local susceptibility is fully documented).

XDR strain management: Intravenous Meropenem or other carbapenems are indicated when resistance to third-generation cephalosporins is confirmed.

5 Prevention, public health, and eradication

Controlling typhoid fever requires combining effective vaccination campaigns with public health engineering:

Vaccination protocols: **Typhoid Conjugate Vaccine (TCV):** Provides long-lasting immunity for individuals from 6 months of age.

Vi polysaccharide vaccine: Injectable option for ages 2+; requires boosters every 2–3 years.

Ty21a vaccine: Oral live-attenuated series for ages 6 and older.

Sanitation (WASH): Clean water, safe sewage disposal, and strict hygiene offer the most effective transmission control.

Carrier eradication: Requires 4–6 weeks of targeted antibiotics or a cholecystectomy for persistent gallbladder cases.

Celeb voices for students

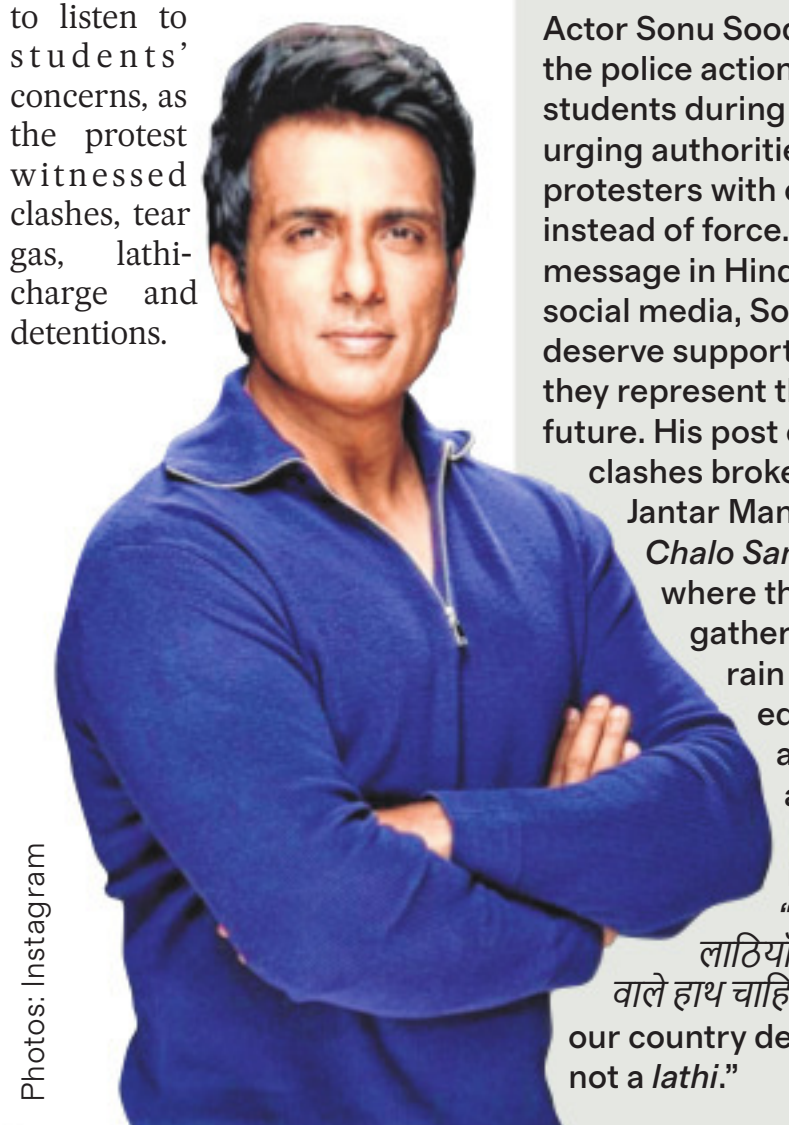
Actors and musicians express solidarity with students after police action during Delhi protest



Supporters gather during the protest in New Delhi, on Tuesday. (PTI)

The police action during the Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) *Chalo Sansad* protest in Delhi has triggered widespread reactions from the film fraternity. As thousands of students marched towards Parliament demanding education reforms, accountability over alleged examination irregularities and the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, several celebrities took to social media to express solidarity with the protesters. While some appealed for compassion and dialogue, others urged authorities to listen to students' concerns, as the protest witnessed clashes, tear gas, lathi-charge and detentions.

Photos: Instagram



Listen to the students' voices: Diljit Dosanjh

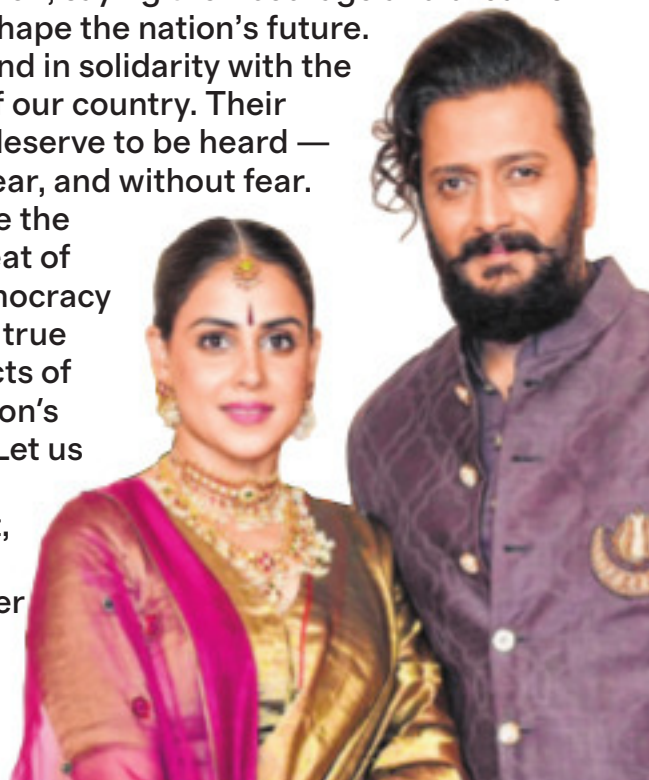
Singer-actor Diljit Dosanjh criticised the police action against students, saying they should not have been treated in such a manner. Appealing to the authorities to hear the protesters' demands, Diljit said the "voice of the people is the voice of God." Reflecting on his own experiences after supporting the farmers' protest, he revealed that he had previously faced backlash and legal issues and expected to be labelled "anti-national" once again for speaking out. "Aj Jo hoyea Baut Maada Hoyea... Students Naal Edan Treat Nih Hona Chaida c... Mai Authorities Nu Request Karda Ke Students Dian Demands Nu Sunn Leya Javey... Lokan Di Avaaz Rab Di Avaaz Hundi Aa." "Mere Te Already Anti Nationalist Da Tag Baut Vaar Lagg Chuka... After Kisan Protest, I faced a lot of backlash & legal problems which I can't even discuss."

Students need hugs, not batons: Sonu Sood

Actor Sonu Sood condemned the police action against students during the CJP protest, urging authorities to treat young protesters with compassion instead of force. Sharing a message in Hindi and English on social media, Sonu said students deserve support and empathy as they represent the country's future. His post came after clashes broke out at Delhi's Jantar Mantar during the *Chalo Sansad* march, where thousands gathered despite heavy rain to demand education reforms and action over alleged examination irregularities. "हमारे छात्रों को लाठियाँ नहीं, गले लगाने वाले हाथ चाहिए! The future of our country deserves a hug, not a lathi."

Stand in solidarity with youth: Riteish Deshmukh & Genelia

Actors Riteish Deshmukh and Genelia D'Souza issued a joint statement extending support to the protesting students, saying they stand with the youth of the country. The couple stressed that students' voices should be heard without fear and described them as the heartbeat of India's democracy. They also urged people to listen to, support and empower the younger generation, saying their courage and dreams would shape the nation's future. "We stand in solidarity with the youth of our country. Their voices deserve to be heard — loud, clear, and without fear. They are the heartbeat of our democracy and the true architects of our nation's future. Let us listen, support, and empower them."



Parliament is meant for debate: Kangana Ranaut

Actress and BJP MP Kangana Ranaut defended the government's position, saying Parliament is the appropriate platform to discuss such issues. She argued that disrupting public order or attempting to pressure the government into removing ministers was not the right approach, adding that elected governments have the authority to take such decisions. "Our parliamentary session is meant for discussion and accountability... You cannot arm-twist the government into deciding who to sack and who to keep."



Shabana Azmi recites father's poem at protest

Veteran actor Shabana Azmi visited the protest site at Jantar Mantar and joined students during the demonstration. She also expressed support for activist Sonam Wangchuk's hunger strike by sharing lines from her father Kaifi Azmi's celebrated poem, highlighting resilience and hope in the face of adversity. "Main koi mulk nahin hoon ke jala doge mujhe... Main to ik khwab hoon deewano ka..."

Photo: X



Big B reveals he was hospitalised in cryptic post

Megastar Amitabh Bachchan recently shared a note about hospitalisation, surgery and the difficult road to recovery. On Saturday, he had visited Nana-vati Hospital, as per sources. In his blog, the 83-year-old actor spoke about how returning home after being discharged from the hospital can often be more challenging than the treatment itself. He wrote, "... in Hospital in a surgery and in the ICU, under the care of proficient doctors and medical staff ... a discharge ... and a homecoming ... this homecoming period is the most difficult phase ... physically, psychologically and practically you are a revered champion and one day a defeat stares at you ... this is the most difficult phase of your life."

He further reflected on how people respond differently to such difficult phases, adding, "... some brave it ... some succumb ... they that strive and be brave ever remain champions ... they that do not, get reconciled and live, exist in the past glory ... a choice each makes individually ... nothing wrong by either ... be well be happy (sic)." Shortly after publishing the blog, Amitabh also posted a cryptic message on X (formerly known as Twitter), writing, "T 5806 - The game has ended! But the work is still going on." Although the actor did not provide any context for either post, the messages sparked curiosity among fans, with many wondering if they were linked to his personal health or were simply philosophical reflections on life. Amitabh Bachchan has, over the years, spoken candidly about his health struggles. During an episode of *Kaun Banega Crorepati*, he revealed that only around 25 per cent of his liver is functional following the life-threatening accident he suffered while filming *Coolie* in 1982. The incident left him with severe internal injuries, requiring emergency surgery and a prolonged stay in hospital.

James Gray to receive lifetime career award

Filmmaker James Gray, known for projects such as *The Yards*, *The Lost City of Z* and *The Immigrant*, will be honoured with a lifetime career award at the Locarno Film Festival. The award will be presented to Gray on August 9. The festival will also screen his latest film *Paper Tiger*, which revolves around brothers, an ex-cop (Adam Driver)



Photo: X

and a hardworking engineer (Miles Teller), who pursue the American Dream by partnering with a waterfront cleanup venture tied to the Russian mafia. James Gray previous directorials, *We Own the Night* and *Two Lovers*, will also screen at the festival. Locarno artistic director Giona A. Naz-zaro said Gray is the "last great novelist of American cinema."

Tears & laughter

Actor Siddharth wears his heart on his sleeve at *Operation Safed Sagar* trailer launch



Ria Sharma



Photos: Ashwini Sawant

Trailer launches often follow a predictable format, but the unveiling of Netflix's *Operation Safed Sagar* in Mumbai on Monday stood out because of Siddharth's presence. The actor emerged as the emotional core of the event, showing both his vulnerable and playful sides. Based on an untold chapter of the Kargil War, the series follows Squadron Leader Ajay Ojha and the Golden Arrows on a high-risk mission. The trailer was launched in the presence of the cast, filmmakers, war veterans and their families, making the occasion even more meaningful. *The Free Press Journal* was present at the event.

Siddharth became emotional several times while speaking about the Indian Air Force and essaying Squadron Leader Ajay Ojha. He was visibly teary-eyed on multiple occasions and even covered his face to avoid the cameras after struggling to hold back his tears. His raw emotions made the moment feel genuine rather than staged. The mood soon turned lighter when younger actors Abhay Verma, Taaruk Raina, Mihir Ahuja and Arnab Bhasin said they had grown up watching Jimmy Shergill and Siddharth. Responding with his trademark wit, Siddharth joked that he had grown up watching Adil Hussain, leaving the cast and media in splits. His arrival also caught attention. While Jimmy Shergill, Abhay, Taaruk, Mihir and Arnab made a stylish entry on motorcycles, Siddharth walked onto the stage wearing an arm sling. When asked about the injury, he revealed only that he had undergone a "small operation," without sharing further details.

'I felt safer teaching in a prison than in Delhi'

Kabir Singh Bhandari

To put it very simply, Tillotama Shome is one of the best actors we currently have. Making her debut with Mira Nair's *Monsoon Wedding* (2001), she played stand-out roles in movies and web series such as *Qissa*, *Sir*, *A Death in the Gunj*, *Delhi Crime Season 2*, *Lust Stories 2* and *Paatal Lok Season 2*. Tillotama has also been practicing Nichiren Daishonin's Buddhism, a spiritual practice which she credits as the backbone of her life.

Her most recent project was the courtroom drama *Ikka* on Netflix, directed by Siddharth P. Malhotra. Over a 30-minute-long Zoom video interview with *The Free Press Journal*, she spoke about her experience working on the film, the misconception we have about those in prison, and more. Excerpts:

A director who respects everyone

"Siddharth really respects people irrespective of what their stardom or perceived stardom is. Sid, far from being foul-tempered, is one of the nicest people you can work with."

Behind the scenes with the cast

"Akshaye, I didn't get to know well, as he would walk onto the set in character, and that's his process, and I respect it. Dia, again, we didn't have any scenes together, but I heard she was quite the 'mama' on set, concerned about everybody's well-being."

Sunny was the one with whom I had the bulk of my scenes. He is an introvert, but he's warm. His silences were not something that made one uncomfortable. You could sit with him in silence in the same room and feel very comfortable. We were shooting during an extremely trying time for him, when his father's health was serious. Sunny was extremely emotional and was unabashedly crying. It was so nice to see a man in this very toxic age of



Sunny Deol and Tillotama Shome in the recently released courtroom drama *Ikka*

masculinity who could have this kind of gentleness, especially someone who has played these high-octane action heroes on celluloid."

On teaching drama to prison inmates

"So, people in Rikers Island (New York City) prison serve time for different kinds of crimes. It was not a prison just for murder convicts. It's a high-security prison, and you have to go through four rounds of metal detector checks. It takes 20 minutes just to enter that classroom. I think I might have felt safer inside Rikers than I did in 17 years in Delhi. Using public transport, going to college from Vasant Kunj to North Campus, and travelling back in the evening after sun-down was what was really scary."



Scan QR code to watch the full interview on FPJ's YouTube channel
(Visit the FPJ website to read the full article)

Tillotama Shome talks about *Ikka*, working with Siddharth P. Malhotra, her co-stars, prison workshops, and her spiritual journey



Photos: Instagram/IMDb

Actress reveals she stopped taking stroke medication and later quit marijuana to embrace a drug-free lifestyle

Sharon Stone opens up about drug-free life

Actor Sharon Stone has opened up about major personal changes in her life, revealing that she stopped taking one of her stroke medications despite doctors advising her not to, and later decided to quit smoking marijuana as part of her effort to live a drug-free life.

Stone, who suffered a near-fatal stroke in 2001, spoke about her health journey while discussing her recent creative comeback, including her return to painting, modeling and plans for a possible Broadway debut. "I got off one of my medications that I was on for my stroke last September, and they said I couldn't go off of it," Stone said, adding, "They said, 'You can't go off of it. You can never go off of it. I'm like, 'I'm going off it', and it was like going off of fucking heroin. I was sick as a frigging dog for four and a half months," she said as quoted by Variety. Stone said her decision came from a desire to regain control of her life after years of taking medications following her stroke.

"I just thought, 'I want my life back.' I had gotten off the majority of the drugs over the years that they had put me on. But I was like, 'I want a drug-free life,'" she said. After stopping that medication, Stone said she also decided to quit smoking marijuana. She explained that the experience was difficult and that she became ill after giving up cannabis.

"Once I got off that, I decided I'm going to quit smoking pot," Stone said, adding, "And because I think they put so much stuff in it now- they really do- when I stopped smoking pot, I also got sick." Stone added that her neurologist warned her about serious health concerns linked to marijuana use. "I went to my neurologist, and he said, 'Sharon, I've had people dying in the emergency room from marijuana,'" she said.

The actor shared these details while sitting at her Beverly Hills estate, where she was also showcasing another major part of her life: her artwork. Stone, who studied fine arts in college before leaving to pursue modeling, said her interest in painting grew significantly during the COVID-19 lockdown. What began as a small creative project became an intense artistic pursuit. Stone transformed her bedroom into a studio before eventually moving her work into a guest house.

It set the course of my life: Minissha

Bollywood actress Minissha Lamba took a nostalgic trip down memory lane as she celebrated 21 years of her debut film *Yahaan*. Sharing a heartfelt note on social media, she expressed gratitude to filmmaker Shoojit Sircar for giving her the opportunity that launched her acting career. Reflecting on the milestone, Minissha wrote, "*Yahaan* 2005. A film by Shoojit Sircar 21 years later. Thank you for choosing me to play Adaa and setting in motion the course of my life. Every scene is a profusion of memories of all the wonderful things that our first film was. And how handsome is @jimmysheirgill looking @shoojitsircar #film #movies #magic #bollywood."

She also posted a throwback video from the movie directed by Shoojit Sircar. The film featured Jimmy Sheirgill, Minissha Lamba, who made her acting debut with the project, and Yashpal Sharma in pivotal roles. Released in theatres on July 29, 2005, *Yahaan* also made its presence felt at the 7th Ocean's Cinefan Film Festival, where it received the Special Jury Prize.

Minissha Lamba has been part of several notable films, including *Corporate* (2006), *Honeymoon Travels Pvt. Ltd.* (2007), *Bachna Ae Haseeno* (2008), and *Bheja Fry 2* (2011).

Minissha gained further recognition for her performance in Sanjay Gadhvi's *Kidnap*. She later appeared in Shyam Benegal's critically acclaimed film *Well Done Abba*. After taking a brief break from acting, the actress participated in the Salman Khan-hosted reality show *Bigg Boss 8*, which was eventually won by Gautam Gulati.

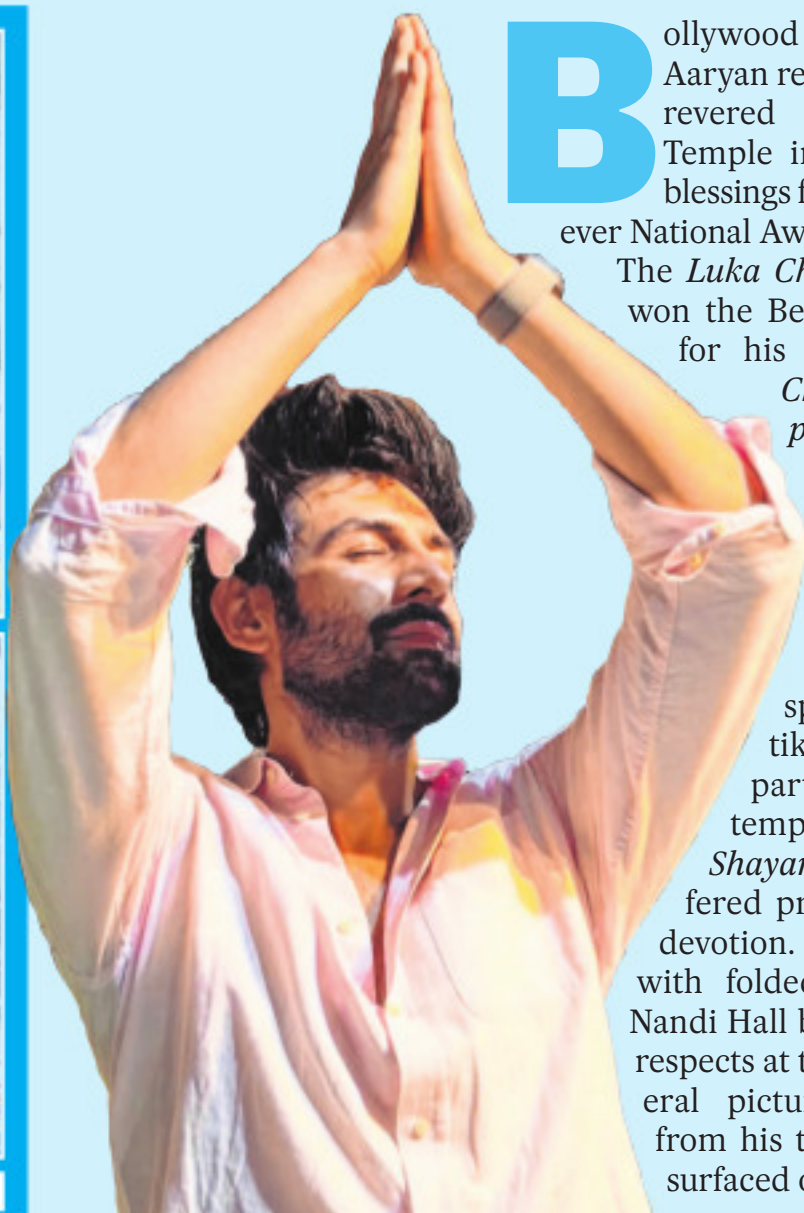


Photo: Instagram_@minissha_lamba

Kartik Aaryan seeks divine blessings



Photos: Instagram_@kartikaaryan/X



Bollywood actor Kartik Aaryan recently visited the revered Mahakaleshwar Temple in Ujjain to seek blessings following his first-ever National Award victory.

The *Luka Chuppi* actor, who won the Best Actor honour for his performance in *Chandu Champion*, was seen expressing gratitude at *Baba Mahakal's* temple along with his parents. During the spiritual visit, Kartik and his family participated in the temple's sacred *Shayan Aarti* and offered prayers with deep devotion. Kartik was seen with folded hands in the Nandi Hall before paying his respects at the sanctum. Several pictures and videos from his temple visit have surfaced online.

Photo: X

Get ready for star-packed Marvel adventure

The much-awaited trailer of *Avengers: Doomsday* was released on Monday, sending Marvel Cinematic Universe (MCU) fans into a frenzy across social media.

Soon after its release, fans flooded X (formerly Twitter) with excited reactions, praising the action-packed visuals and eagerly counting down to the film's theatrical release on December 18, 2026. The trailer features several standout moments,

with a scene involving Chris Hemsworth's Thor and Chris Evans' Steve Rogers emerging as one of the biggest highlights. While offering glimpses of the epic battle ahead, the trailer leaves fans eager to discover what unfolds in the highly anticipated superhero saga.

Directed as the next major MCU event, *Avengers: Doomsday* is slated to hit theatres on December 18, 2026, where it will face a major box office clash with *Dune: Part Three*.



Chris Hemsworth in the *Avengers: Doomsday* trailer

Nandamuri Balakrishna injured on the sets of NBK 111

Nandamuri Balakrishna suffered a leg injury while filming an action sequence for his upcoming movie, tentatively titled *NBK III*, in Kakinada. The actor was shooting a fight scene in and around the Kakinada Port area when he sustained the injury. He was immediately taken to a hospital, where doctors diagnosed him with a ligament tear in his leg.

Doctors have advised Balakrishna to undergo a minor surgery. If he proceeds with the procedure, the actor is expected to take a few weeks of rest before resuming work on the film. Soon after the reports surfaced, actor Jr NTR posted on X, "Get well soon Bala Babai. Wishing you a speedy recovery and good health. Looking forward to seeing you roar back in full form."

A lot of things have changed since Vardaan came: Vikrant



Photo: Instagram_@vikrantmassey

Vikrant Massey with wife Sheetal Thakur and son Vardaan

Actor Vikrant Massey seems to have been ruling the roost in the domain of acting with his unique choice of content, especially over the last few years.

The actor, a few months ago, had been honoured with the prestigious National Award for his stellar performance in his hit movie, *12th Fail*.

The actor reflected on how fatherhood has transformed his life. Crediting his son for bringing good fortune into his life, Vikrant said he firmly believes that every child arrives with their own destiny and blessings.

Speaking to IANS after receiving the National Film Award for Best Actor for his performance in *12th Fail*, he said, "I completely believe in it. I completely believe in it. Because in our family, it is said that every child brings his fate. And I also believe in that. A lot of things have changed since he came. And I couldn't have asked for anything more. I am really, really grateful."

For the uninitiated, Vikrant and his wife, actress Sheetal Thakur, welcomed their first child, a baby boy named Vardaan, in February 2024. The National Award marked a major milestone in Vikrant's career. He won the Best Actor honour for portraying IPS officer Manoj Kumar Sharma in filmmaker Vidhu Vinod Chopra's critically acclaimed biographical drama *12th Fail*. Based on Anurag Pathak's bestselling book of the same name, the film chronicles the inspiring journey of Sharma, who overcame poverty and repeated academic setbacks to clear one of India's toughest competitive examinations.

Running into so many people I respect: Shakira



Queen of Latin music Shakira, who performed at the FIFA World Cup finale, ran into names such as Beyonce, BTS, Tom Cruise and many more.

Shakira shared a photo-dump featuring pictures of her posing with names such as Beyonce, BTS, Tom Cruise, Anya Taylor-Joy, Kevin Hart, David Beckham and Jay-Z.

"What a day yesterday! Running into so many people I appreciate and respect, and receiving so much love from all of you!! Also, ¡que viva Colombia en este día y siempre!" she wrote as the caption.



Photos: Instagram_@shakira

The first-time protestors said Instagram, X and WhatsApp became their guide after videos from Monday's clashes began circulating online

Goggles, masks, helmets: Protestors in protective gear



Students lathi-charged in Hyderabad

Students trying to march towards Lok Bhavan in Hyderabad on Tuesday to demand the resignation of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the NEET paper leak were stopped and lathi-charged by police, triggering tension.

Until two days ago, many of the teenagers and young adults who gathered at Jantar Mantar had never attended a march. As hundreds joined on Tuesday, they came carrying swimming goggles, N95 masks and helmets after watching videos of the previous day's tear gas clashes circulate on social media. As hundreds gathered at the protest site on Tuesday, a day after the BJP's "Chalo Sansad" march, the protective gear stood out almost as much as the placards. Some protesters returned wearing the same goggles and masks they had used during Monday's clashes, while many others bought them overnight. Tear gas shells were lobbed and lathis rained down on protesters during Monday's march.



Others have seen what is and asked why. I have seen what could be and asked why not." — Pablo Picasso

DID U KNOW?

Harishma stood carrying swimming goggles, wearing an N95 mask and dressed in a full-sleeved shirt



Any fool can know. The point is to understand - Albert Einstein

Kerala to train women as rubber tappers

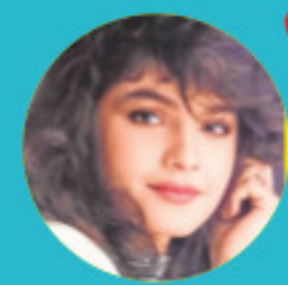
In a move aimed at tackling Kerala's chronic shortage of skilled rubber tappers while creating sustainable livelihood opportunities for rural women, the state government has decided to train members of the Kudumbashree mission as rubber tappers and plantation managers, with plans to expand the initiative across major rubber-growing districts.



Rahul, Priyanka, Akhilesh detained



The dramatic protest outside Prime Minister Narendra Modi's residence at 7 LKM on Tuesday ended up in the detention of Leader of Opposition (LoP) Rahul Gandhi and the arrest of many Congress MPs, including Priyanka Gandhi and others, including SP chief Akhilesh Yadav, by the Delhi Police.



Crushing dissent preserves the authority of those in power
— Pooja Bhatt

Road accidents leading cause of death among youth

DID U KNOW?

The study projected the global economic cost of road injuries to reach USD 1.8 trillion

In 2023, road accidents caused 50.9 million injuries and 1.34 million deaths around the world and motor vehicle crashes were the leading cause of road injury cases and deaths, a new study has estimated. Findings published in The Lancet Public Health journal show that road

injuries were the leading cause of death among young people ages 10-39 globally and the second-leading cause among children ages 5-9. Overall, road injuries ranked as the 11th cause of death around the world. Mortality rates are nearly six times higher in low-income countries.



Main Vaapas Aaunga recovers costs



As "Main Vaapas Aaunga" entered its sixth week in cinemas, producer Mohit Choudhary on Tuesday said the Imtiaz Ali-directed film has become a commercial hit by recovering its costs through theatrical and non-theatrical revenues. "Main Vaapas Aaunga", a Partition-era romantic drama that unfolds across two timelines and generations, released in cinemas across the country on June 12 and had a slow start in its opening week.

MPs were scared: Kangana Ranaut



Actress and politician Kangana Ranaut has said that things went out of proportion when the protestors marched to the Parliament in light of the recent political turmoil in the national capital. On Tuesday, the actress spoke with the media outside the Parliament, and said that the MPs were scared given the rage of the protestors. She told the media, "You were also inside. You saw how scared everyone was. The gates were also closed. All the parliamentarians were also locked inside."

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Celebs back students



From Diljit Dosanjh, Anurag Kashyap to Sonakshi Sinha and Huma Qureshi, many prominent names from the world of showbiz criticised police action against students who marched towards the Parliament to demand the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan. On Monday, thousands of students, demanding the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the NEET paper leak issue and irregularities in the exam system, attempted to march to the complex but were pushed back with

Many prominent names from showbiz criticised police action against students who marched towards the Parliament to demand the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan



teargas and batons. While celebrities like Shabana Azmi and Prakash Raj participated in the student march, many voiced their support and concern on social media. Actor-singer Diljit Dosanjh, who is in

the US, said what students faced on Monday was "very wrong". Actor-comedian Vir Das said it was important to speak out for the youth. Riteish Deshmukh and his wife Genelia.



Phoolan to premiere in Toronto

Filmmaker Richie Mehta's "Phoolan", a film based on the dreaded Chambal dacoit-turned-politician Phoolan Devi, will have its world premiere at the 51st Toronto International Film Festival (TIFF). The Hindi-language movie will be screened at the festival on September 16 at the Princess of Wales Theatre as part of the Special Presentations section.



The way I play football is also my approach to life
- Konrad Laimer

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INDORE | WEDNESDAY | JULY 22, 2026

Post FIFA WC heartbreak



FIFA WC 2026 runners-up Argentina received a grand welcome at the airport

Hero's welcome for Argentinean team



IFA World Cup 2026 runners-up Argentina received a grand welcome at the airport with red carpet and a military band when they returned home following a heartbreaking 1-0 defeat against Spain in the final held at MetLife Stadium in New York. Despite the team failing to

defend the title, the fans show their support to the national, thousands gathered outside the Argentine Football Association (AFA) office near at Ministro Pistarini International Airport in Ezeiza. After landing, the aircraft was moved to the private flight area FBO to facilitate the arrival of the delegation. Coach Lionel Scaloni and the rest of the team were welcomed on the tarmac with a red carpet by the Grenadier

Regiment to the rhythm of "Muchachos" and then by a multitude of fans in the surroundings of the grounds. Fans were holding white and blue umbrellas and wearing the number 10 jersey of their team captain, Lionel Messi; however, the 39-year-old was not present with the squad.

DID U KNOW?

The AFA had earlier announced that several team members would not be travelling, including Messi.

7 Indians progress to next round

India have kickstarted their campaign at the World Squash Junior Championships strongly with women's top seed Anahat Singh, advancing into the next round after a straight-game 11-2, 11-1, 11-3 against Australia's Lilly Wilson. Meanwhile seven Indian squash players successfully advanced to the next round of the World Squash Junior Championships in Niagara-on-the-Lake, Canada.



India series won't be one-sided



Zimbabwe skipper Sikandar Raza has dismissed the thought of the 2026 T20 World Cup champions India being favourites in the upcoming three-match T20I series, saying the contest will not be one-sided and both

teams will have an equal chance of emerging victorious. Zimbabwe are hosting the Shreyas Iyer-led side, with all three matches of the series to be held at the Harare Sports Club.

Harmanpreet to lead India



Hockey India on Monday announced the 20-member

men's squad for the upcoming FIH World Cup Belgium & Netherlands to be held from August 15 to 30, with ace defender and drag-flicker Harmanpreet Singh leading the side. Veteran midfielder Manpreet Singh, India's most-capped player, brings vast experience to a balanced squad comprising a blend of seasoned campaigners and exciting young talent.

QUICK NEWS

Jhon Duran joins Benfica

Former Aston Villa striker Jhon Duran has joined Benfica from Al-Nassr on loan from the Saudi club through the end of the 2026/27 season. This will be the seventh club of Duran's career at the age of just 22.

Bayern extends Laimer's contract

Bayern Munich extended Konrad Laimer's contract through June 2029, the Bundesliga club said. The 29-year-old joined Bayern in 2023 and has won two Bundesliga titles, the German Cup and the German Super Cup.

Fencing squad reaches HK

A 24-member Indian fencing contingent has officially departed for Hong Kong to represent the country in the Senior World Fencing Championships 2026, which will take place from July 22 to July 30, 2026.



I was rewarded for
being brave enough to
dream
- Sanju Samson

INDORE | WEDNESDAY | JULY 22, 2026

Spain's postal service honours champs with commemorative stamp

Correos, the state-owned postal service and courier for Spain, paid tribute to the men's national team for its triumph in the FIFA World Cup 2026 by releasing a special commemorative stamp dedicated to the world champions. The stamp features the national team badge on a red background, matching the colour of its home jersey, with two stars representing the country's two World Cup titles, won in 2010 and 2026.



Ipswich sign Kayne van Oevelen



Ipswich Town have completed the signing of Dutch goalkeeper Kayne van Oevelen from FC Volendam, with the 22-year-old putting pen to paper on a five-year contract ahead of the new PL season. Oevelen will join Ipswich's first-team squad at their ongoing training camp in La Manga as he begins the next chapter of his career.



ICC Men's T20 WC

Wicketkeeper-batter Sanju Samson has revealed that he initially struggled to believe Rohit Sharma's reassurance that he would still have a role to play

Samson recalls Rohit's support



India wicketkeeper-batter Sanju Samson has revealed that he initially struggled to believe Rohit Sharma's reassurance that he would still have a role to play in ICC Men's T20 WC after



DID U KNOW?

Samson explained that disappointment of missing out lingered into early stages of the World Cup.

missing out on playing XI during latter stage of the campaign before rediscovering his confidence and producing

one of the defining innings of India's campaign against the West Indies. Looking back on the difficult period following the New Zealand T20I series, Samson admitted he was mentally drained and could not see the path that

Rohit envisioned for him. "To be honest, I didn't believe him at that time. Sorry. He might have spoken from his heart or from his experience, but that day I wasn't able to see what he was seeing," Samson told JioStar.

Cummins, Hazlewood, Lyon return for Tests

Australia have named a full-strength Test side for the first time in a year after captain Pat Cummins, along with Josh Hazlewood and Nathan Lyon, were all named in the 13-strong squad for the two-game

series against Bangladesh. This will be Bangladesh's first Test tour of Australia since 2003 with the first match scheduled to take place August 13-17, Marrara Stadium Darwin, followed by the second from August 22-26 at Mackay.

BETHELL RULED OUT OF THE HUNDRED

England all-rounder Jacob Bethell has been ruled out of this year's The Hundred with a right knee injury, casting doubt over his availability for next month's Test series against Pakistan and depriving the rising star of a valuable opportunity to captain Birmingham

Phoenix. Bethell suffered the injury during England's recent ODI series win over India and withdrew from the tournament after an MRI scan on Monday morning. The ECB has not shared a timeline for his recovery. England's opening Test against Pakistan at Headingley is set to start on August 19.

FP SCHOOL EDITOR: AMRISH HERDENIA

FP SCHOOL is a publication for and of school students. Principals, teachers, parents and students are welcome to send news and pictures of functions held at schools, students who have excelled in different fields and stories, poems etc penned by students for publication to: freepressschool@gmail.com



CHILDREN DANCE TO WELCOME MONSOON

Podar School, Indore, organised Monsoon Magic, a programme inspired by the hope of welcoming the monsoon through music and dance. Drawing on the popular refrain "Megha Re Megha Re", the event reflected children's anticipation of the rainy season.



Hope beyond horizons

The India of my dreams is a country where every citizen, regardless of background, enjoys equal opportunities to learn, grow, and succeed. It is a nation of harmony and unity, where differences in religion, language, or region do not divide people but instead enrich the social fabric.

ANAY SURYAWANSHI

Class 2 - B

Advanced Academy, Nipania, Indore



Building healthy digital habits

SICA-54 School Balvatika, Indore, organised an awareness session on healthy digital habits for pre-primary students to promote responsible use of digital devices. AI engineer Vishal Yadav addressed the children and explained the effects of excessive mobile phone use. Through a presentation, he said prolonged screen time could affect eyesight, health and concentration. Yadav encouraged students to limit their use of mobile phones, spend more time playing outdoor games and maintain a balanced daily routine.



IMPERIUM IN SESSION: Students puts ideas to vote



Choithram School North Campus, Indore, hosted CNMUN, a three-day Model United Nations conference centred on the theme Imperium of Minds, presenting leadership as the outcome of ideas, dialogue, innovation and informed decision-making.

The conference brought together around 790 students from Classes VII to XII representing institutions under the Choithram Education

Society Unit, including Choithram School North Campus, Choithram School Manik Bagh, Choithram International, Tirathbai Kalachand School and Choithram School Nipania.

The event was inaugurated by Irene Chhabra, an alumna of Choithram School North Campus. Addressing the gathering, Irene Chhabra said the conference provided students with an opportunity to engage in informed discussions and understand the value of dialogue in addressing contemporary issues.

The conference was organised under the gui-

dance of Rita Gupta, head of the department of social science. It featured 16 committees, including UNCSW, UNODC, WHO, UNEP, UNESCO, WTO, UNGA DISEC, UNGA SOCHUM, SPECPOL, ECOFIN, UNHRC, Lok Sabha, Rajya Sabha and AIPPM. Alumni of Choithram School North Campus served as committee chairs and designed crisis simulations to recreate the workings of international diplomacy.

Representing countries and political bodies, delegates researched, debated, negotiated and drafted resolutions on issues

including women's safety, climate change, global health, human rights, international security, the Uniform Civil Code, foreign contribution regulations and the strategic disinvestment of public sector enterprises.

"The conference helped participants develop communication, leadership, critical thinking, negotiation and collaboration skills while improving their understanding of democratic institutions and international governance," school principal Amit Trivedi said. He added that the discussions encouraged students to examine global chal-

lenges from multiple perspectives and work towards practical resolutions.

The conference concluded with a felicitation ceremony recognising delegates across all committees. Awards were presented in the categories of Verbal Mention, Special Mention, High Recommendation and Best Delegate.

Trivedi felicitated the Best Committee of the Conference and congratulated the award recipients. He said their participation reflected commitment to research, discussion and collaborative problem-solving.

